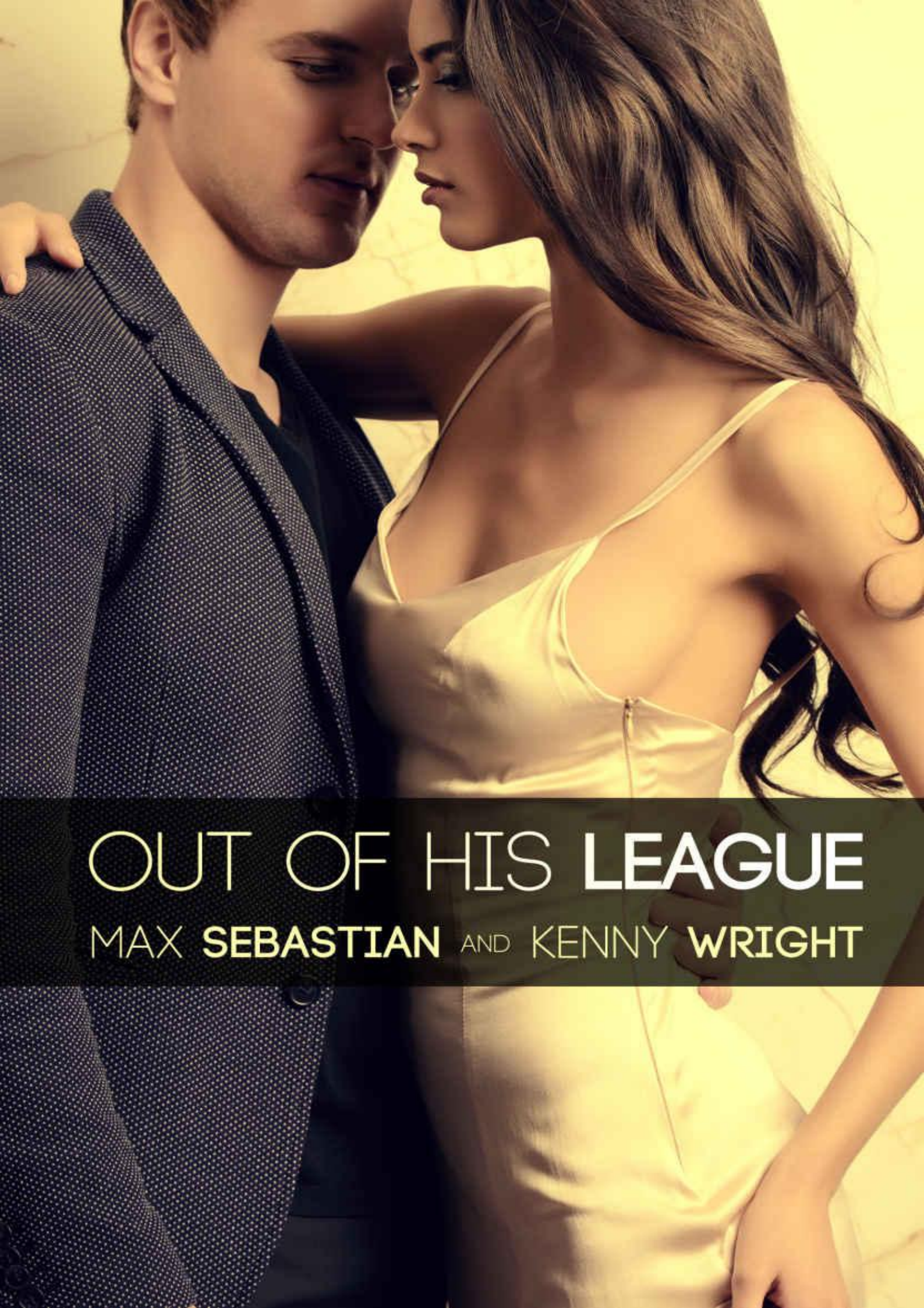




OUT OF HIS LEAGUE

MAX **SEBASTIAN** AND KENNY **WRIGHT**

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Foreword by Kenny Wright

I wrote the first chapter of this book a long time ago. It's not a terribly original idea. In fact, one could say it's a core theme in the world of hotwifing—man is insecure because he's got an attractive wife, and as a defense mechanism, that insecurity breeds this fantasy. I just turned up the volume a little.

Trouble was, I didn't know where to go next. I didn't even know what kind of story I wanted to write. I tried a few things, but I couldn't see a thread emerge that I was interested in following.

Fast forward a couple years. Max and I were talking about a collaboration, kicking around a few ideas. We'd never done one, but I've always thought our styles would work well together. I pulled this one out of the filing cabinet (virtual, via Google Docs, let's not get the wrong idea about me!), dusted it off, and sent it on over to Max. He did what he does so well, and like that, the book you hold in your hands was borne.

It's not the book that would have grown out of the chapter if I'd done it myself. It's a stronger, more nuanced one. It went places that I didn't expect, and I think Max and I surprised ourselves at how neatly it wrapped up in the end. As always, it's a pleasure to work with someone of Max Sebastian's calibre, and I look forward to doing it again!

Kenny Wright

January 13, 2017

Out of His League

By Max Sebastian
&
Kenny Wright

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Chapter 1

I remember the first time I met him. You don't forget a thing like that—not a moment, not a single damn detail—although at the time I didn't know that everything was about to change. It was late afternoon in late summer, and I was picking Courtney up from work.

Thinking back on it now, I can still remember the smell of that waiting room—an odd mixture of disinfectant and magazines. I remember how crowded it had been, the silence punctuated by a cough or the creak of someone's chair as they each waited to be called. I remember thinking that there was no way she'd be getting to everyone by five.

The door that led into the patients' rooms opened and a large football player of a man stepped out, grinning. He wore his arm in a sling, but didn't seem bothered by it.

"You were right, man," he said to the guy sitting beside me. The big man drew closer, his smile going even wider. "She's totally hot."

I shifted in my chair, my stomach starting to squirm. My ears felt kissed by fire.

The guy beside me said, "There's a reason she's recommended so highly, and it's not just because she's the best sports doc around."

The guys shared a high-five handshake, the kind that always made me think of arm wrestling. "Take care, brotha. See you 'round."

When the big guy left, I chanced a look around the room. The two hadn't been quiet, and I spotted more than a few smiles on the faces of the waiting patients. My stomach squirmed even more. I tasted the bite of jealousy, the hopelessness of insecurity, and, as always, the dizziness of arousal. After four years of marriage, and three years dating prior to that, I would have thought I'd get past this. Not so.

The guy beside me—good looking in a stocky way—chuckled when he saw me looking his way. "First time here?" he asked.

"Nah," I said.

"So you know what I'm talking about."

I did, but I played dumb. "Dr. Haute?"

"Yeah, Dr. *Hot*," he said with a laugh, mispronouncing my last name on purpose.

I'd been here before, in the awkward situation where guys drooled over my wife when they didn't realize I was her husband. Sometimes I clued them in, but most of the time I just felt embarrassed—for them, for me, for Courtney. Guys like this were pretty harmless. They had no chance—not back when Courtney was single, and certainly not now. They were all bluster, and Courtney didn't tolerate cocky bullshit. Being as beautiful as she was, she'd developed a toolkit for dealing with them. They still made me squirm, though, but they were nothing like the quieter guys—the ones who made their attraction known with furtive glances and secret smiles. Those guys made me feel like drowning.

The door that the big guy had emerged from opened again, and there she was. I looked up at her, seeing her as everyone else in the waiting room did—as Dr. Hot.

There's no way to say this without overstating it, but Courtney was beautiful. Like, head-turning, jaw-droppingly beautiful. With her paper white—lightly freckled—skin, her dark hair, light blue eyes, and the soft, symmetrical lines of her face, she could have graced the covers of fashion magazines if she'd wanted to. Her mother had, back when she was young, and yet Courtney puts her mother to shame. Even standing up there, her sable hair in a messy bun, a white coat over a slim, blue dress, a stethoscope draped around her neck, my wife commanded everyone's attention.

I quickly glanced around to confirm. There were the open stares and the furtive looks, making me all queasy inside.

Courtney spotted me, her face lighting up in a smile that faded just as quickly. She crossed the room, her brow already crumpled in apology, and tucked a strand of hair that had escaped her bun back behind her ear. "I'm sorry, John, but I'm going to be a little late."

I felt the eyes of the guy beside me stare in wonder. I could practically hear his thoughts: *you're married to Dr. Hot? No fucking way!*

I did my best to ignore that sensation and answered my wife. "I can see that. Want me to come back and get you?"

I stood. She shook her head. "Don't worry about it. I can take a cab."

"You know how long? I can always postpone," I said. I felt like I was on a stage with every man watching.

She said, "No, don't do that. Go, have some fun with Charlie. I'll join you when I can."

"Will do."

We kissed—a soft, familiar, and public kiss. If she felt at all self-conscious about our audience, she didn't show it. My guess was that she barely even noticed them.

"See you later," she said.

I was almost at the door when I heard her call the next guy from her clipboard. "Henry Richards."

"It's *Harry*, actually." I could hear the smile in his reply—the familiarity. It was enough that I turned to look back at him just as I exited.

He looked about our age—around thirty—although there were flecks of gray in his shortly buzzed hair. With his clean shaven face, if this guy wasn't military now, then he probably was a month ago. But it was the way Courtney looked at him, surprise plain on her face, that haunted me as I made my way out to Urbana. She knew him, hadn't seen him in a long time, and was happy to see him now.

The door shut, but I could still see them through the glass panes. He rose to his tall, strapping height, and they met in the middle of the room, sharing a hug. He winced, grabbing his shoulder. They spoke, then moved toward the back, toward the privacy of those small patient rooms.

I left.

Okay, so I've got a jealous side. It's a byproduct of being married to someone that everyone else has the hots for. I'd learned to deal with it over the years, but it still reared its ugly head from time to time. It definitely hit me head-on as I left her office and got into my car. Who was Harry Richards? Courtney had never mentioned a Harry Richards, although I suppose that didn't mean much. She'd had a whole life before she met me, and Courtney was the outgoing type who had plenty of friends.

Or were they more than friends? I considered Harry's lean body and broad shoulders. He was tall, I recalled, standing almost a head above Courtney, who is already a tall woman. She liked that, I knew. Liked that enough to date at one point?

The jealousy twisted me up inside, tangling with something even more disturbing: arousal. My pulse quickened. I felt heat build beneath my collar and crawl up my neck as I considered the past, as I saw in my mind Courtney and Harry—

"No," I said aloud. "Don't."

I looked around. I'd arrived at Urbana on auto-pilot, and occupied my thoughts the next few minutes searching for a spot to park on the street.

We were supposed to be meeting a friend of ours, Charlie, who'd recently started a new job. As always, Charlie wanted to downplay it, but I convinced him to meet me for drinks with a couple other friends.

I found a spot a couple blocks away, then found Charlie staking out a table on the sidewalk patio, a drink already in front of him.

He stood as he saw me approaching, opening his arms wide for a big bear hug. And that's exactly what it was. Charlie wasn't a small guy, and when he gave out hugs, they were all consuming. "Where's the wife?" he asked. "Don't tell me, she finally wised up and realized she married beneath her?"

"Don't, man," I said, harsher than I'd intended. "Not tonight."

Charlie grew serious. "Something happen? You want to talk?"

I glanced at my friend, who regarded me with concern. We'd met years ago when he was my shrink and I was dealing with my early insecurities around dating Courtney. He'd helped me through that time, helped me realize that it was more about me than her. Mostly I understood that, but I also became better at hiding it.

"No, nothing happened." Nothing had. I was being silly. "Just... long day. Courtney's going to be a little late. She's still got a room full of patients waiting."

Charlie would normally make some joke about guys lining up for her, but sensing my mood, he held his tongue. "That's too bad. Well, we'll have to drink for her, eh? Liz is on her way, too."

"Cool."

So we drank. We ordered appetizers. We talked about his new job overseeing the mental health of returning vets. And I thought about where Courtney was now, what she was doing. I thought about her disappearing into the back with... Harry. About the way she'd smiled at him. About how easy it would have been for the guy to lift her onto an examination table, paper crinkling under them, as their lips mashed and their hands wandered and—

"Buddy?" Charlie broke me out of my downward spiral.

"Sorry. We should probably order some more food. What time is it?" I looked at my phone. Nearly seven and Courtney still wasn't here—and still hadn't called. When I looked up at Charlie, though, he wasn't buying it. I said, "Stop looking at me like that."

"And how do you think I'm looking at you?"

"Like you're my shrink. I stopped paying you years ago."

Charlie looked mournful. "Don't cheapen what we have, Johnny boy. But seriously, what's on your mind?"

Just then, a sleek, black BMW pulled into an open spot on the opposite side of the road. We watched the driver parallel park. When he stepped out from behind the tinted windows, though, my stomach fell. He wore sunglasses, mirrored aviators over his cut jaw, but I knew who he was—Harry, my new nemesis—and I knew who he was with.

Courtney stepped out on the other side of the car. Her white doctor's coat was gone, leaving her in just the blue dress I'd seen beneath. Like everything that Courtney wore, it was sexy in a crisp, refined way. It was tight along her slender form, but reached her knees and buttoned high around her neck. Her arms were bare, slim like the rest of her, toned from good genes and her gym routine.

Her dark hair was loose now, falling in waves around her shoulders. She circled the BMW, her hips telling a flirty story to anyone who was watching. And when Harry put his hand on the small of her back as they crossed the road, Charlie cleared his throat and leaned in.

"Ah," he said. "Now I see what's on your mind."

Chapter 2

I'd like to tell you I'm a very self-assured, confident man. I'd like to tell you I had absolute trust in my wife, even if she was a lot of men's idea of a bedroom fantasy. I'd like to tell you our love was so strong, so complete in every way, that there was no way I could entertain the possibility that she might ever even consider straying from the path our wedding vows directed.

I'd like to tell you I had no reason to be paranoid, to wake up in the middle of the night with my skin clammy and cold, fearing the name of Harry Richards.

"Hey, honey. You're turning into my own personal chauffeur."

"You know how it is... I was in the neighborhood."

The truth is, Courtney is flirty with most men, that's just the way she is. But I'd never seen her like I'd seen her like she was being in the few brief moments I'd seen her with Harry Richards. It terrified me to the core—it wasn't just that I thought he might one day tempt her into something, a little inadvisable moment of physical weakness; the sight of them together had made me feel a total loss of control in my life. She was doing something I wasn't comfortable with, seeing someone I wasn't comfortable with her seeing, and I had no way of doing anything about it. Because really, I had zero right to tell her who she could and could not see. Especially professionally.

"Well I can't say I don't enjoy the company on the way home!"

I started turning up at Courtney's Sports Injury Clinic and Rehab Center a few evenings a week after that brief run-in with Harry Richards. I had the big excuse that the property I was developing at that moment just happened to be a ten minutes drive from her office, but that had happened before and I hadn't suddenly turned into the World's Most Attentive Husband overnight. I'd even go on the days the Center runs a public clinic, opening its doors to whoever was happening by—by which I mean the guys who can't afford the usual exclusive rates. Those days always saw Courtney running particularly late, since she was one of the few partners in the Center who felt the need to see everyone who turned up in her waiting room, rather than closing the doors on poor high school

or college athletes in desperate need. That first time I'd seen her with Harry Richards had been a public clinic day.

"There's a new Italian restaurant over in the Grove District, how about we give it a try?"

"Oooh, I love Italian food..."

I got away with it. She didn't look at me as though I was some kind of stalker. Each time I arrived and her receptionist Shawna either waved me through to her office, Courtney would look up from her desk with delight sparkling in those cool blue eyes, genuinely pleased to see me.

It did settle my nerves, I can tell you. As did attending her office all that time without seeing neither hide nor hair of Harry Richards.

I should have just let it go, taken my anxiety down a notch. Trust is an important thing in a relationship, but you can't keep trying to test it in your partner, you've got to have faith, too. Courtney would have appreciated the occasional drop-in by her darling husband just as much as she did the few days a week I was regularly turning up. Perhaps more so, because it would have been unexpected, special.

But when I'm working on a house, flipping it from a grim mess of uneven floors, fading wallpaper and damp, crumbling walls into a gorgeous temple to modern style and comfort, I spend a lot of time on my own, working away in silence during the periods where I don't have contractors around performing the more specialized work. I have plenty of time to think. And after Harry Richards turned up in my wife's clinic, I had plenty of time to think about every nuance of that particular arrival.

The thing was, if I was just your average jealous husband, I probably would have picked up my wife regularly from work for a little while, and seeing no signs of Harry Richards in her life, I would have eventually just let it go. I mean, it's not as though I had any grounds to hire a private detective to tail her. Yet I was not just your average jealous husband. Sure, the jealousy was there, and the hopeless sense of insecurity. But also, ever present ticking along underneath it all, there was that dizzy arousal, that throbbing excitement—some kind of weird optimism that my wife might actually be thinking about having an affair.

I don't think I could have explained it at the time. As I recognized it in myself—seeing how disappointed I was when I turned up at Courtney's clinic again to find no Harry Richards there with his shoulder in a sling—I was deeply confused about it, even humiliated by how I felt. I was arriving at her office hoping that he'd be in there. Jesus.

I certainly wasn't going to open up to Charlie about it when we met up for beers, or a late summer barbecue in the lavish garden of the latest

house I was finally close to finishing. He dug around for gossip—but even if, as my former shrink, I knew he'd keep details confidential, I wasn't going to reveal my embarrassing secret.

"Courtney still seeing that BMW guy?" he'd ask me, teasing a little, but knowing how much it had clearly affected me.

"He's just an old friend," I'd say, or something similar. "I don't need to worry about that kind of thing."

And then one afternoon Courtney sent me a text message telling me I shouldn't come by her office that evening, that it was another public clinic day and she was expecting to be done especially late. She'd never sent me instructions to keep away from her after work. Sometimes she'd give me an ETA if I expressed interest in collecting her, but she'd never preemptively advised me not to come at all before.

I felt snubbed, unwanted. And working on a brand new house, tearing out an old outdated kitchen, I had some time to myself to turn that feeling of rejection into some kind of conspiracy theory. The best I could come up with was, how did she know she was going to be particularly late? Had there been a flood of injuries from the nearest high school, some football game that had turned nasty?

I did wait until later, when her public clinic days usually ended, but then I went round there anyway. I carried a big cup of her preferred Starbucks coffee, just in case I needed a valid excuse. "Oh, well, honey, I thought you might need a little something to get you to the finish," I'd say, handing it over before fleeing, to show that I wasn't checking up on her or anything, just trying to be helpful on my way home.

God, I really was turning into a stalker.

On this occasion, though, I turned up at the Center to find a very empty parking lot, and Shawna heading out of the front entrance, fastening the last few buttons of her coat as she turned toward her regular parking space.

"Oh, hey John," she said, apparently a little startled I was there.

"Courtney done yet?" I asked with a broad, innocent smile.

"She's just... uh... seeing her final patient of the day," the receptionist said, sounding a touch uncertain for some reason. "Told me to just head home."

"Right," I nodded, acting calm as my runaway paranoia immediately jumped to the conclusion that Courtney's final patient might be one Harry Richards, and my wife might have sent Shawna away for a little private time with him.

“I can wait a little longer if you need me to,” Shawna said, now unfastening her coat buttons again. As though I needed a receptionist to be present if I was going to wait for my wife in the waiting room.

“No, it’s okay. Go home,” I told her. “I can just sit and wait for her to finish, no reason for you to be there.”

“Okay...” Shawna said, not seeming too happy with the plan. “Well... have a good night, John.”

I went in through the automatic doors to find most of the lights in the Center switched off. I really did feel like a stalker as I found a seat in the waiting room outside Courtney’s door. Hiding in the shadows. This really wasn’t healthy, whether I had a big vat of Starbucks sugary coffee on hand for her or not.

Stillness as I waited. Uncomfortable stillness.

I couldn’t hear anything from her office. Again, I had the strangest sense of disappointment, that I couldn’t hear obvious signs of adultery, no matter how faint, emerging from her door. I told myself these were soundproofed rooms, the doctors needed to protect their patients’ privacy.

Fifteen minutes went by. I was starting to get really antsy, really jumpy. I couldn’t sit down any longer, and especially not in the shady parts of the room. I started to be afraid that Courtney would think me creepy, hiding in wait for her, ready to jump out at her from the shadows. In many respects, that was exactly what I was doing.

Another ten minutes went by. The coffee cup in my hands seemed lukewarm at best by now. I could hardly barge into her office and present it to her now, while a few more minutes would make this completely undrinkable. My excuse for being there had become unconvincing. I wouldn’t be able to say I’d simply dropped by, it would be obvious I’d been waiting a while, deliberately going against her wishes by being there.

Discomfort soon turned to nerves, and nerves soon turned to outright fear. What would I say if she came out with Harry Richards? Perhaps laughing and blushing and glowing with perspiration, her usual smart appearance slightly disheveled, her crisp dress creased and rumpled. Uh... no, honey, I’m not checking up on you. And anyway, what’s been going on with this new patient of yours?

I dropped the coffee cup, full and untouched, into the trash by Shawna’s reception desk, and walked out of there. I was a mass of conflicted feelings. I was shaking with anxiety yet burbling with bizarre, perverted hope.

I found my battered old Volvo and swung into the driver's seat, fired up the old but comforting engine. Cranked it into Drive and stepped on the accelerator.

I felt so stupid, told myself there wasn't anything to worry about—there never had been. I was just a ridiculous, stupid man, who distrusted his wife because she was gorgeous and other men desired her, when I really had no cause whatsoever to do so.

Then on the way out of the parking lot I drove past a sleek, black BMW that seemed hauntingly familiar.

I didn't stop. I couldn't turn around. I continued on toward home feeling physically sick, cold, and yet more turned on than I could remember, a huge erection lurking there in my pants.

Jesus.

Chapter 3

This wasn't paranoia, I told myself. Again and again, I focused on that thought, even as I fought to breathe, even as I began to hyperventilate on the way home. This wasn't like Jason. This wasn't all in my head. I *knew* that I hadn't imagined it. I'd known since the first day I met Harry.

The sleek, black BMW pulled into an open spot on the opposite side of the road, and out stepped Harry and Courtney. Harry put his hand on the small of Courtney's back and led her across the road, to where Charlie and I were sitting, waiting. Watching.

It was that hand on her back that clued me in. They didn't just know each other from before, they'd been intimate. Worse, Harry hadn't seemed embarrassed when Courtney introduced me as her husband. He did drop his hand from her back, only to hold it out and squeeze mine in a numbingly hard shake.

"Harry," he said. "Nice to meet you, Josh." Even his voice, deep and resonant, was annoyingly masculine.

"It's John," I corrected. How could he mess up as simple a name as John? "And this is our friend, Charlie."

We'd exchanged pleasantries. Courtney had explained that they knew one another from college, but had said no more. I knew better than to dig, even after we'd finished our drinks and had all gone our separate ways, even when it was just the two of us, alone in our apartment. We'd been down that road before, years before, when we were just dating, with a guy named Jason, and it had nearly ended us.

"But this isn't in your head, man," I said aloud as I pulled into the basement garage of our apartment complex. I sat there for the longest time, engine running, wondering what the hell I should do.

I pulled out my phone, turning it over and over.

I could call Charlie and talk. That would be the most sensible thing, even though he'd pick my brain apart and would get me to second guess everything.

I could call Courtney. That was the most confrontational, although it also sent a jolt through me as I imagined her answering her phone, out of breath, as Harry plowed into her from behind, his hand splayed across her taut ass.

I could text her, which was the more passive aggressive way to handle this whole mess.

Or I could do nothing.

For now, I did nothing. I put my phone away, took a deep and hearty breath, adjusted my erection so it wasn't painfully pressed against my trousers, and got out of the car.

I managed to make it up to our apartment before breaking down again. I pulled my phone out, composed a text, then stared at it without pressing send.

[Me]: Just got home. Should I order a pizza or something?

I read it over and over, trying to discern whether there was any way to read into it. Of course there wasn't, but I hesitated hitting send anyway. I knew I'd read a lot into her response, and the amount of time it would take for her to send it.

I dithered for nearly a minute before hitting send, then sat on the sofa and stared at the screen, waiting for her response. When she didn't immediately start typing, my chest clenched.

"Okay, there's plenty of reasons why she didn't immediately respond," I told myself. If she'd been seeing a patient, she wouldn't have been able to respond right away. She kept her phone in her office, so she might not even see it until it was time to leave.

Or she could be in one of the patient rooms, splayed out over an examination table as Harry rocked into her naked body. I could hear the crinkle of the examination paper beneath her. My stomach dropped.

I stared at my phone until I couldn't stand it anymore, then darkened the screen and tossed it onto the kitchen counter. My heart drummed against my chest. She wasn't going to respond, there were a lot of rational reasons why not, but I wasn't going to think of any reason but the most sordid.

And it left me hard. So very, painfully hard. I needed to pee, but could barely do it with my erection. I contemplated cooking, but after standing in front of the refrigerator for a solid minute, cool air belching out around me, I gave up trying. I grabbed my phone—still with no messages on it—and ordered a pizza.

Waiting was going to be no good for me. I could already feel myself spiraling into a very dark place. I had to talk to someone, so at last, I picked up the phone and called the only person I could trust about this.

"John, what's up?" Charlie said, sounding concerned.

"Um, why are you asking like that?"

“Well, first of all, it’s a Friday night and you’re *calling* me, rather than texting. Also, you’ve been kind of MIA these last few weeks, which I would normally think had to do with that new house you’re working on, except that I also know about the BMW guy—”

“Yeah, it’s that,” I interrupted, cursing myself for calling a shrink. “I need to talk about...him.”

“Just him?”

I could almost imagine Charlie looking at me over his glasses as he scratched something into a notepad.

“She’s with him. Right now, she’s with him.” Saying it out loud took my breath away.

“Okay, that doesn’t sound good. How do you know?”

“I kind of...followed her. To her office.”

I gave him a short version of the past few hours: the text not to pick her up, the empty parking lot, Shawna’s nervousness, the waiting, and the BMW parked outside. Charlie listened quietly, turning it over and over in his head, analyzing, breaking it down, coming up with the most infuriating and frustrating reason for all of this.

“I texted her about a half hour ago or so. Maybe twenty minutes. She hasn’t responded,” I finished out-of-breath.

He didn’t speak immediately—long enough that I almost asked him if he was still there. Then, he said, “John, why didn’t you go into the back and tell her that you were there?”

I rubbed my forehead in frustration. This was exactly why I shouldn’t have called him in the first place. “Because she asked me not to get her.”

“You’re upset,” Charlie said.

“Of course I am. My wife’s cheating on me.”

“You don’t know that for sure. This guy is a patient, right?”

“A patient who needs more than an hour of personal attention? Doesn’t that sound suspicious to you?” I heard my voice rising, but didn’t bother stopping it.

“Why haven’t you called her?”

“Why haven’t I...?” Charlie, whose side are you on?”

“I’m sorry, John. Yours, of course.” Some of the cold logic thawed in his voice. “I’m just hoping that I don’t have to take a side here.”

“But she’s—”

“Yes, maybe she is.” Thud, a blow to my stomach. I took a hard seat on the ground as his confirmation—as hypothetical as it was—worked its

way through me. “But maybe she’s not. And the question you need to ask yourself is this: do you really want to know?”

“How could you even ask that, man? Of course I do.”

“So why didn’t you go into those back rooms? Have you called her directly?”

“I texted,” I said, realizing how thin it sounded.

“Right. This is Jason all over again. We’ve been down this road.”

“But Jason turned out to be a mistake. On my part. I was a total idiot. This time, there’s so much more evidence—”

“Sure, but that’s not what I’m talking about.”

I groaned. “Stop talking to me like a shrink! Talk to me as a friend. *Please.*”

Charlie sighed. “Okay, I’ll lay it out for you plainly. When you confronted Courtney about your suspicion that she was cheating on you with Jason, and she not only denied it, but proved that she wasn’t, how did you feel?”

“Relieved. Embarrassed. Stupid.” And I felt all of those things, but I knew the real confession he wanted from me. I’d felt disappointed.

“That all?”

“What are you implying?”

“Look, I’m your friend. Maybe your best friend, if grown men still have those. So please don’t take this the wrong way, okay? But have you ever considered the possibility that maybe you *wanted* her to cheat?”

“That’s insane,” I said, too fast, too defensively. I knew it was a lie as soon as it left my lips. “I don’t. I *don’t*.”

Charlie was quiet for an uncomfortable amount of time. “I’m sorry I suggested it, then. But...but before you confront her again, I’d suggest that maybe you wait. At least until you’re certain. The last time you accused her, she almost left you, if I remember.”

Those had been dark times. “Thanks for talking, Charlie.”

“Always. Hey, John, let’s get together sometime, okay? It’s been too long.”

“Sounds good.”

I hung up without saying goodbye.

When I checked my phone, I saw that I had a text from Courtney that must have come in while we’d been talking.

[Courtney]: Sorry, just saw this. On the way home now.

Just saw this, still sweaty from the last hour of sex she’d been having with another man. I imagined Courtney holding her phone before her, standing naked with Harry Richards behind her, his fingers stroking

her hip. *Don't worry, I'll take care of this*, she'd say over her shoulder. *Maybe we have time for one more round?*

When I didn't pick her up, Courtney rode her bike to the office. It wasn't far, and because she could thread through traffic, it would only take her about fifteen minutes.

Of course, she could also get dropped off by Harry, which would probably take about the same amount of time, but mean more time they could spend together—

Stop. I paced over to the window, wondering why thoughts like that turned me on, even if they made me so jealous—why the thought of Courtney leaning over as Harry drove her home, unzipping his pants, and sucking his dick as he worked through traffic left me hard and breathless. She didn't do that kind of thing in real life. Ever. That wasn't the kind of woman Courtney was.

Have you ever considered the possibility that you wanted her to cheat? Charlie's suggestion was preposterous. Of course I didn't want her to cheat on me. I loved her, loved the life that we had. The thought of living a life without her was a devastating one. She was so much better than me, smarter, more successful, a hell of a lot more attractive. Why would I ever want to lose that?

Movement caught my eye. A figure on a bicycle, dressed in a pink, short-sleeved bike jersey and black cycling shorts, gracefully cutting along the street, turning into the parking garage. Courtney was home.

The pressure I felt in those next five minutes, waiting for her to lock her bike up and take the elevators, was unreal. Like I was swimming to the bottom at the deep end of the pool. My ears popped. My chest caved. I couldn't breathe. I could barely stand.

And then the door opened and everything cleared again. There stood Courtney, posing in the doorway like a superhero in her cycling getup, her helmet balanced on her hip.

"Hey, welcome home," I said. "I ordered pizza."

"Thanks for taking care of that. I...I'm sorry I'm late." She sounded strange, hesitant in a way that wasn't her normal self. In a guilty way?

I felt numb. Numb, yet also hyper aware of how turned on I was, like I was floating behind myself, a scientist making the observation more than me myself. "Hey," I heard myself say, "it's just after 7. That's when a lot of people are just getting off."

"Yeah." She nodded, although she didn't seem to accept my excuse for her. There was something distant with her, and that distance

frightened me. She seemed to be searching for something, the courage to speak, to confess, to tell me something that would change us forever.

I stepped up to her before she could find whatever it was she was looking for. She blinked, seemingly startled to see me so close. Even in her bike shoes, she was practically as tall as me. I ran my hand down her arm, and she turned to watch my fingers leave a trail of goosebumps on her skin.

I leaned in and kissed her neck. She smelled like sweat and... what? Cologne? Was that the musk of another man? I scanned her skin for hickeys, marks, but there was nothing out of the ordinary.

“John...” She began. A confession. A question?

I didn’t let her finish that thought. Instead, I kissed her, pushing my tongue past her lips before she would say something that we’d both regret. I cupped her butt, toned and tight beneath her bike shorts. For a moment, she lost herself in the kiss. Her hand clutched at my shirt, the other working up the back of my neck.

Abruptly, she pulled back. “John, wait...”

The fear was there in her wide, blue eyes, rich with it, thick and scary. I tried to kiss her again, but she pulled away as she worked her nerves up.

“Courtney...” I started. *Courtney what? I know? I don’t want to know? It turns me on?*

We both jumped at the hard rapping at the door. The spell broke. She slinked out of my arms, and all of a sudden I wanted to melt into a pool on the floor. Instead, I stiffened my spine and went to answer the door.

“That would be our pizza. Why don’t you hop in the shower,” I said. “I’ll set the table.”

Why was I giving her a reason to wash away the evidence of what she’d done?

The knocking came again. I smiled at her, gestured to the bathroom, and turned away. By the time I opened the door for the pizza guy, the shower had cut on.

Dinner was an exercise in doing everything *but* talking about her day. I don’t know why, but I wasn’t ready for that confrontation. I was still sorting myself out, which in hindsight wasn’t fair to Courtney, who had her own guilt and demons to battle. We talked about the house I was flipping and some of the problems that came with that. We talked about the crazy election and how wild it was. We talked about television shows that we wanted to watch but didn’t seem to have time to.

The pizza came and went without incident, and with each passing minute, that fear and the weight of anticipation lightened. The hesitancy waned with Courtney. Wine with dinner helped some—certainly helped me—and I noticed Courtney refilling her glass more than normal.

“Hey, I was thinking we should go away some time soon,” I said. “Maybe this fall.”

Like that, the pain was back, the conflict somehow making my wife look more attractive. But rather than start with a *John-we-need-to-talk* opening, she just asked, “You have somewhere in mind?”

“I was thinking somewhere where I get to see you in a bikini.” Me and every other guy on the beach.

She laughed...sadly? “We don’t need to spend a bunch of money if that’s all you want.” There was a forced lightness in her tease. Or maybe it was just me thinking it was forced.

“Maybe I’m just looking for an excuse for you to get a bikini wax.”

Courtney covered her mouth and laughed—this time full and hearty. I blushed, smiling along with her. “John, you know we don’t have to go somewhere for that, either.”

“Really?” I’d suggested from time to time that she do that, but only as a joke. And she’d never taken me up on it.

Courtney shrugged. “Sure, why not? Vive La Difference, huh?”

Was it her guilt prompting this? Or something else? Something involving Harry and his own preferences? All of this talk had me hard, and I wanted to finish what we’d started before the pizza guy had arrived.

I leaned across the table and kissed her. Unlike when we’d first kissed, there wasn’t any hesitancy. She returned it, warm and familiar, her smile stretched across her face. Pulling back, I said, “I love you, baby. You’re too good for me.”

I don’t know why I do things like that. Just when we’d moved—temporarily at least—beyond the elephant in the room, I poke at it. Courtney’s face fell and her confession once again began to surface. More confirmation that something *had* happened. More gasoline on the fire.

Before she could go too far down the road, I stood and pulled her to her feet. “Come on,” I said. “Let me show you how much I appreciate you.”

“Ohhh, ohh, John! John!” Courtney thrashed on the bed as I stroked two fingers into her trim pussy and danced my tongue across her clit. Her cries drove me, helping me ignore the ache in my tongue and jaw and work her harder, faster. “Yes, baby, eat me. Eat me!”

Courtney knew I liked it when she talked dirty, but rarely did. Unless she was really into the sex. Tonight, she was either really into the sex, or she was trying to relieve some of her guilt by pretending that she was. That second thought inflamed me more than her cries. If she was pretending now, she wouldn’t be in the end.

I curved my fingers up, seeking out her g-spot as I latched my entire mouth over her sex. Sucking ever-so-slightly, I swirled my tongue around her clitoris until the cramp was too painful to ignore. It was enough. Courtney clamped her thighs around my head and arched her body back, her pussy tightening around my driving fingers.

“Uhhhh!” she groaned, raw, guttural, muffled. I kept eating her, kept fingering her, spurring her on.

“John. John!” she cried, her ecstasy becoming too much. She pulled away, shuddering. I licked her one last time before pulling back.

I ran a hand through my hair, damp with sweat, and wiped my face. Courtney was coated in a sheen of her own sweat, her lean, unreal body stretched out before me—a sight I’d seen countless times, but because of my curse, could never take for granted. Now, as always, I saw her through the eyes of another man—Harry Richards tonight, but countless others in the past—and it triggered this primal instinct in me.

My fingers danced over her pale skin, following my groping eyes across her dark, trimmed bush, across her flat stomach and narrow waist, across her breasts that looked so much fuller naked than when she was clothed. Had Harry discovered that pleasant surprise tonight? Or had he just bent her over her desk and taken her from behind?

I rolled over her still panting body, her eyes still closed, to kiss her lips. She was too limp to return it at first, although I felt her smile.

“I love you,” I whispered. I drew back enough so that I could watch her face as I guided my cock into her. Her gasp wiped her smile away, silent at first, the moan spilling out on a lag. I caressed her face, her high cheekbones, her slender nose. I kissed her eyes, her forehead, her temples.

“You feel...so big,” she sighed.

Was that another attempt to stroke my ego and ease her guilt? I entered her slowly, balancing on the knife-edge of my own orgasm. I was back in the waiting room as the minutes ticked by and Courtney and Harry were somewhere in the back, all alone, and knowing that they were. I thought of the coffee cup I'd dropped in the trash by the front desk, and Harry's black BMW outside in the parking lot.

"Ah, John... Seriously, you feel huge," Courtney said once I'd finally buried it all the way to the root.

Have you ever considered the possibility that you wanted her to cheat?

Haven't just considered, have you, John?

"I..." I couldn't tell her that. I didn't want this. "Maybe I'm just thinking about that Brazilian bikini wax."

Humor had always been my escape lever, and I pulled it heartily here. Courtney laughed softly beneath me. "So it's a Brazilian bikini wax now, is it?"

This was easier to talk about than my uncomfortable and confusing desires. "Don't tell me that's a surprise to you," I said, beginning to stroke myself in and out of her.

"No, I guess it's not," she admitted. Our eyes met, and even in the dark, I saw how heartfelt she looked. "So you want to see me like a little girl?"

"Trust me, that's never going to be a problem." I squeezed her breast as I thrust into her again. "But seriously, I was just kidding. You don't have to do that for me."

"I know, but I want to," she said. *For someone else?* Her eyes widened. "I felt that," she said. "If it keeps getting that kind of reaction, I *definitely* want to."

"I'll make it worth your while." I began to thrust faster, although the image I held wasn't that of Courtney and her promise of a bare pussy, but of how Harry would react to it. Would he see? Would he make it worth her while, too? Would he get just as excited?

"Uh, John," my wife moaned. "Fuck me. Fuck me and think about how smooth I'll be."

"Oh, Court!"

"Oh, John!"

The bed creaked with my thrusts. My arms burned as I held myself over her, driving my hips in, in, hard and harder. I stared down at her, where she sighed and moaned, her eyes shut, her mind on...Harry? She bit her lip, her brow falling, her orgasm rising.

Ever considered the possibility that you want her to cheat on me?
Yes, I had. Yes, maybe, just maybe, I wanted that.

I exploded deep inside of my wife. Was I the second man to do that tonight? I...I guess I hoped that I was.

Chapter 4

Sex has a hugely reassuring effect on a man. A guy can have all the stresses and strains in the world whirling around his head, but a seriously good bout between the sheets and he'll just roll over and drift off into a dreamless sleep.

For me, the effects of a night with Courtney lingered on into the morning, leaving me waking with an enormous feeling of contentment and goodwill. Even my paranoia levels had fallen away to near zero.

I guess those little cells of mine, ticking away inside, feel all the sex hormones floating around and just cannot reconcile any negativity with the vibrant memory of my beautiful wife moaning as she lay under me, begging me to fuck her, crying out my name.

Promising to wax her bikini line, just for my own titillation.

Over breakfast, she was all smiles and breezy cheer, and I was all smiles and bouncy elation, both of us seeming as though we were in some drug-induced haze of self-fulfillment as we went through the usual conversations over cereal and bagels.

"I saw a really nice bag on the J.Crew website—it'll be just perfect for Mom's birthday."

"Sounds good. You can never have enough nice bags, huh?"

"That's right. You and Charlie have all those football jerseys. Mom and I like nice bags. Oh, I have a board meeting on Thursday."

"Sure, honey."

"So no lurking round our waiting room hoping to pick me up, right?"

When she said that, I flushed deep red, and turned away from her to hide my reaction. I knew—or at least, I assumed—she wasn't actually referring to my drop-by the previous night. I felt certain she couldn't possibly have known I was there, that I'd left before offering her a lift home, that I'd seen a vehicle in the parking lot that belonged to one Harry Richards.

Had Shawna tipped her off to my presence?

Yet Courtney wasn't asking me what I was thinking going over there when she'd asked me not to that night. Or why I'd gone there and left without talking to her. She wasn't explaining why that Harry

Richards guy had been there with her, alone, when she'd suggested she'd be late because she had another busy public clinic day.

I had to work on this paranoia.

"I don't lurk," I insisted. "I just like helping you out from time to time."

"Yes, sweetie, and it's much appreciated." She kissed me as she went by to drop her plate and glass into the dishwasher before disappearing upstairs to finish up getting ready for work. And she sounded completely innocent, completely relaxed and unfazed by my recent stalker-like dedication to her homeward transport.

Maybe I should relax, maybe there really wasn't anything untoward going on with her.

I went off to work on my development, and her smell was still all over me. It just brought to mind constant reminders of Courtney in bed—every time I'd breathe in and detect her scent, little details of our previous night's sex would crystalize in my head. The image of her arching her back as I touched her. Shuddering under me as I slid my fingers inside her. Thrashing about and telling me urgently to eat her.

All morning I had those sweet memories to get me through, my efforts to knock down a wall between the kitchen and the living/dining room accompanied by a fairly persistent hard-on, though at least it meant the time flew by.

Later, after my usual plumbing expert, Todd, came to take a look at the surprise pipe my wall demo had exposed, my afternoon stretched out and I found myself starting to remember how Courtney had been before we'd wound up in bed, putting all our worries out of mind.

She'd been on the verge of some kind of confession, hadn't she? Something had been on her mind, and when I'd started kissing her, she'd seemed guilty, she'd been about to tell me something...something difficult.

I'd been too afraid of her coming right out and admitting to an indiscretion. I'd distracted her, kissed her so she couldn't say anything at all. Then later, after dinner, I'd told her I loved her, that she was too good for me. That had almost prompted her to confess, too.

That afternoon, I started feeling regret that I hadn't allowed her to come out and share whatever was on her mind. Would she really have opened up about what had happened with Harry Richards?

At the time, I was terrified it would mean our marriage ending. Either because she'd tell me she no longer wanted me, that she had Harry now, and he was more attractive, more affluent than I was, that he could

provide everything she needed in life—or because I'd blurt out some jealous order for her to get out of our apartment, to leave me, to never come back.

She'd made love to me, though, and it had honestly felt like I had nothing to worry about in the world.

And now, as I worked on that house almost on autopilot, I started pondering what I ought to have said to her, and what I might have said if she had confessed to something happening with Harry Richards.

As the hours ticked by, more and more I found myself imagining telling her, "It's okay... I don't mind... you can have a little fun with him if you like... as long as you come back to me afterward... as long as you still want me..."

I went through a strange process—I guess you could say I was coming to terms with my own sexual kink. Something had flipped inside my brain like a switch being turned on. After that, I could admit to myself that, yes, the thought of my Courtney being tempted off the true path of marital monogamy did turn me on.

The thought of my beautiful wife being unfaithful... it did make me hard like nothing I'd ever experienced. And I was married to a woman so far out of my league that my friends had congratulated me when she'd accepted my offer of a date, when she'd accepted my offer of marriage, when she'd said "I do" on a beach in Hawaii, as though I'd done something wholly unexpected that completely defied the odds, like winning the lottery. Sleeping with Courtney had always been the most incredible experience in the world. How could it turn me on more to think of her now sleeping with someone else?

I wasn't sure about the details. I had no idea why or how I felt this way. But I could at least be honest with myself and admit that, sure, I just happened to like the idea of my Courtney sneaking away to jump into bed with another man, to enjoy the temptations of strange cock, to indulge in the adoration of someone who was, perhaps, more in her league.

Someone like Harry Richards.

I came to terms with my strange urge—that's not to say it didn't still terrify me. I still quivered from the thought of losing my wife, to Harry Richards, to some other guy more worthy of her. Whoever. It's just that I no longer sought to deny to myself that the whole bizarre bundle of risk and reward was the biggest turn-on ever.

I could go home and hope that she was being kept late in the office by another evening appointment with my new rival, and not feel

disgusted with myself, not feel shame.

Oh, it helped that I did a little online research. I asked Google about men who want their wives to sleep around. It wasn't so uncommon. There were even biological explanations for it.

I even found myself thinking about talking it all over with Charlie. Well, he was my friend, but also my shrink. I'd shared so many embarrassing secrets and personal truths with him, what would be the point of hiding this one?

Those few days that I'd collect Courtney from her Medical Center on time, there would be no signs of Harry Richards around, or she'd text me to let me know she'd be home before me. I was almost disappointed that nothing was going on.

On the plus side, each night I'd be so horny from a day of thinking about her, and her potential infidelity, I'd sweep her up in my arms and usually devour her even before we had the chance to have dinner together—and increasingly she seemed to see nothing unusual about it. She was as horny as I was. If I didn't sweep her up in my arms, she'd be shoving me against the wall as soon as we got inside the front door of our apartment, to tear open my belt and pull down my pants.

Our sex life had always been good, but it had never quite been twice, three-times-a-night good. After first meeting Harry Richards, it was that good, and it wasn't just me being desperate to sleep with my wife every moment I had with her. She was desperate for sex, too, like she hadn't been since we'd been dating.

"I looked it up," I told Charlie on the phone when he called suggesting a few drinks at a new harbor-side bar one of his clients had just opened up. "It's one of the signs of a cheating spouse. She starts overcompensating because she's sleeping with someone else and she feels guilty..."

Charlie just sighed, of course, that I was still going on about this. He didn't want me and Courtney fighting. He was a friend for both of us, now.

"She loves you, dude," he said. "It's just a sign that she loves you. Maybe work's going well for her right now, her stress levels have dropped. She's more relaxed, more self-confident, so she... wants more sex..."

"She never said anything about work going well, about her stress levels."

"Look, you clearly don't get out enough, John. You're turning into a complete dipshit. You need to come out Thursday night and get

completely trashed...”

“Okay, okay!” I laughed. “I said it already, didn’t I? I’ll come out. I’ll check out your client’s new place...”

“Great.”

“Isn’t it a conflict of interest, you drinking at a client’s establishment?”

“Nope. The conflict of interest is in the fact that he’s given me a free bar tab whenever I want to use it... but you know... who’s gonna report me?”

We laughed. It felt right. I realized how much I needed a drink or two away from my usual solitude as a flipper of houses.

“Seriously, though, dude. You’re a lucky guy. She’s beautiful, and she loves you. It’s only natural that when you’re with a woman like that, you start to doubt yourself, you start to question why she’s with you...”

“Charlie, are you telling me she’s out of my league?” I chuckled.

“Uh... no... that’s not what I...” he mumbled.

But I laughed. “It’s okay. I know she’s out of my league. I’m pretty sure she still really loves me, though.”

“Right. She does.”

“I just think maybe it means that when someone comes along who *is* in her league...”

Charlie laughed now, as though it was a new tactic to stop me from this constant refrain of paranoid delusions of cuckoldry. But then he said, “John—there’s something different about you. Did something happen?”

“Different?” I prompted him.

“You don’t seem so... down. So distressed. You talk about her maybe cheating on you, but you don’t seem so... I don’t know... terrified.”

“I guess not.”

“There something you want to tell me?”

“I don’t know. Maybe over a drink or two.”

*

But this acceptance of the new driving force within me wasn’t all light and cheer. Even though I did find myself hopeful of discovering new signs that Courtney was perhaps having an affair, it still scared me—still made me feel deeply uncomfortable.

It took until that Thursday morning for me to figure out what it was. When I woke, it was much earlier than usual. Five-thirty, the alarm clock said. I'm such a regular sleeper, it confused me waking at that time. Beside me, Courtney was gone from the bed. I heard a rustle in the dark.

She was getting dressed, already. I propped myself up to watch her pulling on her underwear—black thong, black bra. Stockings, garters. So sexy, so beautiful to watch her, even in the low light levels of an October morning.

It took me a few moments to remember she had a board meeting that day, explaining her early start.

It took me a few more moments to realize that it was odd for her to be wearing stockings and garters period, let alone at this time of day. Let alone for a board meeting.

I was rock hard in an instant, and it wasn't merely from the fact that I was watching such a hot show. I felt a hot flush inside my chest, an intense heat. This was another sign of adultery, wasn't it? I hadn't even seen her in this particular lingerie before, and I don't think I'd seen her in stockings since... well, before we were married.

I watched her, and I pretended to be still asleep.

I found myself thinking that another man would be peeling those stockings off her.

She turned around, and the front panel of her panties seemed sheer to me.

On went her dress—okay, it was conservative enough, businesslike. With a jacket on top, it wasn't out of the ordinary. But my heart was threatening to burst through my rib cage just now.

She spent an age on her makeup, brushed her hair again, gazed at herself in the mirror to make sure everything was right.

Then she leaned over to kiss me and wake me and tell me she had to get going to the board meeting downtown or she'd be late. Filling my chest with her perfume—a new perfume. It smelled sweet, exotic, not quite her usual floral fragrance of choice.

It made me think of adultery.

The moment I heard the front door of our apartment close and knew that she was out of there, I was up and out of bed. I didn't need to get up early, I was self-employed in the most flexible terms possible. But no way was I getting back to sleep that morning.

I wasn't sure what I was doing. I was a mass of panic and delight and horror and excitement, running around our apartment like a headless

chicken.

Should I follow her taxi in the car? See where she was going, whether there really was a board meeting for her health trust that particular day? What if I witnessed her meeting up with Harry Richards instead?

A cup of coffee curbed my immediate stalker cravings. I sat down at our computer, and wondered if it was possible to find anything in her Facebook page, or her email, which might clarify just what the hell was going on with her right now.

It just felt so terribly unethical to do something like that. Like, even if she was cheating on me, to dig into her personal space like that would make me instantly worse than her cheating.

Well. At least I could try to find out a little more about exactly who Harry Richards was.

Chapter 5

Back in the early days of our dating, I probably would have dived right into her personal business out of sheer paranoia. Back then, I'd been so convinced that she had to be seeing other guys—not because she gave me any reason to be, but simply because it seemed so inevitable. Everything about our relationship felt temporary, like a dream from which I would one day wake. Maybe I was still waiting to wake up.

But now, I knew things about myself. I knew that yes, okay, sure, it did turn me on thinking of her being unfaithful. I also wasn't sure how I'd react if she really did do it. Also, there was my experience with Jason and how I'd felt when I discovered that I'd read the situation all wrong. The disappointment was crushing, and while I didn't understand that emotion back then, I think I got it now.

That was the paradox. I think I wanted to know, but at the same time, I didn't. If I lived in ignorance, then I could have the best of both worlds: the excitement that she was being naughty, with the comfort that she was remaining true and that this was all in my head. I could already picture Charlie shaking his head at my bone-headed actions.

So I stayed away from her emails and her Facebook account. It was an invasion of her privacy, and I also just didn't really want to know. Yet? Or never?

I did look up Harry Richards, though. I knew so precious little about him, and it was even tricky to look him up on Facebook and LinkedIn. Turned out Harry Richards was a pretty common name. It wasn't until I remembered that he'd gone by "Henry Richards" when I had first seen him at Courtney's office that I located him.

I found his LinkedIn page first. His hair was shorter in his profile image, cut down to almost nothing at the sides and buzzed along the top. He had been a pilot in the Air Force until just recently, and there were plenty of photos of him posing in front of a fighter jet, his helmet tucked under an arm. He'd earned a few medals over his ten years of service, had fought in Iraq and Afghanistan, and was now working for a defense contractor on some drone projects, apparently.

I searched his past for some connection that he may have had with my wife, but the only thing I could find was that they'd gone to the same

college. If I was hoping to find old pictures of the two of them cozied up together—and I was pretty certain that I did—I came up blank.

By the time I tore myself away from my internet detective work, it was late morning and I was behind schedule on my project. The thought of working alone, though, while my wife may or may not have been at her day-long board meeting with the sexiest lingerie I'd ever seen beneath her dress, was too much. I swung by Home Depot and picked up a couple of day laborers to help with some of the construction work—not because I needed them so much as I needed their distraction.

It worked. Mostly. We talked in a broken mishmash of Spanish and English, understanding one another enough to crack jokes and talk about international soccer. I got more work done on the frame of the new addition I was putting in than I was hoping. And there were stretches of time when I wasn't thinking about Courtney and her new perfume.

But then, there were stretches of time when I was, too. The thing that kept coming back to me was the premeditation of the whole thing. If, indeed, she was having an affair, this was no longer a spur of the moment thing. She couldn't use the excuse that everything had happened in the heat of passion. She had told me about this board meeting a couple weeks ago. She had purchased her sexy lingerie—including the first ever garter belt that she herself had bought—in advance of today. Whatever she was up to, it had been planned.

I didn't know how I felt about that. It got me hard, absolutely, but it also felt like I'd had some really bad food the night before.

Around 4, Courtney texted me, reminding me that she would be late tonight. Without thinking, I responded:

[Me]: That's okay. I'm meeting Charlie for drinks. Will be out late. You'll probably beat me home.

[Courtney]: Oh, thanks for the heads up. Have fun! Give Charlie my love.

See, here is the fucked up part. I just gave her an excuse to stay out late, to not worry about making excuses for coming home. I was enabling this affair as much as she was doing it. And on top of that, it was thrilling when I pressed send.

I did check the health fund website and learned that there was, indeed, their annual board meeting, although search as I might, I couldn't find a schedule. By six o'clock, I wondered if it was over now. I wondered if she'd slipped away to meet up with Harry. I told my workers to clock out, dropped them off where their cars were, and headed out to meet up with Charlie.

*

Charlie's client had opened a harbor-side sports bar named Smitty's, and on a Thursday night, it was packed. Televisions were everywhere, broadcasting Thursday Night Football and playoff baseball, with hockey on a few, and SportsCenter filling the rest. Everyone seemed ready to begin the weekend a day early.

Charlie had staked out a spot tucked away in the corner of the bar. It was good enough that we could watch the football game, but also look through the large windows to the dark waters of the harbor beyond. Even the outdoor porch space, between those windows and the water, were packed with people huddled beneath the heat lamps.

"This place is popular!" I shouted as I took a seat next to Charlie. A beer sat in front of the seat that he'd managed to keep empty, rich and golden and exactly what I needed.

"Yeah, it's doing pretty well," Charlie said. "How was your day?"

I picked up the beer and drank almost a third of it in one go.

"That well, huh?"

"It's been some day, man," I said. "I'm pretty sure Courtney's with her...guy." 'Lover' was more appropriate, but who uses that word these days?

"What makes you say that?" Charlie asked.

"You're not going into psycho-analysis mode, are you?"

"I'm just asking, as one friend to another. As a guy who cares about you both."

"Well, she's supposedly at a board meeting today. That health fund thing that she's on now."

"Right," Charlie said, sipping at his beer. It was hard not to get self-conscious as he looked on.

"Well, I saw her getting ready this morning. Let's just say it looked like she was preparing for more than just a stuffy board meeting. She wore *stockings*, Charlie. With a *garter belt*. She had new perfume. She looked..."

"Sexy?" he offered.

"Too sexy. She's only ever worn something like that once or twice, and only because I'd bought it for her. And this stuff was new, man."

"Maybe she put it on to surprise you later tonight?"

“Maybe...” I said uncertainly.

“Or maybe she put it on to give her some confidence at the board meeting. She’s the only woman on the board, right? Liz does that sometimes, too. It’s like she’s got this secret beneath her clothes. Says it gives her confidence.”

“I guess.” I sighed. He was right, of course, and I’d considered both of those things.

“But you don’t want that to be the explanation,” Charlie said, vocalizing the exact thing I was thinking at that moment.

“I—”

“If I told you that I know she’s having an affair, how would you feel?”

He may as well have punched me in the head. My vision blurred. My brain rang. For a second, the entire bar and all of its noise disappeared, replaced by the reverberating phrase: *she’s having an affair, affair, affair...*

“You...” I raked my hand over my face. “You know?”

“I just wanted to know how you’d feel. Honestly.”

And there was the disappointment, frustrating and confusing as it was. I threw back my beer, drained it, and slammed it onto the counter. Charlie was already signaling for another.

“Okay, so honestly?” I said. Charlie nodded. “You asked a while back whether there was a chance that I wanted her to have an affair. And I think that a part of me does. Isn’t that totally fucked up?”

“It’s...unusual,” Charlie admitted. “But look, John, I happen to know a thing or two about you.”

“Oh, you think?” I said, trying to lighten this conversation some.

“You are a man who lives in constant fear that one day, his wife will find someone better because *you* think that that someone isn’t you, because you’ve created this ‘perfect guy’ who’s the embodiment of every want and desire that Courtney has ever had, all wrapped up into one. Am I in the right ballpark, at least?”

I scowled. “Right enough. But we figured out all this in therapy.”

“We did, yeah, and I’ll tell you now what I told you then—you’re discounting Courtney and her own feelings for you. With your fatalism, you’re basically removing her own free will, like she can’t choose this stuff for herself. Like she didn’t already *choose* you. Maybe Courtney’s Adonis exists somewhere out there—maybe it’s even this Harry guy—but what makes you think that she’d just throw all the love she’s got for you away?”

“I guess that’s just it, though,” I said, feeling my defenses go up. “If she did meet someone...if she ever felt like she was stuck with me, that she’d settled or something—”

“And I’m telling you, man, that she’s not settled. That’s not how she thinks. She’s a smart girl—smarter than you, that’s for sure. Do you really think she’d lose her head because some hot guy hits on her?”

Even the question sent a shiver through me—and not entirely a negative one.

Charlie noticed. “See there, what was that?”

My face lit up. “I don’t know. I guess I...sort of, kind of...like the idea of her losing her head if a hot guy hits on her.” Shit, that sounded bad.

“And I think *that* is a defense mechanism you’ve developed to deal with all the attention that she gets. If you are already prepared for her to cheat on you, then if she does, you’ll be more prepared to deal. And over time, you started to get turned on by that scenario.”

“Is that your professional opinion, doc?”

Charlie groaned. “No, it’s my opinion as a friend. Because you know where that behavior will lead? To you somehow sabotaging your marriage. Like you almost did with Jason. Courtney’s smart, remember? Smart people don’t like being told that they’re not—”

“I’m not saying that she’s not,” I said.

“Sure you are. You’re saying she’s no smarter than an animal, driven by animal instincts.” He tapped his head. “We developed these things to help us deal with those instincts, and she’s got a bigger one than most.”

“You’re right,” I nodded. Took a huge swig to finish up my beer. The bartender had another one down in front of me before I’d even finished wiping my mouth on the back of my sleeve.

“These are really on the house?” I asked Charlie under my breath.

“Uh-huh,” he grinned and hunched his shoulders guiltily. “Don’t tell anyone at the APA, will you? They’d probably toss me out on my ass.”

I downed another swig of the cold stuff, feeling the burn of the bubbles on the back of my throat, letting the sensation dull the low throb of disappointment that seemed intent on embracing me that night. “I’m game if you are,” I said.

Smiling, Charlie said, “It’s all a bit of a gray area, really. Steve, the owner of this place was a client, sure, but a while ago. He’s not now. I guess he feels I had something to do with the fact he no longer needs therapy.”

I laughed. “Sounds like you need to be a little less good at your job, Charlie. You know—customer retention and all that.”

He laughed with me. “I guess I could use a few lessons in that.”

“Here’s a tip: don’t become best buddies with your clients, or they’ll expect to use your services for free.”

Charlie nodded, but looked at me seriously for a moment. “You are always welcome to use my services for free, Johnny boy. But remember I’m your friend more than your shrink.”

“I remember,” I said, lifting my beer for a silent toast in his honor.

“And it’s your friend right now telling you to let it go with Courtney, right? Chances are you’re misinterpreting what’s going on with her. You know what she’s really like.”

I nodded, feeling more than a little sheepish.

And picking up on my body language, he said, “You’re really disappointed, aren’t you?”

I shrugged, and somehow—despite the fact that Charlie had apparently persuaded me to stop being so paranoid, and to stop questioning my wife’s integrity and devotion—in that final moment of that particular conversation topic, I think I genuinely startled him.

Up until that moment, I think he hadn’t really believed I might want Courtney to actually be unfaithful. My response to his “solving” my problems came as a real surprise to him.

After that, we didn’t talk about Courtney, or my strange new fascination. It was a pleasant evening catching up, talking football and so on. Even talking about work seemed like some kind of diversion from all my recent heavy thinking about my wife.

As we finally prepared to part ways for the evening, though, each ordering a separate Uber car to take us in opposite directions down the freeway, Charlie said something that made me think.

“You seem like you’re waiting for the next step in your business, John boy.”

“Huh?” I asked him.

He looked at me, all earnest. Hard to argue against whatever he said whenever he looked at you like that. “You know Courtney is always amazed at how well you’re doing flipping houses.”

“Yeah... I guess...” I said. I’d never really thought about it. It didn’t feed into my usual paranoid agenda of me being way beneath her station.

“How well did it go today hiring those guys to help you get back on schedule?”

“Really good,” I said. Again, I hadn’t really thought about it all too much. The guys had done the work, sped things up for me, and hadn’t cost as much as I’d feared. “Yeah, really good.”

Charlie smiled. “You know... when you sell this place—and I know you’ll make a good sum from this one, buddy—you should buy two places next.”

“Two places?” The idea was somewhat daunting. I’d always been cautious with my whole strategy, buying run-down and bargain properties before adding value and selling for a decent enough profit. Never over-extending myself, never taking too much of a risk.

He nodded. “Split your capital between two projects. Do one yourself, just like you would. Hire in some help to do the other project at the same time. See how it goes.”

“I suppose...”

“You’re good at picking out bargain houses. Even if the other project ran late, you’d probably have no trouble covering your costs.”

I nodded. Smiled. It was a great idea. “You’re supposed to be my shrink, aren’t you?” I said. “Not my business advisor.”

He gave me the standard bear hug as we came outside the bar to find our Uber cars waiting patiently. “I’m your friend, John, that’s the main thing. And as your friend... I think maybe you should talk to Courtney if you have... unusual things... on your mind.”

I nodded, agreed that he was right, he’d always been right.

But as I got into my car, I found myself thinking about what he’d meant about talking to Courtney about the “unusual things” on my mind. It was different to what he’d suggested earlier, to simply stop thinking about it all and give Courtney the benefit of the doubt.

So now he wanted me to open up to my wife about my desire to see her cheat on me?

Maybe I’d had one beer too many that night.

Chapter 6

On my way home I was toying with which way to interpret Charlie's advice when all was said and done. Let it all drop, and avoid any thought of enjoying the paranoia of adultery, or come completely clean and tell Courtney that I was having a strange new sexual fantasy about her?

Slumped in that taxi, I felt fairly sure that Charlie had gone and changed his mind on me at the last moment.

He'd seen with his own eyes that I had a perverse desire to see my wife being unfaithful. We hadn't been able to talk about that much, to be sure, but his advice to discuss this with my wife had been fairly clear, hadn't it?

Nevertheless, the prospect of suddenly opening up to Courtney about all this was a terrifying one. So many 'what if's presented themselves, and many of them suggested dire consequences. With such a beautiful wife, I had to tread carefully. Revealing myself to be some kind of weird perverted freak might not go down well with someone who was gorgeous and incredible in bed, but on the whole in my experience relatively conservative when it came to all things sex.

Her wearing of lingerie to a board meeting might suggest she was less conservative about sex than I'd thought, though, of course.

Still. I figured if she wanted to give me the boot, she could do so relatively easy any time and probably end up with a far more suitable boyfriend or husband or whatever. Harry Richards sprang to mind. A military career was hardly a lucrative one, but judging by his car and his clothes, his new job in private defense—or whatever it was—was paying quite nicely.

I couldn't face Courtney thinking I was a loser, that I was somehow less of a man because I wanted her to enjoy the thrill of adultery.

Finally, as I entered our apartment building and saw that she was already home—she'd picked up that day's mail from our mailbox—a new thought came to me. Charlie could still have meant for me to forget the crazy idea that I might enjoy my wife's adultery—and still want me to talk to Courtney about some of the issues I was having.

As I stepped into our apartment and saw my gorgeous wife sitting on the bench along the floor-to-ceiling windows looking out over the city

—and that she hadn't changed out of her business clothes, even potentially still wearing those black stockings—I knew what I was going to do.

“No. Look. He can't do it at the clinic, he's said so...”

Courtney looked up at me coming in the door as she continued with her phone call, and flashed me a blazing smile, waving at me silently as a way of apologizing for being on the phone as I came in.

“If his employers find out he needs treatment, it'll totally wreck his chances... No, I never said that...”

I smiled back at her, and shrugged to indicate there were no hard feelings.

Somehow, just seeing her perched on that bench, still potentially wearing all that lingerie, made most of my remaining paranoia melt away. Maybe she had worn it for me. Or maybe she'd felt the need for a little more self-confidence among the otherwise male-only board of the health trust.

Surely she wouldn't wear sexy undies like that to cheat on me, then come straight back to see me wearing exactly the same outfit?

“We can book a room at a hotel, for God's sake...”

Her conversation on the phone was work, clearly, so I zoned out.

“Yeah... look, if that's the only option, then we'll just have to do that instead...”

I waited, my strategy clear in my head. I'd act as though I was a completely normal husband, dealing with only the evidence which presented itself to me directly, right in front of my face.

She flashed me another silent look of apology, but finally managed to wrap up the call. “Okay... I'll ask... I can't guarantee it... yeah, bye.”

Then she rose to her feet, saying to me, “Sorry, sweetie. Can't get away from work today.”

“You're home pretty late,” I said, eyebrows rising as she approached me.

“I told you I would be, right?” she said, a note of nervousness in her voice all of a sudden.

“You did,” I smiled, and she relaxed again. “You know they don't pay you enough to work these kind of hours.” I stepped up to her, took her hands.

She smiled. “Yeah... but I can't exactly complain.”

She leaned forward to kiss me, said, “Hey...” as though she hadn't properly greeted me. I smelled that new perfume of hers, not quite so

strong now, but still there. Nothing else, though. Not the hint of another man's cologne, not the tell-tale scent of sex.

"I missed you today," I said softly.

She gave me one of those "awww, so sweet..." looks where she tilted her head for a moment and creased her forehead. I pulled her to me, but she stepped back. "I really need to get in the shower..."

But I didn't let her go. She turned, and I pulled her back to me, holding her by the shoulders from behind.

"I've been waiting all day for you," I complained quietly, sweeping my hands all over her dress, from shoulders down to hips. She smiled broadly, enjoying my attention. She groaned as my hands rose up to settle upon the pleasing roundness of her breasts.

"You can't wait five minutes more?" she teased, but pressed her body back against mine, jiggling her hips as though to try to feel whether I was hard for her yet. I was. She couldn't have missed it.

"Not five seconds more," I said, nuzzling against her cheek, breathing in the wonderful clean smell of her long, dark hair.

And now one of my hands trailed up her leg, feeling that unusual texture of thin black nylon stretched over her smooth skin, the rough black lace that topped off her stockings, the hot flesh between her stocking tops and her thong.

She caught her breath as I touched her there, but didn't prevent my progress.

"You went to a board meeting all day," I growled, "and wore underwear like this?"

My fingers trailed over the sexy black lace of her thong, finding it already soaking with her personal wetness. She couldn't be this wet this soon just from my touching her, I was sure of it.

But I was acting the 'normal' husband. Channeling mainstream behavior for a guy of my station.

"Maybe I just put it on for you..." Courtney breathed as my fingers traced little circles in the lace directly over her clit. I felt a burst of surprise—shock, really—that she might tell me a lie like this. But then she smirked, and added, "Why, are you jealous?"

Her smirk effectively told me I was right, but also seemed to reassure me I couldn't have anything to worry about.

"I saw you put it on this morning," I said.

"You were watching me getting dressed?" She smiled, loving this, loving my furtiveness somehow, and the way I'd paid attention to her when she'd sought to keep this particular outfit secret from me.

“Uh-huh,” I said, and slowly tugged down the zip on the back of her dress, slipped the straps off her shoulders, and allowed it to drop toward the floor, revealing the luxurious lace of her bra, the extravagant eroticism of her garter belt, her scandalously skimpy black lacy thong and those stockings, which made her look as though she’d stepped off the pages of a gentleman’s magazine.

I said, “I know your board is mostly men...”

She giggled, and gave a little melodramatic gasp, making me think of Marilyn Monroe. “You are jealous!” she said, as though it was the most wonderful thing she’d ever learned.

Her hand found its way back to check out the tent pole in my pants. “Jealous and turned on...” she teased. “How confusing!”

I ran my hands all over her, up and down, as though I couldn’t quite believe her lingerie was real. It was so damn extravagant, and I’d never seen anything so sexy. I pulled her face toward me for a passionate kiss, and felt her hand pressing against my hardness, loving how I was responding to her mysterious and sudden use of fancy underwear.

She said, “Is it bad that I’m totally turned on when you get all jealous?”

“I’ve never been jealous,” I insisted.

“Oh, but you are now...” She whirled around to face me, grabbing my head, kissing me as though she was some kind of vampire with a lust for blood, sucking ferociously at my lips, thrusting her tongue against mine.

When she finally broke away from me, breathless, she gazed into my eyes and declared, “I love it!”

She hadn’t actually denied that anything untoward had happened that day, she hadn’t given me any explanation whatsoever. She’d avoided the question, distracted me by this sudden desire for my jealousy.

Had she really done something worth being jealous about?

“Who did you wear this for?” I demanded to know, my hands crawling all over her bountiful rear, tugging on her garter belt. “Someone from the board meeting?”

She grinned, and only kissed me more forcefully. I got the impression that she thought I was role-playing, that since she’d confessed to this new turn-on, I was now indulging her.

It meant, probably, that she did have some kind of rational, non-adulterous explanation for wearing this lingerie. That was somehow both disappointing for me, and uplifting. I was gutted that she might be innocent of all charges—and yet buoyed by the sense that she might

really still love only me, she really might be true to me despite my suspicions.

I liked the idea of her infidelity, after all: it was her lying that I couldn't stand. The word 'cheating' was thrilling to me, but in reality the deceit involved, the duplicity it required as a concept did take the edge off my desire for it. I wanted my wife to be naughty, to be wicked. But I didn't want her to lie to me, didn't want her to keep secrets from me, didn't want her to give something of herself to someone else if it wasn't entirely in my control to give.

"I wish I could tell you I didn't wear it for someone from the board meeting..." she said, teasing me, though somehow still sounding as though she was telling the truth.

For a moment, I suddenly couldn't tell if she was role-playing or not.

What if she was cheating on me?

What if she was about to confess?

It only made her seem all the more gorgeous in my eyes. I asked her, "Did you go with him somewhere, after the board meeting?"

We couldn't stop sucking on each other's faces. Courtney hopped up and wrapped her stocking-clad legs around my body, pulling herself so tightly against me my hard-on was crushed between our two bodies.

"You really think I'd cheat on you?" she said, dropping back down to the floor again.

"I don't know..." I hesitated, wavered. Thinking about Harry Richards, now; his late-night visit to her practice, his arm around her waist that night out with Charlie. His easy sense of possession of her.

"And if I did... you really think I'd tell you?" she taunted me.

Oh God. She was so hot. Even if Charlie had been telling me to drop all this nonsense about wanting Courtney to cheat on me, I couldn't. I really couldn't. I wanted her to be sullied, to be liberated, to be oh so god-damn promiscuous.

I pulled down her bra, a little roughly, in fact. Not how I usually was with her.

"You're my wife," I growled, playing into this as though we were still role-playing, ducking down to take one of her gorgeous breasts in my mouth, and then the other, sucking furiously on those stiff nipples of hers.

Role-playing, and yet she was apparently revealing a fantasy for me to be jealous, and I was certainly harboring a fantasy of having reason to be jealous.

She gasped as I sucked on her tits, and reached to grasp my hardness through my pants.

As I rose again to kiss her mouth, she was smiling so brightly at me, loving this strange new dynamic between us. She declared, “I’m your wife, but that doesn’t mean you own me.”

I grabbed one of her buttocks in one hand, made her squeal as I manhandled her, as I forced her to bend over the hard granite counter of the island dividing our open-plan kitchen from the living room/dining room area.

“You promised to be faithful to me,” I snarled, but I was stroking her stunning curves, pawing at her glorious behind, so very exposed by her tiny thong.

She moaned and giggled and lifted one leg up onto the counter to aid my exploration of her wicked body.

She said, “I promised... but sometimes a girl faces such temptation, sweetie...”

I lifted her up onto the island, so she was kneeling on it, butt raised, head shoved down against the cool polished stone. She was so incredibly turned on—by her day in naughty lingerie at a business meeting, by this little role-play game of ours.

Because I was fairly sure, now, that this was role-play. She hadn’t cheated on me, somehow. Maybe she’d even dressed in lingerie all day just to get me jealous like this for when she returned. She’d purposefully let me watch her getting dressed this morning just so I’d know she was going to her board meeting dressed like a Playboy Playmate.

Even if it was role-play, it was so hot to find out how much this jealousy game turned her on. And maybe, letting her know that her attempts at making me jealous turned me on.

She was so wet, so very very wet. Her smell was all around me as she knelt there before me on the counter, and I grabbed her hips and kissed her hot flesh, peeled her soaking thong down off her behind, leaving it strung around her thighs as I laid my eyes on her sensational, glistening sex.

“Oh... please... honey...” she moaned as my kisses grew nearer and nearer to her sweet pussy, as my hands sprawled all over her buttocks and squeezed as though I really did own her, or at least as though I was reclaiming her as my own.

“Tell me who he is,” I barked.

“I’m sorry... I’m sorry I’ve been a bad girl...”

I touched my nose just next to her smoldering sex, inhaling that powerful aroma of dark spice, which must have been building all day.

“Who... is... he?” I demanded.

“I’m sorry...” she whined, “...I can’t tell you...”

I believed her about the board meeting, but I still wasn’t sure about Harry Richards. Maybe this was all an act today, but there were still questions about that man, the pilot, whatever he was to her.

Maybe this whole role-play thing right now was designed to soften me up, so she might one day actually reveal she’d had a fling with another man, a patient. Harry Richards.

Yet that thought only made me hope it was true, only made this whole role-play thing hotter for me. Only made me desire Courtney all the more.

I growled, “You’re mine. You wear sexy clothes for me, only me. Understand?”

I jammed my face against her searing pussy, tasted the hot tangy zest of her arousal, lapped at her with a ravenous mouth.

She clung to the far edge of the island and cried out in sheer pleasure, “Oh... yes... honey... only for you... only for you...”

I feasted on her, loving her flavor, loving how I made her writhe under me, loving how she cried and whimpered from the sensations flowing through her exquisite form. What if she was sleeping with Harry Richards already? Did it put me off? Not at all. Imagining it only made me hungrier for her.

What if this was some kind of double-bluff? And she’d had another man’s cock in here, stretching her sweet pussy, earlier today?

The thought did not put me off. It only made me see her as more desirable, more out of my league, more and more like some kind of goddess I was fortunate to be in a position to worship.

She came right there on our kitchen island. I don’t think we’d made love outside our bedroom in this apartment, let alone in the damn kitchen. It felt a little different, a little naughty. And wow did she come quickly, shaking like a leaf in a storm under me, whimpering like a lost sheep.

She turned around to sit on the edge of the counter and face me, to kiss my mouth again, but also to gaze earnestly into my eyes.

“You know... I was playing, right?” she said, and I guess our little role-play really had been blurring some lines between fiction and fact. “I didn’t really cheat on you, honey... I really wouldn’t...”

I put a finger to her lips to silence her. “Not yet,” I insisted, begging her not to end the fantasy. “Not yet.”

The corners of her mouth curled upward into a mischievous grin—surprised, but loving the fact that I was as into this as she was. As into being made jealous as she was into making me jealous.

As she perched on the edge of that counter, I pulled off her bra and sucked one of her breasts back into my hot mouth, and she moaned, flashing me another beaming smile. I slid down her body and parted her legs, unable to resist more of her sweet nectar, and the fact there was so much to go round.

I did believe her, that she wouldn’t cheat on me. It did make me love her more. In my head, I fought against the inevitable disappointment that came from hearing her either lying to me or actually declaring that she was purer than pure.

I clung on to the fact that we were playing this game. She was playing the cheating wife, and I was playing the outraged—but horny—husband.

I led her through to the bedroom, and now she was on her knees, dragging my pants down my legs, gasping at just how hard I really was.

“Will you forgive me?” she asked me, taking my hardness in both her hands, massaging it, bringing it down to her pretty, red-stained lips.

“Forgive you?”

She sucked me deep into her hot mouth, and I nearly lost it right there and then. Then she withdrew it, said, “Forgive me for being so weak... for giving in to temptation...”

“I guess we all give in to temptation occasionally...” I said, getting back into my role.

“You’re so hard, honey...” she breathed, genuinely amazed by what she felt, it seemed, by the difficulty she had in stretching her lips around my cock.

I could only moan by way of reply.

Sounding like some femme fatale in a 1940s film noir, she said, “I don’t know why I ever had eyes for anyone else... you’re more than enough man for me...”

It wasn’t the fact that she was pledging her allegiance to me that got me going. It was her stating that she’d had eyes for someone else. I ushered her up and onto the bed, pushing her onto her back, pulling open her legs before thrusting my stiffness straight into her sopping wet pussy.

In our role-play, I was the aggrieved, enraged husband reclaiming my wayward wife—forgiving her, but apparently putting her actual

transgression largely out of my mind. But as I fucked her, and again managed to bring her to a juddering, trembling climax in an astonishingly short time, I was actually thinking what Courtney might think if we repeated this particular role-play—and I demanded to know more of the details of her actual infidelity.

She could tell me... and I could pretend to be incensed by it... and perhaps she'd never need to know I enjoyed the thought of another man stealing her for a night or two.

What a night. We showered, and when we returned to the bed I was inside her again, this time taking her from behind like some kind of desperate beast.

I think Courtney got the message. Past midnight we collapsed on the bed and she said, "What would you have done if I'd really had an affair?"

The question startled me. Shocked me.

It was, of course, a natural opening for me to confess to everything, to get all of the lurking darkness off my chest. To tell her how I really felt, and thereby dispel at least some of the secrets from our marriage.

But I simply mumbled, "I... I don't really know..."

"You were so hard, sweetie..." she said in a kind of awed whisper. "And we've never... I mean, God, we were like teenagers tonight."

I laughed at that, but still felt surprisingly uncomfortable talking about this subject with her. Why couldn't I just say? Honey, I love the idea of you cheating on me.

Well, the obvious answer is that I didn't want to give her the idea that it was all right just to go out there and cheat on me. Especially with Harry Richards. She was hot, she was sexy, she was clearly turned on by the thought of making me jealous, but I didn't want her lying to me, I didn't want her treating me with that kind of contempt.

"I guess the lingerie worked on me," I said.

She laughed. "And me!"

Courtney reached for her Kindle, which was there on her bedside table as it always was. "Look," she said, switching it on, swiping on the screen to open up the ebook she'd been reading.

It was some kind of self-help manual, I could tell instantly from the layout. I'd used enough of them myself when I'd dropped out of college to flip my first house when the tuition money ran out.

This one, though, was entitled: "Evening Up The Score" and was written by one Martha Wynn-Thomas. My eyes skipped down the page to a subhead that read: "5. Make yourself feel gorgeous". I skimmed

through the paragraphs that urged women to pamper themselves and wear nice clothes to build up their self-confidence when facing tough business environments or particular anxieties in the workplace. And there was the suggestion: “It’s your secret, but some sexy lingerie under your business attire could make you feel powerful even though you have no intention of actually showing it off to anybody.”

I laughed. “Seriously?” I said. “This was what you were doing?”

She shrugged. “You know how nervous I get about all that business stuff.”

“I suppose so...” She had a point. Usually the night before board meetings she was as jittery and nervous as a high schooler before her SATs.

“The medicine... the physio... I can handle. Get me in a room full of suits scouring the paperwork and the power points, and I’m terrified.”

“So did it help?” I asked her, and fished out a scrap of lace from beneath my pillow that just happened to turn out to be her black lace thong.

“Hey!” she said sharply as she realized what I had.

“Would you do it again?” I demanded to know, teasing her by holding her underwear up to my nose, inhaling it as though I was some kind of connoisseur sampling a wine’s bouquet.

“Yes... I probably would...” She was almost indignant about it. Then she broke into another broad smile, “And you know... if it makes you all jealous... that’s another nice plus.”

Chapter 7

[Me]: Sorry, running behind. Will be there in about 15.

I was late. For my own birthday dinner. I'd taken Charlie's advice and hired a few guys to help me out. We'd made up enough time that I'd actually lost track of it. That still meant that I needed to grab a shower and get dressed. Courtney was coming from work, and we'd planned to meet at the restaurant separately.

[Courtney]: Take your time. I'm at the bar, and there's plenty to entertain myself here.

The seat of my pants tightened as I read her text. Since the night a few weeks back when she admitted to me that she liked making me jealous, she had not done much to demonstrate. She didn't bring up Harry. She didn't come home later than usual, or tell me not to come by. She'd been good. But there was a new kind of energy buzzing beneath the surface, unspoken yet electric. It came out when we made love, when she moaned as I fucked her from behind, when we lay together, sweaty and exhausted, and drifted off to sleep.

Plenty to entertain myself. I couldn't resist.

[Me]: Yeah? Run into someone you know?

My heart started crawling up my throat as I waited for her to respond.

[Courtney]: No one I know...yet.

That lit a fire beneath me. I drove just a little faster, cut the lights a little closer, drove a little more aggressively. I kept my phone open on the passenger seat, checking it for more texts every reasonable chance I got. None came, which was somehow worse.

Despite all the rushing, I got so snarled in traffic that I arrived at Paloma's almost a half hour later. I used the valet, just so that I wouldn't have to deal with searching for street parking, and hurried into the restaurant.

Paloma's was in an immediate suburb of the city, within a neighborhood that I could see Courtney and I one day moving out to when we decided to have children. I'd turned a house over out here, a couple years back when it was still transitioning to the upscale spot it was now. Paloma's itself occupied the first floor of a mixed-use high rise,

and took full advantage of the non-urban space. The ceilings were high and the room was open, sectioned off by long, dramatic drapery.

At seven-thirty on a Friday evening, the bar space was packed with office workers and suburbanites getting home after a long week. Despite that, though, it was easy to find Courtney in the crowd—and when I did, my breath caught.

She was seated on a stool at the bar, her legs crossed, flanked by two guys who seemed to be vying for her attention. One would speak, she'd listen with a smile and a flirty nod, she'd laugh at whatever joke he made, and then before she could speak, the other was trying to outdo the first.

I started to raise my hand to wave, but stopped for some reason. All that electricity that had been humming beneath the surface these past few weeks was back, strong enough that my teeth chattered.

Courtney was a true beauty, but most of the time she downplayed it. She wore only a little makeup and hid her body beneath jeans and flowy blouses. Her dark hair was usually pulled back in a ponytail more times than not. When she wanted to dress up, though, Courtney could transform herself. Tonight, for my birthday, she'd transformed. Her hair was done up in an elegant twist, accentuating her graceful neck and the glittering pendant earrings that dangled from her dainty lobes.

Her gray dress wasn't particularly tight or low cut—in fact, in coverage alone, it was conservative, ending just above her knees. But it was tight enough that it left little to the imagination, hugging her slender curves and outlining her high, perfect swells. A slit up the back of the dress left just enough of her black-stockings clad legs to draw the eyes—and these two guys were looking every chance they got.

As I watched, she covered her mouth and laughed at whatever Guy On Her Left had said, immediately looking at Guy On Her Right. The man looked sheepish, shrugging and nodding as she stared at him with wide eyes.

Just then, she looked out across the bar and found me standing there, overheated and dumbfounded by the entrance. Placing one hand on each of their arms, she stood and seemed to apologize to them both. They followed her eyes to me, looking like she'd just diagnosed them with something serious.

Courtney didn't appear to be sorry about it at all. There was no sincerity to her apology. She laughed musically, thanked them for their time, and then sauntered toward me. Her heels were tall, I noticed,

forcing each step to be deliberate, her hips sashaying in a sexy way that was uncharacteristic for my wife.

Glancing behind her, the guys were following her hips, too, pining for the sexy beauty that they almost had, but had ultimately lost. To me. She'd left those two, successful and handsome guys *for me*. Confidence and pride shot through me.

"You finally made it," she said, wrapping her arms around my neck and pressing her body against me. I could smell vodka on her breath and wondered just how much she'd had to drink.

"Sorry. Traffic."

She searched my face with those sharp irises of hers. I recognized that look. She was horny. "It's okay, I told you I found some entertainment."

I looked over her shoulder, where the two guys were commiserating over their beers. "I see that. You have fun?"

"So much fun." Her eyes flashed. She leaned in and kissed me softly. "Come on, let's go see if our reservation is still available."

I stared at her as she moved away from me. While the dress reached her neck in the front, from behind it left a swath of her creamy back bare—enough to tell that she couldn't have been wearing a bra beneath. Not only that, but the tight dress, made of some crushed velvet material, hugged her ass enough that I wasn't sure she was wearing *anything* beneath. My cock surged, and embarrassed by the bulge, I caught up to her.

"My husband and I had a reservation," she was saying to the maître d'. "Party of two for 'Haute'."

The poor man visibly swallowed as he processed what she'd just said. After a confused moment, he realized she was talking about our last name, then nervously scanned his books. "Yes, we, um, still have your table."

He led the way as Courtney flashed a smile at me. I put a hand on her lower back, my fingers searching for the outline of her panties. I didn't feel one. "This is quite a dress," I said.

"Thank you," she said. "You're the third man to tell me that today." She laughed silently at whatever shocked expression splashed across my face. "I'm sorry, I'll stop. It's just hard to get out of the mindset after teasing those two guys like that for almost 45 minutes."

"They looked pretty disappointed when I arrived," I said. The host showed us to our private table, pulling the seat back for Courtney. I noticed his eyes stray down her sheathed body as he did so.

“Thank you,” she said to him.

“A server will be with you shortly,” he said, and hurried away.

“You think they were?” she asked, crinkling her nose cutely.

Insincerely. “Disappointed?”

“You really do enjoy this, don’t you?”

She looked up at me quietly, considering her answer carefully. “I’ve had two cocktails on an empty stomach—your fault, by the way. I can’t be held accountable.”

Her confession emboldened me. I reached across the table and took her hands. “Those two, poor guys are going to go home thinking about how close they were. And that turns you on.”

Her face twisted into a smile. “Oh, I wouldn’t feel too sorry for them. They did ply me with drinks and then invite me back to their place for a threesome.”

My jaw dropped. So that’s what had shocked her there in the end. Before I could formulate a reasonable thing to say, our server showed up and introduced himself as Rick.

“Can I start you with something to drink?” Rick asked.

Courtney looked up at Rick, meeting his eyes, and asked, “I’m in the mood for something rich and earthy. Feels like a night for red, don’t you think, Rick?”

The young man, broad-shouldered and fit, returned her flirty smile, despite the fact that I was right there. “I know just the thing. We’ve got an excellent Cabernet that just came in from Napa. Let me bring you a tasting.” He took a step back, then seemed to remember me. “And you, sir?”

I could see Courtney’s grin out of the corner of my eye. It made me smile, too. “I’ll try the same.”

“I’ll be right back.” He seemed to stumble away.

“Now you’re being mean,” I said to her.

“Don’t be sorry for these guys. Trust me, I doubt they sleep alone very often.” She glanced off at the server. “I mean, if I were single...”

I shifted in my seat, trying to adjust my growing cock.

She shook her head, seeming to come out of whatever spell had overtaken her tonight. “But this is your birthday. We’re here to celebrate that.”

Rick the server came back over, and this time Courtney was much more reined in—much more her usual self—as he poured her a small sip of the Cabernet. She nodded, and he filled both of our glasses, took our orders, and left.

“I think he’s got a crush,” I said.

Courtney held up her hands. “I didn’t do anything to encourage it that time.”

“You didn’t need to. He was hooked from the moment you asked him about the red wine.” I picked it up. “Cheers. To my birthday.”

Courtney must have been sobering up, because she actually looked a little bashful, pink creeping up her cheeks. “Happy birthday, honey.”

“It’s already been an interesting one.”

She took that as a negative, which I wasn’t sure that it was. “I’m sorry about that. I promise, it was harmless.”

“That happen often? Guys just come up to you and...offer you threesomes?”

Courtney covered her mouth as she laughed unexpectedly. I laughed with her. “No, I would say that’s more of an ‘occasional’ occurrence, not often.”

It was a joke, but even the idea of that not being her first time was thrilling. “Have you ever done that?” I shivered as the question came out, and even more when she hesitated before answering.

“Um, you really want to know?”

Yes! I wanted to scream. “I think you just answered it,” I said, proud that my voice didn’t crack. “Did you like it?”

Courtney studied me carefully, her expression stuck between embarrassment and curiosity. I could feel her picking me apart, analyzing why I was asking, studying my reaction. Did she see my own flushed skin? Did she know I had such a huge erection hidden beneath the table?

“Sure, it was fun.”

I released a pent-up breath. She really had done it.

“But it was a long time ago. I’m not that person anymore.”

Her caveat was somehow even more thrilling. “What does that mean?” I blurted.

Courtney sipped her wine. “Um, I mean... Okay—I probably shouldn’t have said it like that. I just mean that back then, before I met you, back in college, I was much more...” She trailed off.

“Sexually active?” I offered.

“No, not quite that.” She played with the stem of her glass, thinking of how to approach this conversation. “I don’t talk about my past much because... I’m not really proud of who I was back then.”

“You know you don’t have to be ashamed of anything, right? I’m not going anywhere.”

She held my gaze for a long time, wrestling with whatever demons she held in her past. My gut churned as I filled in those details, imagining Courtney going off with those two guys, being stripped between them, dropping to her knees as she took turns sucking on their cocks.

We were shaken from our silence by Rick returning with our food. “Can I get you anything else? Another glass of the Cabernet, perhaps?”

I hadn’t realized that we had both finished our glasses. “Not for me, but my wife will take another,” I said.

“Trying to get me drunk?” she asked when he was gone.

“You figured me out.” I shrugged, glancing at the departing server. “So back in college, would you have gone for him?”

Courtney looked at Rick, sizing him up beneath her long lashes. She looked at me slyly. “He’s good looking,” she said. “But it wasn’t exactly like that.”

“So tell me how it was.”

She sighed. “I only had four boyfriends before you. I never lied about that.”

I felt the pressure of her confession begin to build. “Okay. Yes, four boyfriends, including only one in high school. Long-term boyfriends, too, because you didn’t like being single.”

“That’s right.” She bit her lip. “But I’ve, um, *been* with closer to... I don’t know... ten, fifteen guys.”

“Okay.” I scratched my head. “Help me understand that.”

“I’ve always been...pretty.” She rolled her eyes. “That sounds awful, but whatever. Guys have been checking me out since puberty. It’s a thing I had to learn to deal with early on, and I knew that I shouldn’t let that get to my head, but...” She shrugged. “Teenagers aren’t the most self-aware of people. So I guess it did get to me, kind of.”

“So you were what? The ‘mean girl’ in school?”

Courtney looked embarrassed. “Yeah, I guess I was. I mean, not as bad as that movie or anything, but there was definitely a clique of pretty girls, and I was in it. Anyway, we were an incestuous group, you could say, doing the group date thing more than anything exclusive. I don’t count any of those guys as boyfriends, by the way, and nothing serious happened. But there *was* this kind of competition, between us girls, for who got the most attention.”

“And you wanted to win.”

Courtney blushed. “I didn’t just want it. I did win. And you know how?”

I guess my face must have betrayed my lecherous thoughts, because she laughed and shook her head. “Not like that. I learned to play the guys off of each other. It was a game. Guys are kind of easy to manipulate—especially teenage boys. All I’d have to do is sit back, make them jealous of one another, and everyone would want me.”

“Very manipulative,” I said. “I didn’t think you had that in you.”

Courtney batted her lashes. “You’d be surprised at what I had in me. It was pretty shameful.”

Rick arrived just as she said that, with our refills of wine. If she was embarrassed, she didn’t show it. She sat there quietly, meeting his eyes as he refilled her glass, and thanked him as he left.

We looked at each other and shared a laugh. I said, “Okay, so you were a mean girl. Then what?”

“Then I sort of settled on Mark. Football quarterback, homecoming king. I mostly chose him because all the other girls wanted him.”

“You sound perfect for one another,” I said.

She laughed. “I hadn’t thought about it like that. But yes, at the time, I guess I thought so, too. We dated through senior year and into college. I had every intention of, I don’t know, marrying him or something. You know how it is with young love. In college, though, there was this whole other pool, and all the attention that came with it. It was...” She looked dreamy. “...eye opening. We tried to make it work. And it did, for almost the first semester. He’d visit, or I’d visit. He got jealous, though, so jealous. Especially when we were apart. But the crazy thing was that whenever we were together, whenever we reunited, the sex was intense. I found that the more jealous he was, the better those reunions were.”

I could understand that, but didn’t say anything. She was in the zone, and I didn’t want to disturb her.

“Then, close to winter break, during finals, I...” She hesitated, looking down into her wine glass. “I actually cheated on him. I felt awful. I didn’t mean for it to go so far, but we were drinking, one thing led to another, and...” She shrugged, wincing up at me.

“I’m not judging. High school relationships never last,” I said.

She licked her lips. “But that’s just it. It kind of did. I went home, confessed, felt terrible. Told him I was so sorry, and that it was meaningless, and all that. Mark was pissed, of course. So angry. And yet...”

“The sex was amazing.”

Courtney nodded. “So intense. So, *so* intense.”

“That wasn’t the last time you...slept with someone else when you were with him.”

Courtney shook his head. “I didn’t set out to do it, but found I couldn’t resist. It’s so awful, I know, but thinking about Mark’s jealous reaction was sometimes more exciting than the sex with the other man.”

I found myself envious of Mark, despite all logic. “So what happened?”

“Eventually, inevitably, it all came crashing down. I went to surprise him at his college. He was in bed with some other chick. Turned out that *he’d* been cheating on *me*, too. Maybe that’s why he never broke up with me. Like we had some unspoken open relationship. I don’t know.”

“So you split up.”

Courtney nodded.

“But the seed was planted.”

“Yeah.”

“And the other three boyfriends?”

“Also got pretty jealous. And none of them could handle it like Mark. It became self-destructive.”

My heart skipped a beat. “And me?”

Courtney was already shaking her head, like she knew just what I was going to ask. “You were different. After my fourth failed relationship, I knew I was out of control. It was fun, but there wasn’t a future in it—not the future I’d wanted since I was a little girl, anyway. I actually swore off men for a couple years before I met you. And the rest is history.”

What wasn’t said was that history had a way of repeating itself, and I had the distinct impression that it was right now. More, a part of me hoped that it was, despite knowing how badly those other four relationships had ended.

“That’s quite a story,” I said. “So I’m...what? Safe?”

Courtney’s eyes went wide. She shook her head. “No, it’s not like that at all. You’re *exactly* who I want. I couldn’t ask for a better husband. I just wasn’t ready for you until I met you.”

“And if I’d come into your life in college?”

She looked at me slyly. “Well, you’re a good looking guy, so I’m not saying you wouldn’t have had a chance. But I also don’t think you’re the type of guy who’d cheat with another man’s girlfriend, which is probably what I would have used you for.” She covered her face. “God, that sounds bad.”

My glass of water was almost gone. My plate was nearly empty. I finished the last swallow of water, the ice clinking against my teeth, and took a deep breath. “Do you ever miss those days?” I saw a shadow pass across her face. “Do you ever get tempted?”

There was something there. I swore that there was. A moment’s hesitation. Or maybe it was my imagination.

“I’m not going to risk what we have. Nothing’s worth that.”

It wasn’t a denial, but I didn’t call her on that. Instead, I brought up our conversation the other night. “But you’ve admitted you like making me jealous. Like with the lingerie and the board meeting. Or the guys earlier tonight.”

She didn’t back down, but in her head, she also clearly saw those things as different. “That’s nothing. It’s just a game. It’s nothing like...back then.”

I wanted to know more, but Rick interrupted us before I could. He placed a chocolate cake with a lit candle on it in front of me. “Happy birthday, Mr. Haute. Complements of our pastry chef.”

Courtney said, “Happy birthday, John. Make a wish.”

I stared at the flame, seeing Courtney’s past life in the sinuous flicker. Make a wish. I wish, I wish, I wish that someone would tempt Courtney beyond the game. My heart jumped.

I blew out the candle.

Chapter 8

After the chocolate cake came the cocktails. I was already feeling buzzed from all the wine, and even thinking about maybe slowing down a little, in case I ended up on the floor fairly early on in my birthday night.

But Rick arrived to remove the plates and the silverware, and Courtney immediately demanded the cocktails menu.

“Are you sure?” I asked her, considering the fact that she was acting a little tipsy herself—I can tell when Courtney’s been drinking, she gets ultra confident. It’s hot, but it’s a little nerve-wracking.

“Seriously? The night’s still young,” she said, her eyes flashing with mischief.

“I suppose...”

Rick returned quickly with the cocktail menus, and Courtney leaned across the table to take one from him, in the process giving both him and me a superlative view of her chest. I was somewhat surprised—her dress had started off as really quite tame, not at all low cut. Now she sat up straight with her menu and I could see it plunge down to show off a lot more of her cleavage. How had she managed that?

I looked at our waiter and had no doubt he’d seen exactly what I had. He looked a little hot under the collar, for sure. It fired me up more than a little.

“A Zombie for my husband and a Death in the Afternoon for me,” Courtney demanded. I raised my eyebrows at my sudden lack of choice in the matter, and it made her laugh. “You can choose the next ones,” she promised.

“So what’s next?” I asked her as our waiter melted away to fetch our cocktails.

“Whatever you like, it’s your birthday,” she said, sitting back to finish her red wine before the next round of drinks appeared.

She seemed to be enjoying showing off her chest to whoever happened to be passing by. I was enjoying it, too, though I tried not to show it too much.

“If it’s my choice alone,” I said, “then I’d most like to take you home and peel off that dress.”

Her smile was bright, but short-lived. As much as she liked my attention, she wasn't ready to call it quits yet for the night. She pouted, "We can go home any time. You don't want to see what the night might bring?"

I laughed. "I'm not sure I can drink quite as much as I used to."

She giggled. "I can. More, maybe."

"Okay," I nodded, seeing where this was going. "So what I want to do on my birthday is whatever you want to do. So what do you want to do?"

She grinned, ecstatic. "I want to have a few more strong drinks with my cute hubby, and then go dancing somewhere."

Our drinks arrived. I took one mouthful of my violently orange cocktail, and nearly burned out my throat. "Uh... what is this?" I asked.

Her drink was a cloudy pale green color, served in a Champagne glass, which she sipped delicately, showing no ill effects at all. "You've got three different kinds of rum there, lime juice... I think Pernod, Grenadine... grapefruit juice? Something like that..."

"Uh... nobody strike a match, please."

My wife was drinking Absinthe and Champagne, which I didn't even think was legal, so that shows how much I know.

The cocktails did what Courtney wanted them to, I suppose. I felt my inhibitions gradually weakened.

"The dance clubs... the good ones... aren't even open yet, so we might as well stay and be comfortable," she said as I suggested maybe we could skip the after-dinner liqueurs. "We can entertain ourselves, can't we?"

"Okay..." I said, sitting back clutching my orange biohazard, attempting to sip it yet very nearly passing out from the fumes alone. If she ordered me one more of these, I'd be out for the count.

"Now I think you're trying to get me drunk," I murmured.

"Of course," she laughed.

"You realize," I said, holding up my drink as though I was toasting her, "the more of this I drink, the worse my performance in the bedroom?"

Her eyes flashed. "Oh, but there's plenty of time to deal with that. Doesn't it make you feel nice?"

I looked around our table, taking in the relatively civilized restaurant, which really didn't seem like the place to drink such strong cocktails. I did feel good, I couldn't deny that. I was in that sweet spot where I felt ultra relaxed and strangely confident, yet without getting to

the stage where my movement was impaired, or my head becoming dizzy.

“I guess so,” I said.

“And makes you feel like we could say anything to each other.”

I nodded, “I suppose we could.”

She leaned forward, squeezing her breasts together for my benefit, and whoever else was looking our way. “So tell me what’s on your mind,” she demanded.

I shrugged. This was like some interrogation, here. I thought this was supposed to be my birthday. But there was an odd thrill in the fact that she was urging me to speak my mind. And that perhaps she would speak hers.

“What’s going on with your dress?” I asked her. “There’s no way you were showing off that much cleavage when we got here.”

She giggled. “It’s a Girrou dress. Made of really stretchy fabric,” she said, and tugged the neckline to show that she could effectively change the shape of her dress on her body, making it appear much more conservative.

“Wow,” I said.

“You like it this way, or this way?” She asked, giving me the option.

“That way,” I indicated the option where her cleavage was very much on display.

She grinned. “I thought you might say that. So what else is on your mind, sweetie?”

“Isn’t it my turn to ask what’s on your mind?”

She crossed her legs, and even from the other side of the table, I could see how high her dress was riding on her shapely thighs. I guessed that her Girrou dress had also been pulled down to just above her knees earlier, but had since seen its hem rising quite a way.

She said, “Okay... what’s on my mind?” She looked directly into my eyes, her gaze somehow sharp, almost intimidating. “Okay... what’s on my mind... this: when I wore some nice new lingerie and made you think I was wearing it for someone at our board meeting...”

“Yeah?”

“It made you into some kind of sex god,” she said. I felt my ears burning.

“I don’t think I’d call myself a god...” I said, modesty cutting in.

“That was the hottest night since... since...”

“Since Mark?” I prompted her. I felt a slight fluttering of the butterflies in my stomach, but the adrenaline was flowing through my

bloodstream. Normal husbands might not like to hear about their wives' previous boyfriends, but it was fascinating to me, exciting.

"I'm sorry..." she said.

"No, it's okay... so your other boyfriends... when you made them jealous..."

She shrugged, "With two of them it started out hot... and then kind of went nowhere. After a while they kind of resented any attempt to make them jealous."

"And the other one?"

"The other one didn't like it from the start... I'm not sure what happened there..."

"How long were you with him?"

"Six months? Maybe more. I never realized how much of a... I don't know... I guess he was religious, he liked the good girl image I projected on the surface."

"You were with a guy like that for six months or more?" I chuckled. "How did he manage to keep you?"

"I cheated on him," she said, with a sigh. I didn't want this to turn into some kind of therapy session, but it was interesting to me. "I liked cheating on him, I liked it more than anything else about him. I was kind of angry, I suppose."

"What happened?"

"Well... I mean, I'd cheated on all my boyfriends, and that was ultimately what killed those relationships. But then there was Wesley... and somehow it was the cheating that kept me in the relationship."

"Until he found out?"

She nodded. "I guess you could say... my reputation around college was like mud after that," she laughed, though I could tell the memories were painful. "At least it made me focus on my studies. Wouldn't be in the job I'm in otherwise..."

My turn to choose cocktails. I wasn't exactly going virgin, but I wasn't going to refresh the Eau de Chernobyl in front of me, and I didn't want Courtney to go off the boil yet, either. Long Island Iced Tea for her, Mojito for me. Easy, simple, nice.

"So all this has been on your mind?" I asked her.

She shrugged. "I really did wear that sexy underwear just so that it might improve my confidence in the board meeting," she said. "It was so important: I had to pitch to the board to support a project that will see our public clinic days increase to five per month..."

"And they went for it?"

“They did,” she grinned.

“Honey, that’s fantastic!” She did seem pleased.

“Only,” she said, “I get home... and there wasn’t time to change out of my clothes before you got back...”

“No need to,” I insisted.

“And then you were all jealous... and all over me...” I wasn’t sure whether she was complaining or celebrating what had happened. But from the way her nipples were pushing out through the thin gray material of her dress, I could tell she was turned on.

“You looked so good,” I explained. “And I guess thinking that I might lose you to some other guy...”

“You know you’d never lose me,” she said, earnest, honest seemingly.

“You seem... I don’t know... anxious...” I said.

“I don’t know... it awakened something inside me I thought I’d moved away from. And now I can’t stop thinking about it. And it frightens me.”

“Because your other relationships all folded?”

“Uh-huh.”

“I’m not going to stop wanting you just because you make me a little jealous now and again,” I said, feeling myself blushing, revealing more than I thought I’d be able to. Getting so close to telling her I fantasized about her sleeping with other men.

Why couldn’t I just tell her? I still felt embarrassed.

“I’m not kidding,” she said. “This could be very dangerous for us.”

The darkness she’d put out there between us... it was so very tempting to me. I felt like Anakin Skywalker being tempted by the wrong side of The Force.

“You said it’s just a game to you,” I reminded her. “Nothing to worry about. If you do something I’m actually uncomfortable with... I’ll just tell you, we can take it down a notch.”

She paused, looked at me almost regretfully. Pandora about to open her box.

“It worked with Mark, didn’t it?” I told her, though she didn’t seem persuaded. “It wasn’t you that wrecked that relationship... it was him cheating on you. You have to know I’d never ever do something like that to you.”

She nodded, trusting me. Seeming relieved, heavily relieved.

I felt strangely excited, though also very nervous at the same time. I’d effectively given her the go ahead to try treating me like her previous

boyfriends. To make me jealous in order to ramp up our sex life to unbelievable levels.

But with previously boyfriends it had been a slippery slope for her, descending into surefire infidelity.

Was that really what I wanted?

Chapter 9

Rick brought us the bill, and there was that awkward moment where he appeared to hand it to me to pay, because I was the man, then looked into Courtney's eyes before thinking better of it, and asking who was going to pay.

"Here," I said, reaching forward to hand over my card. Rick offered me his little mobile machine.

"I'll give him the tip," my wife said, pulling herself slowly out of the booth seat while I was typing in the PIN number for my card.

I looked up, amused that Rick found himself staring down at Courtney's gorgeous chest, then flicked his eyes up to her face to find he was well and truly busted.

Courtney gave him a silent naughty-naughty scolding with a gentle shake of her head and a wry smile, and our waiter did seem suitably humbled.

I glanced down to see that the payment had gone through, and then when I looked up, my wife said, "So I guess I should thank you for a lovely evening, Rick..."

I almost missed it. Almost wasn't watching. I like to make sure my bank card is safely stowed away in my wallet before I leave a place. I looked up to see Courtney step up close to our waiter friend, right into his personal space, and place a hand delicately, seductively on his chest.

I was just about shocked enough to see her press gently against him, her ample breasts touching against his chest, that I almost wasn't looking up, where she brought her face to his, her lips closing tenderly on his.

What the—

She brought her hand up to press against the side of his neck, and she was sucking on his lips, slowly tilting her head this way and that to explore his mouth—even slipping him a little tongue.

I was stunned, to say the least. I mean, my cock was so hard it almost burst through my pants, but at the same time I felt a powerful loss of control. This was, I had to admit, part of my big age-old sexual fantasy, but to be honest I hadn't entirely expected to feel like this on seeing Courtney actually doing something with another man.

It was hot, of course. The tenderness, the softness of the kiss, the incredible beauty of Courtney making out with this younger guy, closing her eyes and taking what she wanted, stroking the back of his head as she massaged his lips with hers. Rick was startled by her advance, naturally enough, but he didn't object to it. After a moment or two, he was as into it as she was. She was so wicked, so naughty, and it was so very wrong that it turned me on like nothing I'd ever witnessed before.

But I felt suddenly so... emotional. It's hard to describe, but along with the near-painful arousal, the adrenaline scorching through my blood vessels, I felt a real flood of emotions, a totally unexpected mix of feelings I never thought I'd have.

I just sat there and watched them, and felt blind panic take hold of me, raw terror gripping my heart, and an almost overwhelming sense of sorrow—I don't know, that I'd unleashed this, that I'd taken our perfect relationship and somehow ruined it.

Rick was one of those perfect American college guys—trim, athletic, tall, square-jawed and broad-shouldered. He might have stepped straight off the pages of a Gap catalog. I watched him with her and felt envy, and more than a little insecurity. I was out of her league, no question. At least physically. He wasn't.

Somehow I rode the wave of feelings and held fast to the breath-taking excitement inside me. Clinging to the positives, telling myself this was what I wanted, the excitement and risk of my perfect wife set free to explore her sexuality unbound by marriage. My gorgeous wife permitted to become a sexual temptress, a stunning goddess. And I told myself that by doing this, we were ensuring a stronger bond, we weren't risking our relationship.

I just had to forget the part about all Courtney's previous relationships ending in flames.

The two of them broke apart, and Courtney gave him a sultry little smile, looking right in his eyes. Rick went in for another kiss, and my wife obliged.

Then, "Thank you," she said softly, patting his chest as though he were her pet. And she turned to me to smile wickedly, taunting me, teasing me, testing me.

"Uh... have a good night," our waiter said, suddenly remembering himself and where he was, glancing across at me with fear spreading across his pale face.

"You too," I said, acting the calm, amused—and, I suppose, magnanimous—husband who was perhaps very used to his wife's

rebellious antics.

Rick scurried away as I stepped up to Courtney, nodded lightly at her mischievous smirk, then linked my arm in hers and escorted her out of the restaurant.

“You survived?” she said quietly as we went.

“Uh-huh, just about,” I replied.

“So you still want to do this?”

As we went, I kept seeing men all around us glancing up from their tables, looking over from the bar, turning their heads as they walked by—all of them checking Courtney out, wowed by that dress, by her long legs, by the sinuous beauty of her figure.

I drew on the energy, the raw envy being broadcast in my direction, and took strength from it. I even teased her, “You think you can make me jealous by giving some waiter a little kiss?”

She grinned, but like me, was attempting to maintain an outward cool, to mask the real whirl of emotions churning around inside.

“I don’t know... you looked kind of shocked by it,” she said.

“Maybe at first,” I conceded. “I just wasn’t expecting such a sudden move.”

“You think this is just gonna be me putting on sexy clothes from time to time?” she said.

We reached the cloakroom, retrieved our coats, and as Courtney put hers on, I once again saw just how hard her nipples were, straining against the dress. The slight flush over her cheeks, her upper chest. She might be acting out all cool and collected, but this was really getting her going. The tension in the air, the sense of risk and danger and raw uncut excitement was tangible.

Out the door, I said, “You think you can shock me? You’re going to have to try harder than that.”

She laughed. “I don’t know... I think you’re worried already. I think we might have to cool it a little.”

In the darkness outside the restaurant, I pulled her to me, turned her, pressed her up against the wall and kissed her, hard. I breathed her in, I smothered her face with mine, I sucked on her devilish lips, amazed that they’d locked on another man’s mouth mere moments before.

My wife, who hadn’t kissed a soul in seven years other than me.

She was smiling as I kissed her, horny but also somewhat relieved, it seemed, that what she’d done hadn’t revolted me, hadn’t turned me off. She kissed me back as passionately as she had ever kissed me, one hand pulling me into her, the other clinching the back of my head.

Had her lips ever been so sweet? Her body so tempting against mine?

She lifted a leg to wrap around me, and I felt her pulling me against her so she couldn't fail to feel how unbelievably hard I was for her. "Oh God..." she said, breaking our kiss to look me full in the eyes and share her wonder at how turned on I was, at how much I wanted her and she wanted me.

My hands slipped up her dress, taking in the sensational smoothness of her thighs, the lower slopes of her behind, with the full intention of determining once and for all whether she was actually wearing panties tonight.

Then came the disrupting voice behind us: "Taxi for Courtney Haute? Uber?"

And we had to break apart before I could determine anything at all.

I looked at Courtney, and knew that she had plans to go dancing, to see out my birthday in real style. But right now my whole essence was crying out for the opportunity to bed her, given what she'd just gone and done. Stone cold sober, I was never going to enjoy dancing myself.

My wife stepped out from my clutches, her chest heaving with her heavy breaths. "That's me," she said.

The driver smiled, nodded, stepped back to point the way to his anonymous Ford minivan. "Where to?" he asked.

"Home?" Courtney said, looking at me to gauge my reaction.

I nodded. "Home."

She led the way into the taxi. It seemed like a very short journey home, but I certainly found out long before we got there exactly what my wife was wearing under that dress.

Chapter 10

“Hey, honey...” Courtney’s whisper drew me from my dream. Half-opening my eyes, I found her right over me, her soft hair tickling my chest. “I don’t need a ride after work. I’ve got an open clinic today. You know how those things go.”

I did, and while they were long, they’d never been so long that I couldn’t wait around and pick her up a little late. But there was a twinkle in her eye this time, and after she kissed me and crawled off the bed, my sleepy head started to put a few things together.

For one, she was wearing that perfume again—the sweet, exotic perfume, the one I associated with adultery. The other was her lingerie, a bra and panty set constructed on sensual, bright red lace. The panties were a thong—wide banded at the hips before disappearing into her tight, little butt, and while she kept her back to me as she dressed, I got the impression that the bra did wondrous things to her tits.

On top of that went her usual, doctorly clothes—a tight pair of black leggings, a cami, a loose sweater. But the impression of the red bra and panties lingered like a sunspot, long after she’d kissed me goodbye and left for the day.

A week had passed since my birthday and the kiss she’d shared right in front of me with the waiter. We’d gone home and made furious love after that, and while I wanted to ask her if she was thinking about *him* behind her closed eyes, I was too caught up in the fury of my own passion to give voice to it.

The thing I came back to when the sober light of the following days finally found me was Courtney’s confession about her past. She had cheated on every single one of her boyfriends. This was my worst nightmare. I was already insecure about having such a beautiful wife. To hear that she not only had a tendency to stray, but got off on the thrill of it, was devastating—and thrilling—all at the same time. It was like a trap door had opened beneath me, I’d fallen through the floor, and found that I loved the descent.

The situation was different now than back when we were dating, back during the whole Jason incident. Back then, I was so certain I was going to lose her that I nearly lost my mind and did it for her. Now, I was

pretty certain that I wasn't. When she said that she'd put that life behind her, I believed her. Even now, as she teased me and played this game—even kissed a man in front of me—I didn't think these were symptoms of her finding me lacking. It was more like a thrilling bad habit, like a former smoker sneaking a cigarette.

Then again, maybe that's what I wanted to believe. It was safer to assume that I was safe than to think she'd grown bored of me and was looking to move on. Charlie would know, and almost out of the blue, Charlie called me up that very day.

"Hey, sorry I'm so late telling you happy birthday," he said. "Let me make it up to you. You free for dinner tonight?"

I had half a mind to stake out in front of Courtney's clinic just to see why she'd be so late. This was safer. "Sure. Actually it's the perfect night. Court's working late."

We planned on meeting at a steak place downtown and I spent the rest of the day trying *not* to think about Courtney and her red lingerie. I was semi-successful, catching myself thinking about her standing in front of Harry only a few times—every time accompanied by an embarrassingly stubborn erection.

Then I got the message, close to the end of the day.

[Courtney]: Going to grab a drink with a friend. I'll be home a little later.

A friend. Could have been anyone, a fellow doctor, a neighbor, her college roommate in town for the weekend. Or it could be Harry, and the more I thought about it, the more certain I was.

[Me]: Have fun.

My heart raced. My cock was up.

[Courtney]: Yes, sir!

*

"Hey, John. You look like shit."

"Thanks, buddy. Ditto."

"Hey, why you have to be like that?" Charlie said, spreading his arms. A moment later, he pulled me in for a bear hug. "Come on, let's eat some steak."

I was pretty good until the steaks arrived and Charlie finally put me on the spot. "Something's bothering you. Did you talk to her?"

“Yeah. Sort of. We...talked.”

“You’re going to have to work with me a little more, John.”

I cut into the steak, but suddenly lost my appetite for the juicy meat. Adrenaline rushed through me as I stared up at Charlie and realized that I was about to tell him everything. “She told me that she likes...cheating. That she cheated with all her previous boyfriends. She even told me that she stayed with one guy *because* of the cheating more than for him.”

Charlie weathered the confession with a maddeningly unreadable expression. He was back in clinical mode. He said, “And now you’re worried that she’s like that with you?”

“No, ‘worried’ isn’t the right word.” I thought of the kiss, the lingerie, her so-called game. “She’s still like that. I think... I think she’s out with someone *right now*, Charlie.”

“And how does that—” He stopped himself, realizing that he was slipping back into his role as shrink, not friend. “How do you know?”

“I don’t. Not really. But I’m pretty sure. She’s been playing this...game, I guess.” I told him about the black lingerie during the board meeting and all the things she’d told me over my birthday dinner. I even told him about the kiss with the waiter—which he could hardly believe—and the lingerie this morning. Finally, I showed him the last set of texts.

“Okay, this is going to sound like Dr. Charlie, but I promise you, it’s your friend asking.” He took a quick breath. “Why didn’t you go over there and stop her?”

My instant response was to go with humor: *Because I didn’t want to pass up a steak dinner*. I stopped myself short, though. He asked me an honest question, and I needed to give him—and myself—an honest answer. “Because I didn’t want to. Because I want her to go out for a drink with another man.”

“Because—”

“Because it turns me on,” I interrupted.

“And if she went out with someone and ended up sleeping with him tonight?”

I was even expecting it, and the question *still* hit me right between the eyes. But I knew the answer. I’d known it for a long time now. “I’d be even more turned on.”

“Does she know that?” he asked softly.

I shook my head. “I haven’t been able to tell her, and...” An epiphany took shape. I looked at Charlie, wondering if *this* was what he wanted me to figure out for myself. “I don’t want her to know. Part of the

thrill for her is that she's doing something she shouldn't be doing. If she had my permission, it would take some of the excitement away."

Charlie was nodding before I even finished. He did add, though, "You realize that's super fucked up, right? I also happen to know Courtney almost as well as I know you, and I can tell you that she loves you, man. You mean so much to her, and losing you would be devastating."

I knew all of that, but it was nice to hear it validated by someone else. Warmth spread through me. "I feel the same way about her. Which is probably why I'm okay with her doing this. In a fucked up way, it's one of those, 'I'm happy if she's happy' situations."

"You know what I have to tell you, right? Both as a friend and as a doctor?"

"That this isn't going to work?" I offered.

"Not exactly. But you do need to talk to her about this. Sometime. Directly, I mean. Because both of you are operating in the dark right now, and so far that's pretty exciting. But one day, one of you is going to do something that the other didn't want, and that's going to lead to a problem."

"So talk. I get it." I did, but I filed it away for now.

"Happy birthday, man."

"Thanks for talking. And thanks for the steak!"

*

When I got home, I wasn't sure what to expect. Would Courtney be home, or still out on her date? Would I walk in and find her in our bed with another man? As I turned the key in our apartment door, I did so quietly, my heart pounding between my ears.

I opened the door to the sound of soft music playing in the background. My chest tightened. My face burned. The lights in the living room were down low, filtering romantically through the room. I half expected to see some candles on the coffee table, right next to a pair of empty wine glasses.

Instead, I saw Courtney, curled up on the sofa, reading her Kindle beneath a blanket. She was wearing the same sweater she'd had on when she'd left this morning. Looking up at me, she smiled. "Hey, you're home," she said. "No text?"

I hadn't texted because that twisted side of me wanted to walk in on her, and judging from the knowing smile she gave me, she knew my reasoning, too. "I thought you might still be out," I said instead. "Didn't want to disturb that."

Courtney rose off the couch, setting her Kindle on the coffee table. The blanket she'd had on her lap fell away, revealing that she'd taken her leggings off. Her sweater fell to the tops of her thighs, giving her a cute, sexy look—or a supermodel's approximation of what "cute" could be.

"Did you have a nice dinner?" she asked.

"I did. It was good to see Charlie." She stood there, looking amused, and so attractive because of it. "And you? How were drinks?"

Courtney seemed to go somewhere else for a moment, the corners of her lips turning up. "It was fun."

She may as well have reached between my legs and squeezed me. I couldn't just stand there any longer. It was like I'd been restrained, and finally I was free. Stepping close, I pulled her into my arms and kissed her hard, tasting her lips and sliding my tongue along hers.

She met my passion with her own, our embrace tightening, intensifying. My hands dove beneath the sweater, squeezing her bare buttocks before I discovered her thong. Impatiently, I pulled back, grabbed the sweater, and whipped it over her head. Courtney gasped, delighted, as our bodies crashed together once again in passion.

We kissed, dancing awkwardly to the bedroom, leaving a trail of my clothing in our wake. I kicked off my boxers, freeing my steel-hard cock from its confines at last. Courtney caught it, squeezed it, then fell to her knees.

Her dark hair was in a ponytail, leaving the view as she wrapped her lips around my prick completely unobstructed. She kept her eyes trained on me, blue and quivering with lust, as she swallowed inch after inch. I groaned at the sensation, and the illicit thought that maybe, just maybe, this was the second cock she'd sucked today.

Courtney pulled back, looking up at me. "You're so hard," she said, continuing to pump me with her hand.

"I mean, considering the circumstances, can you blame me?" I said lightly.

"So you're considering those circumstances?" she asked. My head rang with her suggestion as she returned to sucking my cock, this time with more aggression than she normally did.

I didn't answer. She knew, anyway. But I also wouldn't last much longer under this onslaught, with that suggestion floating around in my

head. As if sensing my closeness, she sucked down harder, jacking me off in time with each bob. I gnashed my teeth, feeling my balls tighten and my come boil.

“Stop.” I pushed her back and groaned. For a moment, she looked ready to protest. Before she could, I hauled her to her feet and kissed her hard. I was surprised to find that her left hand—her free hand—was crammed down inside of her panties. “Naughty, naughty,” I said.

“You know me,” she said between kisses. “So naughty.”

I turned her around and bent her over the bed. With a yank, I ripped her thong off. Her cry was part glee, part surprise. I wasn’t normally like this with her. We rarely had rough sex. Tonight, I couldn’t hold back.

Before she could regain the upper hand, I placed my cock against her pussy and entered her from behind. “Touch yourself,” I ordered.

With one hand stretched out, clutching the sheets for support, she pushed the other beneath her and did as I told her. I grasped her hips and rammed home, entering her dripping wet cunt. Was she looser than normal? Or was that just how wet she was?

“You feel huge, John,” she moaned.

“And you’re so wet,” I moaned. “Is that for me? Or for whoever you had drinks with?”

At first, she didn’t respond. Not with words. She moaned, shutting her eyes and losing herself in my thrusts. I reached down, grabbing her shoulder, taking control of her body. Using the muscle I’d built over the years of construction, I swung her along my cock with each drive of my hips, the two of us working in tandem as I hit parts of her pussy that I normally couldn’t touch.

“Gah, yes, yes!” she moaned, a mess of sighs and grunts. I slapped her ass and she moaned harder. I did it again, riding her, fucking her, bouncing her on my dick as I thought of her doing this with another man. With a special friend. With Harry Richards. Harry Richards, who wasn’t a name that Courtney had ever mentioned before—not as a friend, not as a boyfriend. He wasn’t one of her three, which meant he was one of her Other Men, one of the guys she’d cheated with. Had she cheated with him tonight?

“Oh, fuck, fuck!” I groaned, exploding inside of her. She tightened beneath me, joining with me in a raw and throaty scream of her own.

She collapsed forward, and I with her, keeping my still hard cock buried deep. We lay there together, catching our breaths, our skin damp and hot. She still wore her bra, I realized, and that made me laugh.

“This new?” I asked, kissing the strap over her shoulder.

“This old thing?” she asked. The twinkle was back. “Yeah. First time I’ve put it on. You like?”

“I like the red.”

She turned onto her side as I reached for the clasp and undid it.

“You get it for me?”

She giggled. “Who else would I be buying sexy lingerie for?”

“You tell me.”

I traced my hand along her bare breasts as she turned over more, lying on her back. I kissed her softly, the rabid passion satiated. For now. She said, “Maybe I needed some confidence today.”

“For?” My fingers traced the outline of her nipples, still hard points. I dipped down and sucked on one, drawing a gasp.

“Lot of men come in during the open clinic. Lot of fit, handsome men,” she teased. “Some of them can be so forward.”

I kept my composure, even as my heart began to beat faster. I traced my hand down further, across her abdomen and along the curve of her waist.

“Did one of them ask you out for a drink?” I asked.

“Oh, they do that all the time,” she said. I gasped. “I’ve never gone...”

“Until tonight?”

She laughed musically. “I didn’t say that.”

“Something got you worked up,” I said, pushing my hand at last down between her thighs.

This time, it was my turn to gasp in shock. Where I expected to find her trim bush, I found nothing but impossibly soft skin. I looked, eyes wide, tracing her lean form to the juncture between her legs, where she was now completely bare.

Courtney opened her legs. “You like it? I had that done today, too.”

I traced her hairless mound with my thumb. “Waxed?”

“Full Brazilian. Isn’t that what you wanted?”

“Yes,” I said tightly. Just me, though? Who had she had drinks with, and had he discovered this, too? But my body didn’t let me linger on the question. My body craved hers. I climbed onto her, my dick hard once again, and sank into her, watching my thickness spread her bald pussy.

“You are a bad, bad girl. Aren’t you, Court?”

Something that could have passed for a yes burst from somewhere deep inside of her. I sawed my cock into her harder, spurred by her cries, by her unintelligible response.

She felt so different, softer, wetter, slicker. How could I have missed it during our first round?

“You like me—uh... you like me—fuck... You like me being bad, don’t you?”

“Fuck, Courtney, you’re so hot!”

“That’s it, baby, fuck Courtney. Fuck your bad, bad girl!”

I pinned her hands above her head and mashed my lips against hers, kissing her as I fucked her, ramming my tongue down her throat like punishment. She struggled. I held her fast, our bodies slapping, the bed rutting against the wall, the world receding to blood-pumping red and muscle-aching fire.

I want you to cheat. I formulated the words in the fire of my mind. I tasted them on my lips. I felt them tighten around my balls. *I want you to fuck someone else, to get that thrill, and then I want you to come back to me so I can remind you why you will ALWAYS come back to me.*

I said none of that. I swallowed it, bottled it up inside, and used that tension to fuel my driving cock. I squeezed her wrists above her head until she cried out, until she rocked her body up and into me in wild ecstasy. “Oh, baby! Oh baby, come! Come!” she screamed.

I roared something I couldn’t understand. My balls burst, yet I kept thrusting, faster, harder, deeper. She was with her lover. She was getting filled by his thick, forbidden cock, and I came with them.

In the come down, I felt like rubber, my brain mush.

“Guess you like the new look,” she said with a tired chuckle.

“You going to keep it?”

“With the kind of response I’ve gotten? How could I not?”

The kind of response I’ve gotten. Like there were multiple. It was a line designed to tease, to get my jealous hackles up. Or maybe it was a slip of her own tongue in the haziness of her climax.

I fell asleep, not sure which it was, but happy with the ambiguity.

Chapter 11

When Courtney woke up before me, and dressed in sexy underwear for work, that was like the Bat Signal for us.

It didn't happen every day, didn't happen every week, but it was relatively frequent back then—Courtney said it was because she was having a lot of business meetings, a lot of financial stuff to do with the extra clinic days she was pushing for, and she needed the extra confidence. I knew she was just horny, and wanted me thinking about her in lingerie all day, and the possibility that she might flirt with someone at work, or maybe more. So I'd be extra hard when she came home.

What can I say, it was sweet. We seemed closer as a couple, Courtney seemed happier and more confident in her life, and I gradually stopped worrying about her actually doing something behind my back without telling me, and the possibility of losing her.

I even stopped thinking about Harry Richards.

I was confident, I was happy, I was getting regular attention from the hottest woman on God's earth. She'd drop little hints here and there, make up stories, create little role-play scenarios where I might get jealous, and I'd lock on to her role-playing and ramp up the testosterone, culminating in ferocious sex.

Yet after a while I came to expect that any little suggestion that Courtney was cheating on me, or might be planning to cheat on me, was merely that: a suggestion. Every time something came up, deep down I would tell myself it was okay, she was just fooling around, she was just playing our game.

It was safe.

Looking back, I can recognize that she pretty much sign-posted the whole jealousy experience for me. She'd make sure I was awake enough in the early morning to notice her dressing in sexy underwear. She'd drop little clues exactly where she knew I'd find them. She presented me with confessions after one of her nights out without me, laying everything out for me in easily digestible form.

I'd completely given up being suspicious of her. That stalker-like behavior I'd presented after Harry Richards came back into her life, that had completely vanished. I trusted her, knew what she was up to, so there

really wasn't any sneaking around to be done. Any doubts I had about her were dispelled.

"I have to hand it to you, all this has you relaxed and self-assured and way less paranoid than I've ever seen you," Charlie said over another one of our regular get-togethers, which always seemed to happen in bars owned by his grateful client.

I cracked a broad smile. "I feel like I don't need to worry about her running off with another guy. Because what other guy is going to allow her this damn fantasy?"

"There are men out there of like mind," Charlie warned. "I've read up on it a little recently. Trying to figure you out."

"Oh, yeah?"

He laughed, "It's why I'm willing to step back and not conspire to get you committed."

"Well," I shrugged, "I guess I'm saying I can see a little more why she's with me, why she still finds me... you know... desirable."

"So where's she tonight?"

"Girls' night out."

Charlie raised an eyebrow. "Girls' night out? Since when does Courtney go on girls' nights out?" he said. "She always had guy friends, and work friends... but not really girlfriends."

"She's good friends with Liz, isn't she?" I said, but I knew Charlie had a point.

"Liz is babysitting for her sister tonight, she's not out on any kind of girls' night out," he said dryly.

"As far as you know," I teased him. Then I added, "I don't know... she reconnected with some of her college friends on Facebook. One of them had a baby shower, which she went reluctantly... but then... you know, she suddenly felt she had lots in common with them, so..."

"Uh-huh," Charlie was sipping his drink and looking at me as though he were my shrink again, not my friend. "And this group of college buddies, now they go out once a week... she doesn't really tell you where... she turns off her phone while she's out with them..."

I merely laughed at him. "I don't keep her on a short leash, you know. She can do as she likes..."

"Don't tell me, sometimes she disappears for hours at a time and tells you she's been shopping... but she doesn't always come back with any actual purchases..."

I rolled my eyes at him. "Hey, she's just discovering the whole work-life balance thing, and that fact that ever since college she's been

on the wrong side of it.”

“You have to be to be a damn doctor,” he said. “I should know.”

“Well, now she’s in a position to redress the balance a little. Relax, let her hair down.”

“And you’re actually hoping she’ll... cheat?”

I shrugged. “If she’s in danger of doing it... I don’t think I’m so worried any more. I think she knows that if anything happened... she’d only have to tell me about it, and... we’d reconnect.”

Charlie sighed. “Women aren’t always like that, buddy. People aren’t always like that. It’s clear her social patterns have been changing recently, and that’s sometimes—often—a sign of marital problems. Adultery. She might think you’re on board, but she might doubt you. Or she might meet someone who makes her forget about you.”

“It’s not like that,” I said.

He nodded. Drank a toast to Courtney and I. “I know you both, I’m sure she’d never do anything like that to you.”

But something in his tone troubled me. I don’t know if it was the genuine sense that he believed Courtney might damage our relationship, or if he simply continued to quietly disapprove of what we were doing, how easy I was making it for Courtney, or possibly how Courtney might be exploiting this strange desire I happened to hold just now.

But she’d had plenty of girls’ nights out since that baby shower, and I was completely trusting in her. She’d come back and tell me if any guys hit on her, if she’d ended up dancing with anyone, if anyone had given her their number.

She knew any of that would get me going, and she liked to impart that kind of information when she got home. She made it look as though she would have wanted to take things further, but it was difficult when she was actually out with a bunch of college buddies, who were Facebook buddies as well.

I’d encouraged her to flirt, to chat, to even dance with other guys if ever she got the chance, and she knew how I’d respond if anything like that actually happened. So why wouldn’t she tell me if some guy ended up making out with her?

It was this game of ours. The girls’ nights out were merely another way she could play the jealousy game, another way she could get out of the apartment for an evening, take her new social freedom for a ride, and continue the thrill ride our sex lives had become when she got back.

No matter how much I described this situation as perfect for me, that night Charlie parted ways with me with an uneasy expression on his

face.

“What?” I said to him, with an awkward laugh. “You don’t believe me, do you? That I really want this.”

He pursed his lips. “I just think... you’ve created a protection mechanism for yourself, man. Only, rather than just protect yourself in the event of her cheating... you’re pushing her to do it.”

“It’s really not like that,” I said, but underneath I kind of felt there was more than an ounce or two of truth in what he said.

“Okay,” he nodded. “Look, I’m happy for you, buddy. It’s not always easy to keep a marriage going strong, even if you seem perfect for each other. Sacrifices have to be made somewhere.”

I returned home after bidding farewell to Charlie, and Courtney was still out with her friends.

As usual, I’d be pleased she was still out—the later she was out, it seemed to me, the higher the chance that she might misbehave while she was out. So I cheerfully fixed a late-night snack, watched a little late-night TV, and then wandered through to the bedroom to settle down for the night.

In the bedroom, there were dresses and various articles of underwear strewn all over the bed, from when she must have come home after work to get changed for her night out. From the looks of things, she’d been going for tight dresses that didn’t cover much. The underwear she’d been considering was all fairly skimpy, lacy stuff.

And then as I shifted the dresses back into the wardrobe, and her underwear back into her underwear drawer in order to free up some space on the bed so I could actually get some sleep, underneath there was something that really took my breath away.

A big box of Trojan condoms.

Wow. Now, I know she could have stashed this box on our bed where I’d be bound to discover them when I came home and wanted to go to sleep. But somehow it didn’t seem like something she’d think to do in order to make me jealous.

“Seriously... condoms are like the least sexy things in the world...” I could imagine her saying.

My heart was thumping hard as I picked up the box. Trojan Bareskin. “Get Closer”. “Our thinnest condoms ever”. Yet as I saw that the box was open, and that three of them were missing, I was hard as granite, adrenaline racing around my body like fire in a paper factory.

Were we really at the stage where Courtney would go out taking condoms with her? Jesus. Perhaps we were.

Oh, maybe it was just another part of the game. But this wasn't kissing a waiter. This was potentially going out with a view to ending up fucking a stranger. It terrified me, even if it was darkly arousing. Would it be cheating if something happened? I guess technically I wouldn't know about it until after it happened. I'd dropped hints that I'd be able to cope with her cheating, though. If she was genuinely tempted, she'd have reason to go for it.

I just didn't like the idea of her hiding anything from me. What if she came home and said nothing had happened, when it had? I just had to hang on to the idea that she had no reason to lie, no reason to cover anything up. I was baying for her to go further and further in trying to make me jealous.

Finally, around 2am, a text message from Courtney.

[Courtney]: On my way home, sweetie! It turned into a late one ;-)

I didn't know what to say in reply. Tell her I'd found her box of condoms? Ask her if she'd used all three she'd taken with her?

It was exciting to think that she might have used even just one. And yet troubling, too. We hadn't actually talked about her genuinely cheating. Though I wanted it, I'd been too nervous about bringing up the subject, too nervous about what would happen if we went for it.

What if it had happened tonight? She'd forced the issue. I felt an enormous rush of nervous energy to think that it might already have happened, my wife was already unfaithful.

I sent her no text in reply. Indecision turned into the thought that at 2am I ought to be asleep. I didn't want to give her the impression I'd been up all night worrying about where she was, and who she was with.

I lay in bed and waited, my heart pounding. And when, eventually, I heard the front door closing, I pretended to be asleep. Sure, I didn't normally fall asleep on my back, but who cared about that?

I could still see her come into the bedroom through almost-closed eyes. She dropped her coat over the chair by her dresser, to reveal the little black and silver dress that must have turned a fair few heads that night.

She was smiling at the fact I'd apparently fallen asleep, but she obviously wasn't in the mood to simply fall asleep next to me, or else she would have taken a shower, or at least washed and brushed her teeth. Instead, she climbed onto the bed like a panther stalking its prey. Crawled up the bed to straddle me, to lie over me, to kiss my mouth.

I couldn't fail to smile as she kissed me. Her lips were so sweet, tinged by some kind of fruity alcohol. Cocktails, no doubt. As she kissed

me I was engulfed by a cloud of her exotic perfume, the one she didn't normally use, especially not for me. Only, the thing was, it smelled slightly different than the last time. I couldn't put my finger on what it was...

"Hey, honey..." I said, in a fake sleepy voice. "What time is it?"

"Hey sweetie. Nearly 3am, I guess... sorry I was so late." She just went on kissing me, as though it meant I couldn't be mad at her for being out so late.

I kissed her back, and suddenly realized that the difference in her smell was because I could detect a man's cologne on her.

My God.

I felt a surge of intense heat bloom inside my chest. Had it happened? Had she done it? Had she fucked some stranger she'd met at a club?

I tried to act calm. "You had fun?" I asked her. "I thought you must have... met someone... or something..."

She smiled as we kissed, and yanked the bed sheets out from under her, so she could sit on my seriously hard cock.

"Mmm..." she said as she ground herself down on my stiff shaft. "You like thinking about me meeting someone, huh?"

"What happened?"

"I met lots of people, actually. Lots of guys..."

She held the side of my neck as she kissed me forcefully, stroking me with warm affection. I breathed in her scent: she must have tried to apply a fresh burst of perfume over the male cologne, but she'd failed to entirely cover it up.

It was intense, a little overwhelming for me. She'd been with someone, even if she'd only made out with them. It made my manhood throb to think about it, but it wasn't the jealousy that I felt most: it was the sense that Courtney must have had a really good time, and that above all made me happy. I wanted her to have the excitement of being single again, even if she was obligated to come back to me afterward. I liked that she'd had a little naughty fun.

"You were dancing?" I asked her.

"Uh-huh." She kissed down my neck, and over my upper chest.

I reached down, my hands gliding over her back, down to the smooth skin of her thighs, then up again, pushing up her dress. I caught my breath as I found she was wearing no underwear. And yet I hadn't seen her dropping her panties as she'd come into the room—just her coat.

“What happened to your underwear?” I asked her.

“I don’t really know,” she giggled, sitting up on me. “Things got fairly intense on the dance floor toward the end of the night.”

I raised my eyebrows at that. “This club... it wasn’t at the Playboy Mansion, was it?”

She laughed. “No, nothing like that. But some of the guys I was dancing with were getting awfully friendly...”

I felt her wiggle her hips over me, crushing my erection having doubtless felt it throbbing as I contemplated the idea of her dancing up close to various men, letting them put their hands all over her. To the extent that she’d lost her panties.

I sat up, wrapping my arms around her waist, kissing my way down her ample cleavage, where the scent of male cologne only strengthened.

“They were... touching you?...making out with you?” I asked between kisses.

She laughed. “Maybe.”

“You liked it?”

“Oh, I had the best time... and there was one guy... later on... oh, honey, I hope you’re not upset with me...” Courtney suddenly turned on her little girl lost demeanor, sexy but vulnerable, seductive but regretful, concerned about what I might say.

“What happened?” I said, trying to suppress the shock I felt at Courtney for being so bold in this game of ours.

“I guess... my friends were getting tired... so they went home... only, I wanted to stay and dance...”

Gulp. So she’d lost the monitoring facility of her college buddies. No wonder something had happened.

“What happened?” I said, a little more gruffly than I meant.

“There was a guy... Russell... we were having such a good time... dancing up close... holding each other... I could feel his... thing... pressing against me...”

“What happened?”

She pushed me down on the bed, and said: “Are you angry with me? Sweetie? I think I took things a little too far... I didn’t mean to... it was the heat of the moment...”

“It’s okay,” I said, feeling my throat drying up, finding it difficult to talk.

Courtney pushed herself down on my cock, and she must have known how unbelievably hard it was, she must have felt how I was really thinking about her confession.

She said, "We left the dance floor for a break, for a drink of water... and I guess we ended up in a dark corner... he was kissing me..."

Oh Jesus, it did make me want her more. I pulled her down for another kiss of her mouth, and I was sucking on her lips, so taken by the fact that another man had been here before me, in my place.

She pulled away at last, and, breathless, said, "I... I didn't mean for anything to happen..."

"What happened?" I said again. "Tell me."

"He was pressing me up against the wall... I could feel his... his thing... his dick... pressing against me... He was so big, honey..."

"What happened?"

She seemed frightened, but the way I held her thighs firmly, looked up at her so intently, she knew she had to tell me. "He... he asked me if I had any condoms..." she said. "I don't know... I guess I'd been drinking... a lot... and with everything we've talked about... I said I did..."

Lying there under her, I felt my world reeling, shaking, rocking. My stomach was folding in on itself, my heart was just about ready to burst out of my chest. And yet the adrenaline, the arousal... it was insane.

"And you actually did?" I asked her. "You had condoms with you?"

She shrugged her shoulders, looking dejected, apologetic, pitiful. "With everything we've been talking about..." she said, as though our jealousy game explained everything. I guess it could to some extent.

"You fucked him?" I asked her.

"I... I couldn't help it..." she said. "I don't know... he... he broke down my resistance... I thought... maybe you wouldn't mind so much..."

Was she genuinely scared I'd be angry at her? Was she really worried that I might end things between us, now that this had happened? If she wasn't, she was a good actress.

But lying there on my back, I looked up at her, naked other than this tiny slip of a dress, and saw only Aphrodite personified. I'd never wanted her more.

I dipped my hands under her thighs and circled my arms under her, then pulled her up my body until she was over my head. Courtney let out a little squeal of surprise, but then saw where I was going with this.

"Oh John..." she moaned, as I encouraged her to find a comfortable position over me.

I held her bare buttocks as I pulled her down onto my mouth. The view was just stunning, and in a way startling since I wasn't yet used to Courtney after her full Brazilian.

Only, this was her after sex with another man. Her pussy lips were reddened, puffy, glistening—and if I wasn't mistaken, open. I'm sure she wasn't like this after she'd been with me: her pussy had been stretched, I swear it.

Her guy must have been truly huge.

There between her thighs I breathed deeply, inhaling the scent of fresh sex. It made me tremble, melt a little inside. I lapped at her sheen of juices and the buzz I felt inside from what I was doing was almost overwhelming. Sucking on her, slipping my tongue inside her after another man had fucked her right here. And somehow, the little tang from the latex condom made it seem that much hotter, that much more real.

She was so wet, she was dripping down my cheeks as I ate her. It was magnificent.

“Oh... Jesus, John... oh my God... oh my God...”

I think the sheer force of my hunger for her after this act of infidelity astonished her. I guess the strength of the feelings, the force of the craving I now had for her somewhat took me by surprise, too. Oh, the jealousy had added a touch of spice to our relationship, a piquancy to our sex. But adultery leant it real fire, explosive energy.

She let me enjoy her, let me savor her, gazing down on me, gently stroking my hair as I tasted her, holding up her dress as she cupped her breasts so I could see all the way up her trim body.

Then she was pressing down on me, no longer letting me take the lead, no longer letting me explore her unfaithful pussy—now she was using me, gyrating her hips to grind her sex over my mouth, to take what she wanted from me, to provide the release from me that my comparatively gentle sucking had promised.

I loved it, it felt so dirty, and so intimate, rubbing my face in her adultery, gazing up at her as she panted and writhed and rocked and cried out. And her Brazilian wax-job, well that did make it easier on me.

I reached around to stroke her clit as the mad frantic energy of her climax approached, and then she was leaning over me, grabbing my head with both hands, pressing her hot body all around it, and she shook, shuddered, screamed.

It wasn't just Courtney getting off on my adrenaline-driven technique, this was my wife turned on by my response to her infidelity. This was my wife made to come hard by just how much I wanted her after her evening's transgression. This was my wife's thermonuclear explosion triggered by the certain knowledge that I wanted her to explore her sexuality, I wanted her to have fun with other guys.

This was her knowing I wanted her to cheat on me, so long as I got to share in the details afterward.

“Jesus... Jesus... Jesus...” she was whispering once she came down from her high peak.

She shuffled back down my body, kissed my mouth, just held me for a while.

I said, “I can tell...”

“You can tell?”

“He was inside you.”

Still panting for breath, she brushed her long dark locks out of the way of her face, kissed me as though to apologize for my knowing. But then she pressed her body down on me, crushing her breasts against my chest, her sex against my hardness—and she caught her breath at just how hard I was.

“John... sweetie... you’re *enormous*...” she said, in awe it seemed.

“I guess I like it when someone warms you up for me,” I smiled.

She grinned, but still seemed amazed at me, surprised at this. She reached down to slip my cock inside her, and I very nearly ended things right there.

Yet I just managed to hold it together. She rocked her hips over me, taking advantage of her copious wetness, and my rock hard erection, quickly ramping up to a lively pace. She rode me hard, gasping for air, her body flushed with the effort, both our bodies glistening in perspiration.

I grabbed her, rolled her over, plunged back into her and just owned her, smothering her body with mine, embracing her tightly in my arms, gazing into her eyes as I took her, as I reclaimed her.

“Tell me,” I growled as I fucked her. “Tell me how good he was...”

“Oh Jesus... he was good... honey... he fucked me so good...” She knew what to say to me, she knew which buttons to press. She took us both over the edge as she moaned in my ear, “He fucked me against the wall... then he turned me round and fucked me like a dog... oh honey... it was so incredible... he had the biggest dick I’ve ever seen... he filled me up so good... he made me come so hard...”

She raised her legs, pulling her knees up under her chin as I fucked her, locking her thighs together to make herself tighter for me—acknowledging, perhaps, that her first lover of the evening had stretched her.

Along with her dirty talk, that seemed to be the straw that broke the camel’s back, the thought that whoever her stranger had been, he’d

stretched my wife's pussy that night.

With that, I squeezed her body tight and flinched—once, twice, three times... my hips spasming as my climax hit, and my cock bucked to fire thick white cream deep inside her adulterous pussy.

“Oh... come in me... come in me... come in me...” she gasped, and her second orgasm of the hour came along quickly.

Wow. Just incredible.

And afterwards we just held each other, speechless, sucking in oxygen to help our depleted muscles recover, both of us seeming astounded at the other one.

I held my wife and thought about how strange it was, what we had done, what she had done. What she now was to me. I adored her still, and I only wanted her more.

That came as strong relief to me as we drifted off to sleep in each other's arms.

It seemed the final confirmation that despite all my paranoia, I wasn't going to suddenly hate her for fulfilling my own personal sex fantasy, I wasn't going to have a sudden change of heart about her infidelity. In fact, I only wanted her to continue it.

The relief seemed almost to come more from my own lack of anger and revulsion at what she'd done than from the sense that even though she'd had wild sex out with some big-dick stranger, she still wanted to come home to me, she still had ground-shaking sex with her husband.

*

I think that sheer sense of relief even tided me over when, later that night, I awoke and hauled myself out of bed to pay a brief visit to the bathroom. It meant I didn't mind so much when I saw her handbag lying there by the sink, and there inside it was a large—very large—dildo onto which she'd placed a condom.

I was shocked, sure. But my disappointment was actually tempered by the almost certain feeling that this had been a real test, perhaps even the final test. Courtney had wanted to know how I'd feel to really honestly believe she had cheated.

Now, it seemed, she was ready to do it for real.

Chapter 12

I struggled getting back to sleep that night, then struggled through the weekend, bouncing between feeling relieved and nervous. The game was now on. She knew she had permission. *I* knew she had permission. Question was, now that we knew what we knew, what came next?

I kept going back to the dildo in her bag, a prop set up so perfectly that she had to know that I'd find it—if not when I did, then in the morning. It was as if she'd winked at me and said, *Just kidding*. If that was where this thing ended, if that was as far as she was willing to go—games, teases, clever setups—I should have been fine with that, right? I should have been fine with it. I had a super-hot wife, smart and successful and, for some reason, devoted to me. What more did I want?

But I *did* want more. I wanted her to go through with it, and if all she did was tease me, it was almost as toxic as if she'd done it behind my back. Strange to think you could feel so betrayed by, literally, *not* being betrayed.

Looking back on it now, in some ways, it might be responsible for what came next. It was at that moment that I decided that I needed to talk to Harry Richards.

*

Getting in touch with the man proved harder than I would have expected. My initial thought was to wait for him outside the clinic—the only place that I knew he'd been before. Of course, that was problematic because, for one, I didn't know when his appointments were, and for that matter, whether he was still seeing Courtney at all. And two, I couldn't exactly just skip work to stake out my wife's place of business. My current flip project was nearly complete and I needed to be onsite for the finishing touches, no matter how good my guys had become.

I did have a name, first and last, and the Internet, which opened a world of possibility for the amateur stalker such as myself.

His LinkedIn page was the first thing to pop up—and the most reliable since a professional photo was attached. He was still on active duty in the Air Force, working out of a military base outside of the city. I wouldn't be able to reliably follow him from there or I'd risk getting arrested. He'd earned some medals and accolades while serving in Afghanistan, and seemed like a real G.I. Joe. I second guessed my plan—but only just.

Facebook was the next stop on my journey through Harry's life. Again, there were photos to confirm that I had the right guy. He didn't post much, although a man like that didn't seem like the type to report out the minutiae of his life. He did post photos, though, and was tagged in plenty—most of them with other women. I held my breath, looking—hoping?—to find Courtney in one of them, but never did.

What did show up, fairly consistently, was a bar—June's. I knew the one. Sports bar, built on the ground floor of a mixed use building in one of the trendier neighborhoods of the city. Judging from the photos, he was a regular.

I had a place, at least, and a general time, based on his job. Now all it took was patience and, more importantly, courage. My first trip to June's, leaving just after work, was short-lived. I went in, ordered a Miller Light, took in the ambiance—the place was wide and open with exposed brick columns and televisions everywhere—and then left. Quickly. This was not a good idea, and my plan was half-baked at best.

When I went back there on Friday, my plan was still half-baked, but I'd had more time to convince myself that it was the right thing to do. I sat down on a stool—a little earlier than the usual knock-off time—and stationed myself at a spot at the bar with a good view of the doors. Again, I ordered a beer, and again, I considered running.

This time, however, Harry came through the doors before I could. He wore a golf shirt tucked into a pair of pressed khakis—his form of casual Friday, apparently—and a pair of aviators that robbed me of the chance to see if he recognized me. We'd met once, months ago, after a happy hour, and while his face was etched into my mind, I couldn't count on the same being said for mine.

He took his sunglasses off and strolled up to a free spot at the bar. Apparently he didn't recognize me after all. I let him order his beer—apparently he was alone tonight, at least for now—before scooping up my own pint and sliding into the seat beside him. I was happy to have the head start, because the half-pint of beer helped calm my spiking nerves.

“Hello,” I said.

“Hey,” he said, one stranger to another, doing a double take when he saw me. He still couldn’t place me, but I could see him trying. That uncertainty gave me the nerve to plunge forward.

“I’m Courtney’s husband, John. We met a while ago, at Urbana?”

I watched his face very carefully, watched his body language. The way he reacted to my revelation was extremely important—one of the main reasons that I was even here. When his eyes went wide and he swallowed a short, nervous gasp, I went queasy, my stomach swimming with nerves. Had something been going on, after all?

The reaction was gone in a flash, replaced by grit and bravado.

“Hey, John. Sorry, didn’t recognize you. You’re out of your way, aren’t you?”

He pressed the offense, just a little. I wasn’t exactly expecting it, but should have been, considering the kind of guy I knew him to be.

“Actually, I’m here because I wanted to talk to you.”

I made sure that my smile was laced with just enough threat to wipe away his facade of confidence. That it did helped fuel my own.

“Yeah?” he said uncertainly.

“Yes.”

Here’s where my half-baked plan came in. I’d come here to try and learn more about Courtney and her past—about her relationship with this man, and vaguely, maybe convince him to make a play for her now. If she wasn’t going to go through with it, then maybe I could give her a little encouragement.

But reading the moment, I decided to take a big risk. “I know, Harry. I know about you and Court.”

Again, I saw Harry flinch. Again, the confirmation hit me in the gut. He licked his lips. “She told you, did she?” He chuckled sardonically to himself. “And here I thought she really *had* changed.” Again, I got the impression that that was for him.

I had no clue what he was talking about, and my heart was racing because of that. What had she supposedly told me—which actually meant what *hadn’t* she told me?

I let him sweat, staying silent until he cracked. He took a heavy pull on his beer, then grimaced, like it tasted bad, drawing his lips back to bare his clenched teeth.

“Look, I told her that meeting in a hotel room was probably a bad idea, given her... you know... her tendencies.” He glanced at me, as if to confirm that I knew about those.

I nodded, because acknowledging that was the easiest thing to do. Because nodding helped me keep my composure as I tried to keep up with what he was telling me. She'd been in a hotel room with this man and done something with him that he'd hoped she wouldn't tell me. Only I couldn't just come out and ask him what because he thought that I knew.

That said, I did need to say *something*. He was looking at me, expecting it. Panic spiraled around me as I floundered for something to say, feeling myself lose my edge. I put myself in Harry's shoes and went back on the offensive again. "Not just her tendencies. You two have history."

Harry grimaced, but nodded—one more thing confirmed. "Hey, you know the score. When someone as hot as Court comes knocking, it's hard to turn that away."

I shifted on the stool, wishing I could adjust the direction of my cock, where it pressed down the leg of my pants. He went on, "Courtney was always down to fuck. I figured that that's really why she'd set up the hotel room appointments, so I just went for it."

I licked my lips, nodding. Went for it? I really, really wanted to ask what he meant by "it" in this case. Instead, I just stared.

"Judging from the fact that you haven't punched me in the face, I'm guessing you're like all of her other guys."

"Other guys?" The question just slipped out, admitting my ignorance for the first time. Harry didn't seem to process it.

"I never understood that. What makes you tick? How can you have someone like Courtney and be cool sharing her?"

There was an implied judgment there, an insult wrapped up in the question. He might as well have asked, *Are you too enthralled by her that you'll let her walk all over you?*

I found my grit again. It rose on a swell of adrenaline so powerful I felt my body begin to quake. "At the end of the day, she will always come back to me."

I was ready for him to get into my face, for this to come to blows. I wasn't the kind of guy who got into fist fights, but with all the testosterone surging through my blood, I could pretend to be. Instead, I was surprised when Harry sighed and sank into his beer. Without looking at me, he said, "We done here?"

The taste of victory turned to ash. The adrenaline faded. I returned to the man that I was when I'd walked in here, uncertain and confused and yet ready for something crazy. "I'm sorry about that," I said.

“You’re sorry?” He snorted. “I’m the one who should be sorry, right? I’m the one who tried to fuck your wife.”

“Tried” and “fuck” and “wife” assaulted me, throwing things sideways for a moment once again. In that dizzy, reeling state, I failed to keep quiet, hearing myself talk more than actually processing the words. “I didn’t come here looking for an apology, Harry. I just wanted to hear your side of it.”

He crawled out of whatever funk he’d descended into. “You wanted to double check with me that this wasn’t another Jason situation,” he said, slowly putting the pieces of a puzzle together that I didn’t even know about. “You wanted to check that it really was me making the moves, not Courtney.”

“Jason?” I asked, once again forgetting myself, once again showing my ignorant hand. Jason, who’d driven me to seek out Charlie. Jason, who had practically ended my relationship with Courtney in its infancy. Jason, who was probably the root of my wife-sharing fantasy. What did he have to do with it?

“Oh, you didn’t know, did you?” Harry seemed to feed off my confusion, drinking in the confidence that bled away from me. “I’m sorry, I shouldn’t have said anything.”

“Tell me.” I felt bloodless. My gut churned.

“Sorry, man, but I can’t do that. You’re going to need to talk to your wife about that one.” He pulled out some cash, tossing it onto the bar. “I’ll cover your beer. Sorry to be the bearer of bad news.” He put his hand on my shoulder, although when I met his eyes, there was more compassion than I’d been expecting. “Or maybe this is good news, eh?”

He left, leaving me alone to unpack some complicated emotions. She’d cheated—way back when I thought that she *hadn’t* cheated. And she *hadn’t* cheated in the present, when I briefly thought that she had. I swung between relieved and betrayed, devastated and weirdly reassured.

When I finally got out of there, I still had no idea what to make of the night, other than that I needed to get home and fuck the hell out of my wife.

Chapter 13

On my way home, I was so very tempted to call up Charlie and tell him “I told you so!”. But to be honest, I was so confused, so angry and disappointed and excited and oh-so-god-damn turned on, I didn’t know how it would have come out. I’d probably have ended up ruining our friendship.

So it was just me, on my own, stuck in the back of a taxi thinking about how I could have been so dumb—to let Courtney lead me on at the time, to feel like there had been something desperately wrong with me when she’d denied having an affair. To fall for the evidence she’d ultimately provided to prove there had been no affair.

My head was whirling round and round by the time I got back to our apartment building, tore through the lobby and into the elevator.

When I got inside the door, Courtney was waiting for me by the windows, wearing nothing but seriously sexy underwear—black garters and stockings, black bra, tiny little black g-string. As though she could distract me from my anger, as though she could seduce me out of my disappointment. As though she could persuade my prick that there was nothing to worry about.

“I just had a drink with Harry Richards,” I said, a trifle breathless after my great rush up here.

“Seriously?”

“He told me... a few interesting things.”

“Like?” she put her hands on her hips, a touch surprised that I wasn’t just coming into the apartment and sweeping her up in my arms, I guess.

“Like... that you really did cheat on me with Jason.”

“Jason...” she wrinkled her brow. “Back when we were still dating? Jesus, John, I thought we were past that. I thought we were way past that...”

I felt my stomach crushed at what she said. It wasn’t a denial. It was a plea for a statute of limitations.

“You lied to me.”

She walked toward me, leaned up against the kitchen island. “I didn’t lie to you. I never did anything with Jason. He was a friend. He

was a work colleague. He had a few personal problems, he needed a shoulder to cry on. That's it."

"He needed a beautiful woman to fuck after his wife left him."

She heaved a huge melodramatic sigh, glanced down at the floor for a moment. "Look. I don't know what to say... and here we are, and I thought you actually wanted me to cheat on you right now."

"I don't want you to lie about it."

"I haven't lied! I swear!"

"You can tell me the truth, Court. I'm not going to be angry..."

"You seem pretty angry..." she pouted.

"I'm... I just... I don't know what to think any more."

"You want me to cheat on you. So what does it matter to you whether I cheat on you now, or I cheated on you then?"

"So you did cheat on me."

She sighed. "No, I was just giving you a hypothetical."

"Look. I just want you to be honest with me."

"I am being honest with you. I never slept with Jason. Harry Richards is just filling your head with... with shit..."

"What reason would he have to lie to me?" I said, but part of me could already answer my own question. The way he'd seemed so disappointed at the bar, so dejected, by trying and failing to bed my wife.

"He has every reason to lie to you," she said. "He wants to end our marriage. Before you came along... he had me whenever he wanted—"

"But now he sees you pretty frequently, doesn't he? At the clinic... in various hotels..."

"Have you been... keeping tabs on me? After what happened last time?"

"After I saw you with him that night... I wondered about you."

"So you get all creepy about it again? I'm not sure I get you, John. You get turned on by all this. You say you even want me to cheat on you. But you sound like you've been... stalking me..."

"I just wanted to know why you'd do everything possible to make me jealous—but you never once mentioned one of your exes was back in town. That you've been seeing him regularly."

She rolled her eyes. "He's one of my patients. I've been treating him confidentially for a shoulder injury, that's all."

I said angrily, "Doctors don't make appointments in hotels to treat their patients confidentially."

She huffed. "You don't understand."

I shook my head, replied sharply: “You don’t understand. I’m saying I like the idea of you seeing other guys—with only one condition. You tell me the truth. You hide nothing.”

“I. Am. Telling. The. Truth,” she said.

“Okay,” I nodded. “But sometimes you tell me things, and it turns out you were playing a game, right? I discover a dildo you used to fake sex with another man...”

She sighed again. “I was making absolutely sure you would be okay with it...”

“You could have told me immediately afterward that you were faking it.”

“So what you’re saying now is that you believe the word of Harry Richards—a stranger—rather than your own wife.”

I sighed. “I’m not saying that... I just... He wouldn’t have any reason to lie to me.”

“I’ve told you, haven’t I? He wants to fuck me!”

I said, “And if he just came out and told me that, I’d probably say it would be okay. So why does he need to lie?”

Courtney looked at me with pure venom in her eyes. Kind of terrifying. I think if I wasn’t jacked up on adrenaline, and the raw heat of anger, I might have been seriously afraid I was in the process of losing her. But anger isn’t rational, it clouds your judgment.

She said to me: “Maybe I should go fuck him, then. Get it over with. Then you know once and for all what it’s like to have a cheating wife—and he’ll finally have no reason to lie to you. You’ll find out I’ve been telling you the truth all along.”

There was a slight pause. Oh so slight. And yet it felt as though a huge chasm had opened up between us. Courtney was being pulled back away from me by some unseen force. My heart was so loud, I wondered if she could hear it. My stomach was so queasy, I could barely hold myself still. My cock was so hard it was straining against my pants.

I said quietly: “Maybe you should.”

She breathed out, then gave a very small nod. She wheeled on the balls of her feet and walked away from me, directly to the door. Grabbed her keys and her little coat on the way out.

And she was gone.

Headed for Harry Richards, wearing nothing but sexy underwear under a coat that only just covered the tops of her thighs.

*

I stood there in the silent apartment for a moment or two, stunned.

Then I felt my stomach drop to my shoes, as though I was in some high-speed elevator soaring up a seriously tall building very, very fast.

Jesus, she'd been right. She had to be. Why would she lie to me when I'd already basically given the green light for her to experiment with adultery again?

If everything Courtney had said was true—and she was right, of course, I should have trusted my wife over a stranger any day, particularly if said stranger did have an agenda—then she was still whiter than white. She had given up her adulterous ways before meeting me, she had remained true throughout our relationship. Even if the temptation had been immense.

But I had now pushed her into the arms of the lying bastard who had just set me up in order to steal my beautiful wife from me.

Harry Richards had connived to undermine my trust in Courtney, and it had totally worked. Now she was angry and going to him, to actually sleep with him.

God, the mere thought of that man now brought a white-hot rage to my heart, made me want to punch walls and shout until I was hoarse.

And yet I did not lift my phone, did not tap in her number, did not apologize profusely and admit she'd been right and I'd been wrong. I did not stop her. I did not beg her not to go through with her threat to cheat on me with him.

I waited. I felt the excitement fluttering in my chest, the warm, hard presence between my legs, pressing to be released from my pants.

I wanted her to cheat on me. I wanted her to do it with him, even if I couldn't stand him.

There in a silent apartment, I waited, but I really did not know what to do with myself while I did. I paced around. I stared out of our floor-to-ceiling windows over the majestic view of the city.

I guess a large part of me still doubted that she would go through with it. She'd fooled me before. And though she knew following her other tests that the thought of her adultery did actually turn me on, she had no guarantee how I'd respond to her being unfaithful with him. An ex who had attempted to destroy our marriage.

Maybe I was expecting her to come right back in through that front door and tell me I had one more chance—trust her or lose her. Maybe I

was expecting her to phone and say I'd been right, she had done something more with Jason than simply help him over the loss of his marriage.

Maybe I thought she'd just spend the night alone in a hotel somewhere, teaching me a lesson. Return in the morning with fake signs of infidelity. One more final test of my handling things.

So I waited, and I waited for an age.

Then, at last, my phone buzzed in my pocket, and it nearly made me jump through the window.

"Hello?"

She was calling me on Skype—a video call—and yet the face of my phone remained black, and she wasn't saying anything at all.

"Hello? Hello? Court? You there?"

I fiddled with a few settings, but the video was apparently working. I turned up the volume and there was only white noise.

Then there was a few clicks and bangs, one of which nearly blew my phone's speakers out, so I turned the volume back down a little. A low hum I'd thought to be part of the general white noise seemed now to be a vehicle engine, quiet but varying in pitch as Courtney drove, accompanied by the gentle growl of tires traveling along asphalt. It was her little Mercedes.

Had she butt-dialed me? Could you butt-dial someone using Skype? I supposed if she'd accidentally knocked the app on, and bumped into my contact in her Skype list.

I found myself a comfortable seat on our couch and placed the phone on the coffee table in front of me. Listening attentively to any possible clues as to what was going on. If she was giving me an idea about where she was going, either accidentally or purposefully, I didn't want to miss it. Right now, it sounded as though she was slowing to a halt. An electronic whirr suggested her window being wound down. Was she going into a parking lot? Taking a ticket from an automated machine, perhaps.

I guess if she was intending to spend the night in a hotel, all alone, I wanted to go find her. If she got into trouble, I wanted to be there to protect her, bring her home. If she really was going to see Harry Richards, I wanted to know. I wanted every possible suggestion about what was going on.

Now there was a voice: masculine, stern, authoritative, official. Military.

"Ma'am. Can you open your trunk, please?"

“Sure.”

My heart started thumping a little more quickly. I wasn't the most experienced person in the world when it came to the military, but the movies helped fill in the gaps in my knowledge. It seemed to me that my wife was driving through a military checkpoint. Such as you might find entering an Air Force base.

It took a few minutes. Long enough for me to determine that the only person with ties to the military that Courtney even vaguely knew was a certain Harry Richards. But he was working for a private defense contractor now, wasn't he?

It felt like a stretch, though, that this might be proof that my wife wasn't there to see her ex.

At last, the voice of the guard came back: “Thank you, Ma'am. You know where you're going?”

“Uh... yeah. Block 4-D.” Courtney seemed calm, collected.

“All the way to the left, keep going until you hit the parking lot.”

“Thank you, Sergeant.”

At no point, from what I heard, did the guard ask Courtney who she was there to visit. Had Harry Richards given her some kind of pass to get onto the base?

I heard her driving again, slowly, negotiating her way through the base until she found a place to park. The butterflies in my stomach fluttered. I thought about what she must look like in her car.

She'd been wearing especially sexy lingerie when I'd come home. She'd applied her makeup, her perfume. We hadn't been intending to go out that night. She didn't normally need to go to such lengths just to seduce me. She could have stood there in sweatpants and reminded me of our previous night, when she'd fooled me into thinking she'd finally cheated on me with some big prick. We'd still been in the warm honeymoon period of that particular encounter.

So what if I'd come home and she'd said she was actually on her way out. *Honey, we both want this, you know we do. I'm going to go sleep with my ex, Harry.*

Maybe she'd been intending to go out and cheat on me that night, anyway. But now I'd made her angry. She was mad at me, and maybe Harry could take advantage of that and brief her against me. Maybe Harry could persuade her that I'd been wrong for her from the start. I'd been distrusting her since we'd been first dating, when I'd believed her to be cheating with Jason.

Harry could steal her away from me. *I don't care about all that. I've been with you all along*, he'd say.

I heard her climbing out of her car, closing the door and locking it. The sound of her walking in high heels across the hard pavement of the parking lot. Walking, presumably, to Block 4-D. Was the phone in her pocket? That was why the video was black, but I could hear what was going on. A heavy door opened, but then there was only silence, only the white noise. Courtney walking down a carpeted hallway, perhaps, her heels making no sound.

Then: knock, knock.

“Well, look who the cat dragged in!” It was the voice of Harry Richards. “Or should I say ‘pussy’?”

Chapter 14

“Well, I heard you were so lonely...”

My wife was out, late at night, visiting one of her ex-boyfriends with the expressed intention of fucking him, of cheating on me.

Sitting there on my couch, focused on an iPhone that wasn't giving me pictures, only sound, I was shivering in an apartment that was kept at the perfect temperature all year round.

“Lonely?” Harry Richards laughed.

“Well, I hear you've taken to meeting up with my husband in bars.”

Courtney sounded mildly irritated with him. Or perhaps she was more strongly angry, but suppressing her rage.

“Well, I have to hand it to you, Court,” my rival for her affections was saying remarkably casually, “you seem to have found another one just like the long line of cuckolds you dated in college.”

I heard movement, and came to register part of the white noise I'd been listening to as being Courtney actually moving, though her high heels were still being stifled by carpeting. The door to Harry Richards' accommodation closed, and I knew for a fact that he had stepped back to allow my wife into his room, and Courtney had accepted his invitation.

“He's not a cuckold,” she said sharply.

“Well that all depends on your definition for it, I guess,” Richards said.

“He wants me to do it.” I heard the shift of clothing, and with my increasingly attuned hearing it sounded to me that Courtney was taking a seat somewhere. The creak of a leather couch or armchair confirmed it. Courtney went on: “He wants to know it's happening. He wants to know all the details.”

“Oh, I know all that. I saw it in him, firsthand. Just what you've always wanted, isn't it? The perfect balance.”

I could hear a smile in Courtney's voice as she said, “He's like a unicorn. I didn't think guys like that could truly exist.” The warmth inside me was hope, that her anger at me would subside, that she wouldn't end the night upset at me for taking Richards' word over hers.

“And now you're here, in my room, at late minutes past late.”

“Well...” Courtney said, almost purred at the signs of obvious lust in Richards. “I realize we had to cancel your last appointment...”

“Never know when the Air Force might feel like checking up on me. Almost wish I really did step into the private sector.”

“...I thought maybe this might be the only time I get to squeeze you in this week.”

Richards laughed at her double entendre, but the clear sound of her voice made me quiver. It was no accident, no slip of her tongue.

“Okay... let me take a look at that shoulder of yours...” that leather couch was creaking again. My wife was examining Richards, but I could not tell how they were seated. Jesus. Could he tell she was wearing nothing under that thin coat other than her lingerie?

I heard a slight moan—low, so it seemed to me it came from Richards. My heart started spinning, I felt a little light-headed. What were they doing? Was she really just examining his injured shoulder, or were the two of them making out?

“You’re so tense...” I heard her say. “I told you last time—and the time before. It’s slowing your recovery.”

“You’d be tense as well if you were a guy like me,” he growled. “Itching to get out there again, protect my bros out on the battlefield.”

“Well it’s doing you no good being like this. Really.”

“It’s okay. It loosens up when I train.”

“You’re training already? I thought you had another three weeks...”

“I can’t talk about it, Court, you know that.”

“Well you shouldn’t be risking your long-term health just because the Agency came knocking... Are you sleeping properly?”

“I don’t know... sometimes.”

I heard Courtney sigh. “I could... give you a massage. It would help with the stress a little.”

“One of those shih tzu massages you used to give the guys on the team back in college?” Richards said.

Courtney laughed. It was such a beautiful sound. “No, shih tzus are little fluffy dogs. You mean ‘shiatsu’, right?”

“I don’t know... you say ‘potato’, I say ‘tomato’.”

“Come on,” she said. “I know exactly how to get rid of all this stress.”

Movement again. The creak of the couch as Courtney and Richards rose to their feet. The bumps and scuffles and clicks as the phone and its microphone were taken out of Courtney’s pocket. Bang as the thing was put down on some kind of hard surface.

Then, suddenly, the screen on my phone lit up, and my Skype app was showing a video feed. I couldn't quite tell what it was on screen, but then Courtney stepped back, and I could see it had been a close-up of her beige coat. Now, there she was with Richards in the close confines of that bathroom.

She had to be giving me a view of it all on purpose. If you dropped a phone down on a flat surface in a bathroom or anywhere else, any video picture would be of the ceiling or the flat surface itself. She'd propped this phone up somehow, so I could see the bathroom.

I could see her lean into the shower to switch on the flow of the water.

"You want me to take a shower first, huh?" he said.

"Uh-huh." She stepped back next to him, and now I watched as she pulled open her coat, revealing the scandalously hot black lingerie beneath.

I gasped.

"Well, you sure are being persuasive about it," he said, cracking a wry smile, as Courtney removed her coat and turned to hang it up on the bathroom door, loving every moment as his eyes roamed all over her body.

I reached for my phone, shaking all over, not quite believing what I was seeing. Yet so damn hard, I had to get out of those tight pants to watch her like that.

"We should do this properly," Courtney said. "If you don't get on that mission, you're going to go nuts."

She was removing her bra. Flicking the catch in the middle of her shoulder blades, slipping the straps off over her shoulders. Turning to hang the thing up on the same hook as her coat, so I could see the profile of her breasts, and just how hard her nipples were.

"You do this with all your patients?" he asked her.

She giggled. "You know I can't talk about any of my other patients."

I felt that increasingly familiar burning sensation in the back of my neck, the jolt of shock flushing through my heart at the sense that perhaps there were things Courtney had kept secret from me over the years, after all. Was Richards right? Did she do this kind of thing with other clients?

Now she was stooping to unfasten the garters holding up her stockings, to slip off her panties.

“Jesus,” Richards said in barely more than a whisper as he gazed upon her. “You look just the same as you did in college.”

“You like?” she giggled again. The kind of girlish giggle she didn’t do with me. “I even got that little Brazilian job you always liked so much...”

I was so hard, and throbbing at the strangely confused feelings I was getting from her hinting that perhaps she hadn’t gotten her Brazilian wax job for my benefit. Or not merely my benefit.

And, God, she looked incredible; and, God, she was standing right there next to another man wearing almost nothing. Peeling off her stockings, kicking off her shoes...

And now she was reaching for him, for his shirt, unfastening his buttons.

“So...” Richards said, “I take it your husband wants you to do this...”

“He does,” Courtney said, popping the buttons open all the way down to his belt.

“So you’re going to tell him all about it when you get home?”

Suddenly, Richards was coming across all nervous as Courtney helped him to remove his shirt, revealing the kind of toned, buff torso that I should have known a military man like him would possess.

“I told you—he wants to know all the details,” she said, teasing him as she sensed his discomfort.

“Well... hey... maybe some of it’s classified, right?”

“Hey, it’s okay,” she smiled warmly. “We did this in college, right? Like, all the time.”

“This ain’t college.”

I’m not sure why Richards was suddenly so uncomfortable. From what Courtney had suggested tonight, although she’d been shared by her previous boyfriends, and she’d ended up cheating on them, they hadn’t necessarily wanted her to provide all the details of her infidelities.

“You have nothing to worry about,” Courtney said, flicking open the man’s belt, pulling his pants open, peering inside. “Come on... it’s just a massage.”

She crouched to haul down his pants, revealing his muscular legs, but Richards was holding his hands in front of his prick for now. It amused her.

“You were never this bashful in college.”

He removed his own socks, and then he was naked with her in that little bathroom. Courtney grabbed one of his hands, and now he couldn’t

hide his manhood. I saw that he was already hard. And he was as hairless as she was.

Jesus. Jesus, Jesus, Jesus. She was really doing this.

All smiley and bright, she led him into the shower stall, tested the water with one hand, but then had Richards step under the flow of the hot water. His cock was hard, sticking straight out from his body as the water started spraying down all over his muscular form. It was huge, I could see why this guy might be her go-to lover back when she was hooked on infidelity.

Courtney just stood back a moment, admiring him under the water, perhaps letting it sink into her mind exactly what was happening, that she was back to being unfaithful, this time while married no less.

Then she was running her hands all over his back, and when he turned to her, all over his front. As though he needed assistance to shower. I watched her grab a bottle of soap, pour it out into her hands, which she then used to spread it all over his pecs, his stomach, his arms.

“Relax...” she said, smiling flirtatiously at him. “You’re supposed to enjoy this, you know.”

“What’re you gonna tell your husband?”

She rolled her eyes. “Don’t worry, I’m not going to embarrass you. John wants to know I had a good time, that’s all. He wants to believe I’m getting out-of-this-world sex from you. I’m not here to disappoint my husband.”

She was washing him all over, seeming impressed at his athletic body, his muscles, being all flirty with him while somehow trying to make it appear that this wasn’t a huge deal, she’d done all this before.

She washed him all over, but she seemed to pointedly avoid that huge uncut cock of his. I watched her kneel in front of him, her hands swarming all over his thighs, his calves, his hips and waist, around his loins and his balls without straying to his manhood. It was like she was teasing him—or me.

“You do this kind of thing for your other patients?” Richards asked her.

“Of course not!” she giggled. I felt a little flash of disappointment that she wasn’t giving secret sexy massages to other patients, but it seemed fairly ridiculous. “And you know... technically you’re not really my patient, either. Since all this is off the books...”

God, she was really making sure his thighs were well soaped—but her pretty face was just a few inches away from that huge prick. She stood up, leaving it untouched. Reloaded her hands with soap.

She stood behind him and soaped his shoulders, his back, his buttocks, the back of his thighs.

“You did this with Jason, didn’t you?” Richards asked her.

I felt that prickly heat behind my ears, and along the back of my neck. Listening to something that might have been the real truth emerging here, and it didn’t quite match up with the impression Courtney had given me.

“Something like it,” she said. Didn’t seem fazed by admitting it, either.

“I knew it. I knew you fucked him,” Richards said. It seemed like he’d been vindicated. Like he’d been bothered by the idea that Courtney had been sleeping with Jason, not just me. I supposed from everything the two of them had said, that during the time when Courtney had been with Jason, she couldn’t have slept with Harry Richards, because she hadn’t cheated on me with him.

Courtney merely laughed. “Oh, I never said that.”

“But you did cheat on John with him.”

“No,” she said. “I told you. I didn’t fuck Jason.”

She pushed Richards against the wall, side-on to me, as though she was a cop making an arrest, searching a suspect for hidden weapons. But then she was sliding her soapy arms around his waist, and now she did reach for his hard cock.

I caught my breath as I watched her hands slip over his length, her fingers curling around it. She pumped it, continuing to stand behind him, definitely much more than simply making sure it was well-soaped.

Richards groaned. “You saying that this isn’t cheating on John?”

“I wouldn’t call it that, no.” Courtney crouched by him, jerking his cock and fondling his hairless balls, as though fascinated by them. “Not yet.”

I guess if I was to fully trust her, she hadn’t handled another man’s equipment since... well, since Jason, from what I was hearing. I wondered if she was going to make him come right there in the shower. Had she made Jason come while doing this?

No. She stood, and helped to rinse off the soap from all over his body. I felt that bewildering mix of emotions again—I felt some relief that Courtney hadn’t, in her mind, cheated on me with Jason. Even if in some people’s minds it would be defined as cheating. At least she hadn’t lied to me, if you took her at that definition.

But I guess I felt confused about the fact that she’d never come clean at the time about exactly what she’d done with Jason. Even

covered it with her doctor-patient confidentiality stuff. Would I have been able to handle it? Would it have ended our relationship? I don't know.

I tried to relax. Tried to feel the positives. The strange excitement that came from knowing that Courtney might have done this kind of massage with Jason. Well, he wasn't strictly a patient. A colleague, who she took on as a confidential patient.

"Okay..." I heard Courtney's voice, and found myself snapping out of my little daze. "Ready for your massage?"

She followed Richards out of the shower, but with his back turned, she now came for her phone.

She looked directly into the camera, flashed a knowing smile and blew a kiss at me. Then she took the phone from the bathroom sink and carried it with her out of the room. I was left in a little shock. She obviously knew I was watching then. That had been her intention.

Actually, it was kind of hot that she knew. That she wanted me watching. That she liked me watching. I felt included, somehow. Involved.

She was cheating on me, but in a way it wasn't cheating. I knew about it, and in my own manner I'd consented to it.

I don't know. The dark part of me, the perverted part that had probably generated this fantasy in the first place, was kind of reveling in the thought that my wife was cheating on me.

Or was she? How far was she going to take this massage? She'd gone over there to sleep with him, so she'd told me. He might believe she was there to continue his treatment, or he might not. Now I found myself praying that she was going to go the whole way, all the way round and back to home plate.

I watched on the tiny iPhone screen as Courtney moved her phone to some kind of side table between the bed and the windows. I saw Richards lying there stretched out on the bed. He really was getting a massage.

Courtney had her medical bag with her, it must have been in her car. She reached into it to retrieve something, something which turned out to be massage oil. Then she was up on the bed, kneeling beside him, facing the camera.

I glanced up at our large TV screen, and realized I didn't have to be peering into a tiny iPhone screen. Apple TV allowed me to click a little symbol on my phone, and choose to stream the live video straight through our 52-inch high-definition screen.

I watched my naked wife pouring oil all over another man's bare back, and it almost seemed like I was watching her in real size. It was a sharp, quality picture. I watched her kneel up to sweep her hands all over his body, spreading that oil all over his shoulders, his butt, his neck.

Then I watched her lift one of her legs over his body and straddle him.

"Mmm..." he moaned at the sensation of her smooth skin sliding over his, her thighs locking around his waist, her feet clamped against his thighs. He could probably feel her pussy pressing down on his butt.

She poured more oil all over his back, and spread it past his shoulders and down over his biceps to his forearms, which were folded under his head.

She massaged him a little, rubbing little circles over his muscles, her movement seeming assured, experienced.

"God, that feels good..." he said.

But then she was pouring massage oil all over her own body, down her front, rubbing it over her breasts, those seriously-stiff nipples, down her stomach, between her legs, over her thighs. All over her arms, too, and the parts of her back she could reach, all over her butt.

She moved down to oil up the backs of his thighs, his calves, kneeling between his legs.

Then she dived forward, over his body, her hands gliding up his back, her bare breasts grazing over his butt and lower back, and my beautiful wife was lying on top of him, straddling him again, this time using her own naked body to massage him all over.

"God..." Richards moaned. "I don't remember this in college."

"That's where I learned it," she giggled. "I just never did it with you."

"Now I'm jealous."

She laughed. "I never did it with you 'cause I could never pass up that big cock of yours for long enough."

Wow. She really knew what she was doing. She pulled her whole body up his back so far she could massage his shoulders with her thighs. Then she'd sink down to stroke her breasts all over the backs of his legs. Someone needed a lot of practice to do it like this.

She seemed to use every inch of her naked form to massage him, from her feet up to her breasts, her hands, her cheeks. And I could see with my own eyes she was rubbing her pussy all over him.

"You do this with John?"

Again, she merely laughed. “Now you’re sounding like a cuckold...”

She turned over, and lay on him on her back, massaging him with her shoulders, her back, her butt. Her gorgeous body glistening with massage oil as she writhed over him, her trim muscles quivering as she moved, her breasts prim on her chest, her nipples impossibly hard.

I watched her with my dick in my hands and my heart was beating nineteen to the dozen. I watched her flip onto her front again, moving up to rub his upper back between her thighs, and the way she gyrated her hips made me think of a high-class stripper moving around a pole. Was she going to fuck him?

I felt so burning hot inside. I watched her lift one leg higher up his body than the other, and I could actually see her waxed pussy dripping with oil, caressing his upper thigh, his butt.

“You did this with Jason, didn’t you?”

“Uh-huh.” She didn’t even try to deny it.

She pulled herself off him, and had him turn over onto his back, where she could pour even more massage oil all over his body, all over those big pecs, the six-pack, the buff biceps, his muscular thighs. Oh, and all over that big lolling dick of his.

She kneaded his muscles in her hands, seemed most professional in how she was doing it. Spreading out that oil, working the tension, the stress out of his chest, his arms, his legs.

“Feels good?”

“Uh-huh,” he replied. “You gonna tell your husband about all this?”

“Uh-huh.”

I was damn near panting as I watched her take his big oily cock in her hands and begin working on that just as though it was simply another one of his muscles that needed its tension released.

“What... happened... to... my... patient... confidentiality?” Richards groaned as she pumped his shaft.

“I told you, didn’t I? Technically...”

“But you have been treating me.”

“Well, all that goes out the window as soon as we cross the line,” she said, and I could see she was rubbing her pussy gently against one of his shins.

“The line?”

She grinned up at him. “When you become my lover.”

She ducked down to run her tongue up along the length of his huge cock, from base to tip. My heartbeat almost seemed to slow, and to me it

seemed almost as though time itself was grinding to a halt.

I heard him moaning, and I saw her pulling herself up his oil-saturated body, and now she was straddling his hips, and I saw his cock stroked by my wife's bare pussy.

For a moment or two, I almost believed she would go no further. She would continue sliding her pussy lips over his shaft, teasing him, but still technically massaging him. Not quite cheating.

Then I saw her hand disappear between her thighs, repositioning him. She lifted her body, and kept it in such a position that I could see her sink down on his glistening shaft, I could see that huge thing disappearing into her.

Courtney was fucking another man. My gorgeous wife was now unfaithful. She was cheating on me.

"Oh Jesus, Court..." Richards grunted as she began to move on him.

My wife glanced briefly to the side and flashed me another mischievous smile. Knowing what she was doing, knowing I was sitting there riveted to the sight of her cheating on me. The way they were lying there on the bed, the way she had herself straddling him, she knew I could see everything. I could see him entering her, thrusting into her, I could see her pussy lips massaging his big dick.

"I take it... you didn't... go this far... with Jason?" Richards said, panting.

"Nope," she said emphatically, and I believed her. I felt relieved, even though in many respects my paranoia at the time was now vindicated to a degree.

"Oh fucking God..."

I watched him holding her, his big hands closing around her waist, his powerful body moving under her as he thrust up and inside her. Listening to her moans, her sighs, her gasps, seeing the anguished look of pure pleasure on her face—I loved watching my wife enjoying herself.

"Oh... oh... oh... Harry..."

When you peeled away the paranoia, the fear, the jealousy—and suppressed them, ignored them if you really could—there was just powerful arousal remaining. Someone who had committed herself to me, had given up one of her biggest temptations for me, was now finding absolute pleasure because I was allowing it.

And yet now, I don't think I would feel so bad if she did cheat on me. She'd just have to know how much pleasure I could give her when

she came back to me, when she came clean and told me everything.

“You... gonna tell... your husband... about this?” Harry asked her, now withdrawing his huge, soaking dick from her to stroke over her buttocks, over her pussy lips. Making me wonder at how my Courtney managed to even fit that giant thing inside her.

“Oh yeah...” she said, and now looked directly over toward her phone and the camera again—directly at me, it seemed. Her eyes smoldering, her mouth open, imparting to me just how much pleasure she was getting.

“I’m gonna tell him all about your big dick...”

“Yeah...”

“And how you squeezed it into me... how full I felt when you were inside me... how you stretched me...”

“God, you’re so tight, babe.”

“I’m gonna tell him... how hard I fucked you...” she panted as she rocked herself back and forth over him, circling her hips over him, bouncing her butt over him to slam his cock into her time and time again.

“Oh yeah... yeah... yeah... oh my God...”

She leaned over him and kissed his mouth, and despite the fact she had his manhood inside her, I think it was the first time I saw her kissing him. It felt more jarring to me even than the sight of his big cock stretching her pussy.

“I want you to fuck me,” she said, smiling broadly as she kissed him.

“Yeah?”

“Yeah, right now.”

“This doesn’t seem much like a massage any more,” he joked as she lifted herself off his body, and he moved out of her way so she could present herself on all fours for him, poised for him to take her from behind.

Kneeling up behind her, once again it seemed to me his hard cock was impossibly large—and yet he slipped the tip inside her, grabbed her hips and eased the rest in, inch by inch, and she took it all.

“Oh... oh... yes... oh God... yes...”

“You love it... you love it...”

“Oh God... I’m cheating on him... I’m cheating on my husband...”

“You can’t... resist it...”

“I’m cheating... with your great... big... dick...”

Clutching the pillows, Courtney gasped and moaned as he thrust into her. Richards grabbed her by the waist and pounded into her,

grunting and groaning as he fucked my wife.

“Oh... God, your cock feels so good...”

“Oh yeah... oh yeah...”

“I want you to come... I want you to come...”

Jesus. She said that, and I suddenly realized there was no condom here. I guess with all the massage oil it wouldn't have been safe anyway, but Harry Richards was fucking my wife bareback, his enormous cock plunging into her hot pussy without any kind of barrier...

And now she was saying over and over, “I want you to come... I want you to come...”

She squirmed under him, managed to turn onto her back without Richards moving, facilitated by the fact that her entire body was coated in oil.

He held her legs apart and eased up to her again, stroked his hard cock all over her pussy—but this time Courtney grabbed hold of his shaft with both hands and started jacking him.

“You're gonna come for me...” she was telling him, and Richards was tilting his head back and groaning, letting her do as she pleased with him. “You're gonna come all over this bad girl...”

The big man was grunting, almost roaring, as my wife squeezed his huge cock in both hands.

“Give it to me... give it to me...”

It seemed almost surreal, watching my wife with that thing in her hands, that huge obscene thing glistening with her juices, throbbing and bolting and bucking as her fingers virtually throttled it.

And with an enormous grunt, the man was firing off thick white cream all over her breasts, her stomach, her pussy.

“Mmmm...” Courtney was moaning as he spurted all over her smooth skin, and it finally slowed to a dribble all over her fingers.

Richards just held himself there, panting and gasping for breath. Courtney gazed up at him, amused, turned on—but did he make her come? I guess he must have.

She turned her head, glanced over at me again and gave me an ear-to-ear smile. Brought her fingers up to her mouth to taste this other man's come.

“Mmmm....” she moaned again.

Richards pulled up from her, then collapsed on the bed beside her. Was she going to spend all night with him? I was so buzzed, so completely high, but I wanted her so badly. It felt so unfair to think that

she might switch off the video feed and stay with him, and I wouldn't see her again until morning.

I'd even held out from coming myself in the hope that she would be coming back to me.

Courtney got up from the bed, and walked toward her phone, toward the camera. I could see her body almost shimmering in the oil, and her lover's come spattered all over her heavenly body.

"What's that?" Richards asked her, not really caring, but not really having much else to say.

She reached for her phone. "My iPhone."

"Your phone?" Now she had his interest again.

"Uh-huh." She held her phone up to her face, smiled at me with real love and affection. "He's been watching us through it."

Richards coughed, and laughed, but he didn't seem angry at her. "Seriously?"

She smirked at him. "I told you he was different, didn't I?"

"Fuck."

She smiled radiantly into the camera again. "I love you, honey. I'm sorry things have been so... confused... recently..."

"I love you too..." I said back at my phone, but she didn't react.

"I hope you enjoyed what you saw, honey..." she said, and I got the impression from her that this Skype call was one-way video, she wasn't hearing back from me.

Courtney climbed back onto the bed, lying next to Richards, her head propped up on the pillow. I had a wonderful view of her as she held her phone right between her thighs, so I could stare up at her, a full close-up of her adulterous pussy right there up front.

"You still love me?" she asked, though in an amused tone that did not doubt for a second that I did. "Does it turn you on to see me actually cheat on you? You still want me? I have his come all over me..."

And she was gently rubbing his come into her skin.

Beside her, Harry Richards snorted. "Seriously?" he said. Then he told her, "Turn it off, babe. Come on. I'll be ready to go again in a minute or two."

Courtney laughed. "God, no. That's all you get tonight, Harry."

"Seriously? Babe, you can't resist this..."

I could hear him patting his huge cock, trying to get himself hard again as quickly as possible.

But Courtney just smiled into the camera. Said to him, "Do you know what the hottest sex I've ever had was?"

“Hmmp?”

“Fucking my husband when he believes I’ve been a really, really naughty girl.”

Chapter 15

I actually took a shower after that, lukewarm-going-on-cold, just to clear my head. It sort of worked, although my erection never fully subsided, and every time I closed my eyes, I saw Harry's cock plunging into my wife's wet pussy.

She'd done it. She'd really, actually, done it. I searched my emotional state for signs of jealousy or anger or resentment. I found none, save for the tiny nugget that was Jason and whatever she'd done with him—and even that mostly just sent blood racing back to my cock.

I dragged myself from the shower, toweled off, but didn't bother with clothes. There was no mystery as to what came next. Instead, I grabbed some candles, setting them about the bedroom, and loaded some Gypsy Kings on the jambox. Crawling into bed naked, I only had to wait for a couple minutes before I heard Courtney at the front door.

She called out, "Hello?"

"In here." The buzz was back, along with a cock so hard it hurt. My heart raced. My skin tingled. I held my breath and waited for her to make her way into the room.

The door slowly swung open and in stepped my wife, back from her lover, and looking as tentative and nervous as I felt.

She held her head low and looked up at me shyly. "Hi," she said, tucking a strand of dark hair over her ear. Was this really the same woman I'd just witnessed tell another man how good his big dick felt inside of her?

She still wore her coat, but had no stockings beneath. She still wore her shoes, tall with slender heels that I should have noticed as she left, but was too distracted at the time.

"Did that really happen?" I said, my voice croaking.

Courtney looked at me with an intensity that I will long remember. I saw worry there, anxiety, but also...daring. "Yes," she said quietly. "It definitely happened."

She pulled her coat off, shrugging it off her shoulders. Beneath, she was nude, her paper white skin still glossy from all the oil she'd covered herself in. In the candlelight, she looked like the centerfold of a Playboy Playmate pictorial made flesh. Her pert tits rose and fell with shallow

breaths, drawing my eyes to her hard nipples. Lower, her flat stomach, her narrow hips, her waxed mound and the way her pussy was swollen and red from sex.

“You’re so sexy,” I said without thinking. “How did I end up with someone so fucking hot?”

“You were yourself,” she said, taking a tentative step in my direction. “And if anyone should be pinching themselves, it’s me.”

“How do you figure that?” I asked.

She climbed up onto the bed, the scent of oil mixed with the soapy hint of another man’s come. My breath caught. I glanced up at her.

“How many men do you think would be okay with what I just did?”

“Uhh... I have no idea.”

She smiled. “Right, exactly.” She crawled up beside me, pulling the blanket away from my body as she did so. Wrapping her hand around my steely erection, she gave it a few strokes, as if confirming that I really was into it. “You’re so hard!”

“Your fault.”

“Let me apologize,” she said, lowering her head down to take me into her mouth.

“Uhhh... Court, be careful, I’m so close,” I groaned.

She pulled off of me, wiping her mouth with the back of her hand. “You didn’t come yet?”

“No,” I said tightly. “I wanted to wait.”

She flashed her eyes up at me, then said, “Wait’s over.”

She went right back to my cock, determined and undeterred by the imminence of my orgasm. I didn’t bother trying to stop her, just flattened myself onto the bed, shut my eyes, and let her tongue and lips work their magic. In that swimming darkness, I replayed the night yet again—the shower, the full-body massage, the way she’d kissed another man then told him that she wanted to fuck him.

And then another thing occurred to me—Jason. She hadn’t fucked him, but she hadn’t been totally honest with me, either. What *had* she done with him? Had she fooled around with him? Gotten naked with him? *Gone down on him?!*

“Oh, fuck, Court... I’m... I’m—”

My climax sliced through my warning, cutting me off as I thrust my hips against her and buried my cock into her throat. Courtney gagged, pulled back enough to hold the tip on her mouth, and swallowed my load.

Once drained, she didn't fully release me. Her hands were still slippery with oil and saliva, and she fondled my softening shaft. She looked up at me, a serious expression descending. "Okay, so now that we got that out, tell me how you really feel."

With my orgasm, the fever of the night cooled just enough for all the old insecurities to come creeping back in. My wife had gone off and fucked another man—a stronger, fitter, more endowed man than I was—and based on what I'd heard, she'd loved every moment of it. More than that, she'd *missed* doing that. So the real question, now that the deed was done, was how did I really feel about it?

"Did you have fun?" I asked.

"You're dodging," Courtney said. "You know I did."

"Do you love him?"

She screwed her face up and shook her head. "No. God no. Harry isn't the kind of guy you fall for. *You* are."

She was telling the truth. She'd always been telling me the truth, I realized, even if her version of the truth wasn't exactly the same as mine. She loved me, she was my partner, even if she went off and fucked other men. Even if she *craved* fucking other men.

I began to harden once again, coaxed by her slippery fingers. "What are you thinking about?" Courtney asked.

"Just that I'm glad that I know this side of you is all."

She raised a brow. "Just 'glad,' huh?"

"You're beautiful. More than that." She began to protest, but I held up my hand. "I'm just being honest here, not trying to flatter. You know you are, and you know that I've struggled with that in the past."

"You don't have to, you know."

I did now—more now than ever, as strange as that was. "I do, but I still struggled. You have no idea what it's like to go through life, knowing how I married someone so out-of-my-league, and worried that one day, someone would steal you away."

"And you know that it doesn't work like that, right? I'm not a vase or something sitting on your mantle that anyone can run off with. It's what made me fall in love with you so hard. You treated me like a person. You saw me as more than just a pretty pair of eyes."

I bit my lip. "I do. And every day I'm with you, I see more and more of who you really are. *That's* what I'm thinking of. That's what gets me excited. Why I'm getting hard again right now."

Courtney giggled, stroking me slowly as I stood up in her hand.

I said, "Watching you tonight was one of the hottest things I've ever seen. Watching you...fuck Harry. Watching you come—"

"Actually, I didn't come."

"Really?"

Courtney shook her head. "Maybe I was saving myself, too."

"You know you don't have to do that," I said.

With a twinkle in her eye, she said, "Next time, I'll remember that."

It was the exact right thing to say in the moment. I pulled her up to me and rolled her onto her back. "Next time, huh?"

She looked shy. "Depends on if you really are okay with it."

I kissed her, softly at first before pushing my tongue past her lips. I tasted the traces of my come—and maybe Harry's? Mostly, though, she tasted the same as she always did, warm and slightly sweet.

"I'm okay with it," I said before moving my lips down her neck. She gasped, reaching between my legs to grasp my cock.

"I want you inside of me."

"Soon, honey," I promised, kissing lower. I traced her nipples with my tongue, flicking the hard eraser tip. She gasped. "First, tell me what really happened with Jason."

Courtney stiffened. "I... was honest when I told Harry."

I nibbled on her breast, putting enough pressure to draw a gasp. "I want specifics, honey. I want the truth."

"I never cheated on you."

"You never fucked him. But don't pretend that you were innocent." I heard the aggravation rise in my voice, but it wasn't at what she may or may not have done, but in the fact that she kept dodging the confession. "Courtney, we're in a different place now, and I'm pretty sure if Jason came back into your life, you wouldn't do anything with him at all."

"I wouldn't," she said adamantly.

"Right, but I want to know what happened back then. It's time to put it all in the open."

I kissed the bottom slope of her breast as I moved down her body, still coated in a sheen of oil, sweat, and come. Sliding my fingers along her flat stomach, I moved them in between her legs and across her bald mound. Her clit was swollen, her pussy lips engorged.

"Tell me everything."

"I still hate—ahhh..." She groaned as I plunged two fingers into her. "I still hate that I did that. Even now, when I think back on it, I'm so..." She bit her lips, working through the slow penetration of my fingers.

“I’m so ashamed. To my core. If I could erase one thing in my life, that would be... that would be it.”

I moved in between her legs, spreading them open as I spread out in front of her. I stared at her pussy, beautiful and blooming and so wet. Another man had been here. More would be here in the future. My heart sang at the thought.

“He’d gone through a bad divorce. He’d come to me, as a friend, asking for a prescription for some pills to help with his anxiety. I offered a shoulder to cry on and an ear to listen instead.”

“Had you two ever been together before?” I asked.

Courtney shook her head. “No. He’d always been in a relationship. There’d always been this attraction between us, though, but we’d never acted on it.”

“Until then.”

Courtney bit her lip.

“It’s okay. Tell me. I want to hear it.” I dipped my head down between her legs, sliding my hand up to work her clit as I lapped at her smooth gash.

Courtney steadied her breath, her eyes closing under the onslaught of pleasure. “It happened one night when you weren’t around. He called me. He was upset. Apparently he’d seen his wife out with someone else, so I... invited him over.”

“Did you know what was going to happen?”

She grimaced. She did. She didn’t need to say it. “I’m sorry. I...I loved you, but I also felt the old temptations coming back. He came over, I offered to give him a massage.”

I swirled my tongue up across her clit, teasing it from its hood as my fingers pressed back inside her once again. I was living out her narrative—without jealousy or anger or frustration. All I felt was the sticky heat of arousal and eroticism.

“One thing led to another, and before we knew it...” She mewed. “That feels so good, baby...”

“Before you knew what?” I prompted, drawing my tongue away. She groaned in frustration, lifting her butt off the bed. “Tell me, baby. What did you do with Jason?”

“Before we knew it, we were both naked in bed. I... I...”

The pressure built around me. My heart rattled against my ribs. “What?”

She looked down at me, bashful, chewing on her lower lips, uncertain how to answer. “I was naughty.”

“What did you do?”

“You really want to know?” It was at that question that I realized she was playing with me. She was a smart one. She knew what this confession was doing to me.

“Tell me.”

She licked her lips. “I sucked his cock.”

I gasped.

“I sucked his cock until he exploded in my mouth. It was so bad. So, so bad.”

“And that’s why you did it,” I prompted.

“Uh huh.”

“And then?”

“He went down on me. He made me scream, too.”

I heard the challenge. Adding a third finger to her pussy, I went back to her clit, closing my mouth around her slippery mound as I worked the flat of my tongue again and again against her button.

“Uhhh, yes, baby. Just like that. That’s exactly how Jason ate my pussy.” She moaned, losing herself for a moment. “I think he even got four fingers inside of—ohhhh!”

I added a fourth, splitting her open beyond what I was comfortable with. She accommodated me, amazingly, loosened and primed by Harry’s thickness, no doubt, and heated up by this stroll down memory lane.

“Did he fuck you?” I asked, giving my jaw time to rest. “You can tell me the truth, Court. I’m good.”

“AH!” She moaned sharply, arching back, on the brink of a climax.

“Did he? Did you cross that line?”

“I... I...”

My cock was so hard. My whole body so tense.

“A part of me wanted to so badly. He crawled over me, our bodies sliding together with all that oil, you know. I felt his cock—hard, big, tempting—glide up the inside of my thighs.” Her eyes were shut hard. She was there, in the moment. “I felt him against my pussy. I reached down, ready to place it in me. Ready to feel him deep inside of me.”

“But?”

But she was lost to her climax. Wrapping her legs around my head, she squeezed me as her narrative broke down into a guttural scream. She pressed her cunt against my mouth, dug her hands into the bed, and rode my face with her hairless mound. I weathered the storm, lashing out

when I could, fingering her until she could take it no longer. Pushing me away, she collapsed into the bed again and let out a big sigh of release.

I crawled up beside her once again, my hand tracing her shivering body. She released a gasping laugh and pushed my hand away. “Too much.”

I respected that, flopping down beside her with my head propped up on my elbow. “You didn’t finish your story.”

She looked at me out of the corner of her eyes and nodded. “I almost...cheated. I came so, so close, and honestly, if I had, I don’t think we’d still be here today.”

“So what stopped you?”

“You. Or the thought of you. I’d been in denial of my feelings for you, but in those final, weak moments with Jason, you popped into my head, smiling that goofy smile of yours.”

“I don’t have a goofy smile,” I said.

She laughed. “There it is! And I saw that and I thought, ‘What are you doing, Courtney?’ It was like I had this epiphany, right then and there—although I think the real truth is more than the realization happened over the next few months.”

“Which was?”

“I was sabotaging what we had, because I didn’t think I deserved you. I deserved someone like Harry. Or even Jason. Someone who saw me as just meaningless fun.”

“No,” I said.

“Look, I know I’m pretty. I’ve had this body my whole life, and it may come as a shock to you, but it’s really messed me up. Being objectified—I know, you don’t—my whole life turned me into a serial cheater. And I was doing it again. And I’m so sorry it went as far as it did, but you have to believe me, I’ve never cheated on you. Never even came close after that time with Jason.”

“Until now,” I said cheekily.

“Sure, but while we throw that term around—*cheating*—what happened tonight—”

“Wasn’t cheating,” I finished.

“More like...the most intense form of foreplay I’ve ever experienced.”

“Yeah.”

“I’m yours, John. Always. I won’t ever risk that.”

“I know.” And I did. “But you’re also not mine. You’re nobody’s but your own.”

She shook her head. “No, that’s not quite right either. We’re a team, you and me. Inseparable as we are complicated.” She swirled my chest, traced her finger down between my legs, and stroked my erection. “I need to feel this inside me now.”

I climbed between her legs as she guided my cock against her, rubbing it along her slit like a toy before positioning it home. I thrust forward, easily sinking into her sodden pussy.

“Ah, that feels good,” she gasped.

“I’m not as big as Harry.”

“No, but I love it. You feel just right for me.” She pulled me down against her, wrapping her legs around my waist. “Besides, you know I love variety—uh!”

She knew what she was doing. She knew how she was playing me. This is where we were, in a strong enough position where we could tease one another about other men.

“You do... don’t you...?”

“Yes, I love... feeling... strange cock.”

I slid across Courtney’s oil-coated skin, gliding in and out of her like a well-worked machine. That was us, in a nutshell, or at least where we hoped to be. I rested my forehead against hers, our noses nuzzling, as much of our bodies touching as possible in that moment. Staring down into her eyes, I said, “You know you can, right?”

“Yes.”

“Say it,” I urged.

“I can feel a strange man’s cock... fuck me... whenever I want.”

I groaned, my balls tightening despite my recent orgasm. I staved it off, for now, slowing my hips before I hit my limit.

“It gets you excited,” she said—a statement. “Me cheating on you is as exciting for you as it is for me.”

“It is,” I said.

“And that’s the only reason this works. We get our cake and get to eat it, too.”

“But you have to tell me, Courtney. No secrets. I want to experience the journey *with* you.”

“Of course.”

“Even if it’s just flirting,” I said, making sure she understood. “I want to be there from the beginning.”

“Then I should tell you that that guy from the club a few weeks ago, Russell, found me on Facebook.”

My breath caught. “The guy you told me you had sex with?”

“I didn’t, really.”

“I know. You were testing me.”

She looked up at me sheepishly, but didn’t deny it. “He friended me last week. I haven’t friended him back though.”

“You thought he was attractive?”

She nodded. My cock grew.

“If you’d met him before me, when you were dating one of your other boyfriends...?”

“I would have slept with him,” she said without hesitation.

“Friend him back.”

“You sure?”

I thrust forward in answer, burying myself deep, my cock so hard it hit places it normally didn’t. “Let’s see where this goes.”

Courtney licked her top lip, smiling in pleasure as I drove my hips. But she didn’t look away. She didn’t let her focus fade as she imagined herself with Russell, or Jason, or Harry. She was right there with me, in the moment, her hands curled around my shoulders as I pounded in and out of her.

“Fuck me, John. Show me how excited this makes you.”

“Ah, Court...”

“Fuck me the way you want Russell to fuck me.”

“Oh, baby,” I groaned, fucking her fast enough that my abs ached and my arms began to burn. “You’re such a bad girl.”

“Your bad girl.”

“Mine, yes.”

“No matter what,” she said through her moans.

“No matter what.”

Together we came, an exclamation point at the end of the most tumultuous time of our long marriage.

Epilogue

I remember the last time I met him. Just like the first, you don't forget a thing like that—not a moment, a single damn detail.

It was late afternoon in the Spring, and I was picking up Courtney from work.

Here I was, sitting patiently in that crowded waiting room breathing in the faint aroma of disinfectant and glossy magazines, thinking that at this rate there was no way my wife was going to be done by five.

Her door opened again, and there she was. I looked up at her, seeing her as everyone else in the waiting room did: jaw-droppingly beautiful with her paper white skin, lightly freckled. Dark hair, light blue eyes. A face so pretty it could have graced any of the magazines that lay strewn around this waiting room.

A couple of teenage boys who were staring at her flicked their eyes at each other and sniggered, each teasing the other for their obvious lustful thoughts about my wife. They weren't alone. Most male eyes, and many female ones, too, were looking over there to admire her.

My stomach squirmed to feel the desire of men around me.

Courtney spotted me, her face lighting up in a smile that faded just as quickly. She crossed the room, her brow already crumpled in apology. She tucked a strand of hair that has escaped her bun back behind her ear. "I'm sorry, John, but I'm going to be a little late."

We kissed—a soft, familiar, and public kiss. I took in the fact that she wasn't wearing her white coat. Even though she'd just told me I wouldn't be driving her home, she was sporting a little black dress, no less. She was all made up, too—eye liner, eye shadow, scarlet lipstick. Hair down loose, cascading over her shoulders.

My stomach squirmed. I tasted the bite of jealousy, the hopelessness of insecurity, and, as always, the dizziness of arousal.

"John."

He must have come in while my attention had been totally taken up by the vision of loveliness that was my sweet wife. Around thirty, flecks of gray in his short, buzzed hair, clean shaven face, military bearing. Jesus.

"Hey Harry."

Though I'd watched him having sex with my wife via a camera, it seemed so shocking to greet him in real life, face to face.

"You're looking well," he said, though whether out of politeness or not, I couldn't tell. I had joined a gym since my wife had started regular dates with another man, a man whose pure physicality did make me feel more than a touch guilty about my lapsed relationship with regular, demanding exercise.

"You too," I said, remembering that the first time I'd seen him, he'd been wearing a sling. Nothing like that now.

"For that, I have your beautiful wife to thank," he grinned, but despite his acknowledgement of her status, he now stepped forward to take her arm in his.

I felt eyes training themselves on me, trying to work out why, if I'd kissed Courtney earlier as though I was her spouse, she was now interlocking her arm in that of another man's. A man who was wearing similarly smart clothing, as though ready to go on a date.

I kind of liked the sense that something shocking was going on. It was. That shock only turned me on more.

"Harry's shipping out tomorrow," Courtney said, squeezing the man's arm in hers, full of pride.

"Congratulations," I said to him, though if I'd been in his place I'd have hardly felt that being sent back out to Afghanistan or Iraq or wherever it was he was going was something to be congratulated for. "I know how much you wanted this."

He smiled warmly, trying to conceal a very satisfied grin that would have been just a little less than military-grade cool. Then he said, "Hey, you fancy... coming for a quick drink before dinner?"

I looked at Courtney. She revealed a hint of surprise, but also curiosity and approval for the idea.

And just like that, Harry and I were strolling out to the parking lot like old friends, Courtney walking on his other side. "Afghanistan, is it?" I asked him.

He chuckled. "I can't even tell you that much," he said.

"Black ops," Courtney said, that pride flaring up in her voice again.

"Not supposed to say even that much," Harry said, perhaps feeling a trifle self-conscious that he'd revealed such a thing in pillow-talk. "But I'm serving my country, exactly what I always wanted to do."

It seemed surreal to climb into the back seat of that sleek, black BMW of his. A car I felt like I'd stalked in order to keep track of Harry and his relationship with my wife. The conversation was surprisingly

bland on the way to the bar, considering what was going on between the three of us.

A man.

His wife.

Her lover.

“I hate O’Hare. Just chaos. And my flights are always delayed.”

“Better than Dulles. You ever tried to eat there? Jesus.”

Talking about airports. Well, I suppose it was early in the evening, early for their date. The thing we all really had in common was that we were both fucking her. You didn’t discuss that kind of thing before the alcohol was well and truly flowing. I watched the two of them sitting up there in front, and my interest was in their comfortable body language, their ease of conversation, rather than the topic of their conversation.

“SeaTac, now that’s an airport.”

“Denver’s nice.”

I did notice Harry’s hand subtly reaching over to touch Courtney’s leg once or twice, hinting at things to come. Those little signals gave me a buzz. Made me want to hold out, stay there with them on their date as long as I could before they kicked me out.

Later, at the bar, once the drinks were handed out, tongues got a little looser.

“I like Atlanta. What’s that one called?”

“Hartsfield-Jackson. You only like that one because one of your college lays lived down there.”

Okay, I’d sort of gotten the full story from Courtney about her past sex life, but not quite every detail. There always seemed more to learn, more to enjoy, and these days my wife seemed more open than ever with her past.

“I only slept with him three times.”

“You went all the way to Atlanta to see him at least twice.”

“Well... he had a nice... personality.”

“Cock, you mean.”

Harry looked at me as though teasing me about Courtney’s past might actually irritate me, or even make me jealous. I just lapped it all up. The thought of my wife, all bright-eyed and bushy tailed still in college, flying all the way down to Atlanta simply to grab another night or two in the sack with some well-hung stud—that made me hard, right there in the bar.

But here on his last night in the States before another tour, Harry wasn’t trying to be mean to me. When Courtney excused herself to go to

the restroom, he leaned into me and said, perfectly earnestly, “You know... I always wanted to know... what makes guys like you... you know... tick.”

“Tick?” I grinned, seeing that he was genuinely curious. I suppose that while he’d been my wife’s go-to friend-with-benefit through college, he’d never actually hung out with any of her actual boyfriends before.

“Why d’you do it?” he asked. “Why d’you like it?”

I shrugged. Kind of a huge question to answer. I said, “Because she’s gorgeous.”

His raised eyebrow suggested my explanation had certain holes in it.

I tried some more. “Maybe it’s because... when we started dating, I was so paranoid about losing her. Because she was so much better looking than me. Somehow it morphed into this...”

“You’re afraid of losing her... and that turns into something you’d risk for kicks?” Harry said.

“Maybe... the more I came to trust her, and believe she would never want to leave me, the more my brain turned that original fear into some kind of... turn-on.”

“Weird.”

“I don’t know. I can’t fully explain it. It just turns me on. Thinking about her being with someone else, but then coming back to me, all buzzing and fizzing with energy from just being fucked...” I looked over at the restroom door, saw my wife emerge from it, glancing around the lively place.

“I like the thought of her being naughty,” I said. “I like the thought of her enjoying herself with no limits... and after she’s done it... I have this uncontrollable urge to take her back for myself.”

“I bet,” Harry said.

Courtney was at the bar, now, taking the opportunity to buy another round of drinks. Boy, did she look good. Better than good. Her poise, her sparkle, her confidence ever since we got into this consensual adultery stuff. I glanced at my watch. Ten o’clock—getting late. I thought they were going out to dinner, but it seemed too late for dinner now. Why hadn’t they told me to go home? Why hadn’t they left this bar to find somewhere more intimate for dinner?

Had they forgotten about my presence on their date?

Harry didn’t seem in the least bit annoyed that I hadn’t excused myself from their date yet. He was the definition of chilled. Seeming to enjoy my company.

I said to him, “But you must feel something similar.”

“Similar?”

“All these years... you’ve shared her, too.”

The thought startled him, more than a little. He said, “But she was never mine. I just... you know... banged her when I felt like it.”

“Or when she felt like it,” I corrected him. It didn’t seem to me that Harry had ever had the choice when he got to sleep with Courtney—he had been hers to use when she’d been in the mood.

“But you know... I just took her from some other guy... had some fun...”

I nodded. Up at the bar, Courtney was already receiving some attention from a couple of guys. That dress of hers did not leave a huge amount to the imagination. Waiting to be served, she seemed to be enjoying flirting with them, too. Stroking her hand through her hair, flashing them that beaming smile the whole time—laughing at some joke that was bound to be lame. Giving them the kind of eye contact that said she was available, even if she was stunning to look at, and the person least likely to be single in this whole establishment.

“But you knew she’d just come from her boyfriend... she’d go back to him straight after... you were taking her, but you were sharing her, right?”

He seemed stunned by that revelation.

“It wasn’t that serious,” he insisted. He’d gone pale, even in the limited light, I could see.

“You’re going to take her to bed tonight,” I said to him, what had to be one of the strangest things a husband could say to another man by society’s standards. “But you know as soon as she’s done... later... or in the morning... she’ll come back to my bed.”

He shrugged. “While she’s with me, she’s mine.”

“And you know she’s been sleeping with me all week before she sees you?” Okay, I was being a little cruel by now. Rubbing it in. If I was weird for sharing my wife, he was just as weird for sharing my wife, too. It might just be one-off hot sex with some hot babe in his eyes, but it was one-off hot sex with some hot babe who was getting regular sex from another guy, me.

And now she was twirling a strand of her hair with the tips of her fingers against her chest, perilously close to the dip in between her breasts. Licking her lips as she gazed at one of the men trying to reel her in.

“You see her flirting with that guy?” I asked him. “How does that make you feel?”

He chuckled. “Hey, she’s not mine. She can do what she likes.”

“When you ship out, she’ll start dating some other guy,” I said. “Maybe that guy.” Sure enough, we could both make out the sight of Courtney writing her phone number on the back of the guy’s hand in ballpoint. I felt a little throb between my legs at the thought that she really might take the guy out on a date some time, once Harry was gone hunting bad guys in the desert.

“I suppose so,” he said, sounding distinctly less than comfortable. I felt a little sorry for him by now. He’d always wanted her—wasn’t that why he’d come back to find her? There were other sports injury specialists who would have helped him on the QT.

Now she turned on her heels and wove her way back through the throng toward us. Trying to put a little swagger back into Harry’s demeanor, and perhaps slant my explanation toward his alpha-male type of persona, I said, “You know... at the end of the day, I guess it makes me feel more of a man if there are other guys desperate to date my beautiful wife... but she always comes back to me. I suppose... she kind of always comes back to you, too.”

He nodded. “Something like that.”

And here she was, beaming from ear to ear, a distinct sparkle in her eyes after chatting up another guy at the bar. “Hey, what are you two discussing so deeply?” she giggled, noticing in particular the serious expression on Harry’s face.

“Oh nothing,” I said. “Just the fact that you’ll probably be dating that guy at the bar pretty soon.”

“Oh, Marc?” she grinned. “Never say ‘never’...”

There was no dinner, other than a little tapas at a Spanish bar. Mostly, we drank more. I stayed out with them as more and more drinks were sunk. No hint they wanted me to leave. Harry and I were getting on like a house on fire, somehow during the evening his attitude toward me had softened, and his view of what I was doing with Courtney had genuinely transformed. I don’t think he was genuinely trying to change to be more like me. But in trying to comprehend what I felt for Courtney, he was clearly trying to deal with the fact that he would be losing her.

“What about him? Would you date that guy over there?”

“The guy in the blue shirt? Sure. Dresses well. Drinks bourbon. Nice smile...”

By the time I came back to the table with the second round of drinks in that Spanish place, Harry was already asking Courtney which guys around us she would consider dating, since he was shipping out to a war zone.

“You like Asian guys?”

“Of course. Don’t you?”

“To date. To fuck.”

“It wouldn’t be an issue. If he’s nice, respectful, in good shape...”

“Good in bed?”

“Well you’re never sure about that until it happens...”

It seemed to me that she did mean more to Harry than just an occasional fuck buddy. As I sat there with them, trying to engage in the conversation while at the same time feeling contented just to observe them as they chatted and flirted and prepared to go home and sleep with each other, the sheer closeness of them, the fact that this wasn’t pure and simply about the sex, somehow only made the strangeness of being around them on their date all the more intense.

The risk, after all, of losing Courtney was part of what strengthened my desire for her.

By the time it got to midnight, and the two of them had their hands all over each other, and it seemed only too obvious that it wouldn’t be much longer before they called a taxi to take them away to some suitable bedroom, I was feeling giddy, nervous, and distinctly sober.

When the taxi did finally arrive, I found myself there on the curb wondering why Courtney wasn’t hugging me and telling me goodbye, telling me she loved me, not to stay up too late waiting for her, that she would text me when the deed was done, that she was so grateful for me allowing her to go home with this guy.

But she just hopped in the taxi after him. I just stood there feeling a little snubbed—oh, sure, excited that she had just clambered into a taxi to go sleep with another guy, but still, somehow I’d been forgotten in all the commotion. It felt as though we were parting at the airport with one of us going on a long trip, only she’d skipped off through security without saying goodbye, and without turning at the last minute to wave and blow me a kiss.

Only, the door to the taxi stayed open a fraction too long, and then there was Courtney leaning out of the vehicle just far enough to catch my eye and grin like a saucy little minx, and tell me, “Get in!”

Well, it was nice of them to give me a lift home, presumably on the way back to Harry’s base. I felt a little like a third wheel with the two of

them whispering sweet nothings to each other along the way. Courtney giggling and batting away Harry's wandering hand from her thighs—before ultimately giving in, allowing him to subtly paw at her while I was sitting right next to her on the other side.

Naturally enough, I was hard as a rock. This was foreplay going on, right under my nose. Every moment it went on seemed more and more clear cut to me that these two were not going to finish the night before sleeping together, before properly consummating the date.

And I might not be there to see it happen, but being cooped up in a taxi with them, my senses buzzing with the stimuli from this other man seducing my wife in front of me, it seemed to me that I wouldn't have to do much to imagine what that full consummation would be like.

*

The taxi drew up at our apartment building, and as I climbed out, Courtney followed me. I actually felt disappointed—that the night was over, that their date was over, that my wife was going home with me instead of her lover. Then after paying the driver, Harry climbed out, too.

I don't know, I should have just asked them their plans for the rest of the night. But even if I felt sober, I wasn't, and I wasn't in the right frame of mind for entirely rational thinking. I didn't want to appear somehow weak by querying what was going on. Far cooler just to go with the flow.

Another resident of the building joined us on the way up to our apartment—an old man who lived on some floor above us—and so Harry and Courtney had to keep their hands off each other. Nevertheless, the sly looks they were giving each other all the way up helped to keep up my optimism that they were destined to be together this night.

When we were finally on our own, wandering down the hallway to our front door, the two of them were laughing and stumbling over each other, the drink easing their way no doubt. As Courtney unlocked the door to our apartment, Harry put his big hand on my shoulder.

“You're gonna let her bring dates here?” he asked me.

“Uh... sure,” I said, feeling the butterflies trembling inside my stomach. Though I was certain my wife was about to sleep with this guy,

somehow the way Harry spoke suddenly made it real that after he left the country, Courtney would be free to date other guys entirely.

“I don’t think I’d do that,” he said. “Not my own home.”

I shrugged. “I don’t see the problem.”

Courtney turned to smile at me, loving that I was embracing the idea of her dating other guys once Harry was away. “Thanks, honey,” she said, leaning over to kiss me.

Inside, the front door closing on its heavy spring behind us, I had sudden visions of Courtney coming back here with guys I’d never met... maybe a blond guy... maybe a black guy... maybe a tall guy... maybe a buff gym bunny. Strangers... dates. And I’d be in the spare room, I guessed. Or away camping out at a house I’d been renovating. Wasn’t like I had a shortage of roofs for my head.

Tonight, though, I felt tired, and suddenly dreaded the possibility that Harry would want to stay up all night drinking. As well as we got on now, it was still really late.

I headed for the spare room, thinking perhaps that if I forced the issue, the two of them would simply retire to the master bedroom and enjoy themselves. Sure, I was hoping to overhear them. Wasn’t that what Courtney had brought me here for? Or perhaps why she’d brought him here, rather than going with him to his place.

I heard Harry’s voice behind me, quiet but clear. “Hey.”

Turning, I saw that Courtney had scampered away. The corners of my mouth curved up as I suspected that the great lover might suddenly request some kind of advice from me. How should he please her? How should he deal with the fact that he was about to lose her all over again?

But he beckoned to me, ushered me over, to follow him. Uncomprehending, I followed.

“You want to see this, right?” he said with half a grin.

My heart almost seemed to seize up—but maybe the fact that half my blood supply was suddenly dwelling somewhere between my legs eased the stress on my poor heart and saved me.

Harry calmly offered me the armchair in the corner of the master bedroom, and perched himself on the edge of the mattress.

“I guess I can see why you do it,” he said now, offering me a smile that was genuine and friendly.

“This is still bothering you?” I laughed, trying to make light of things.

He nodded, shrugged. “It’s like going to a movie starring Scarlett Johansson,” he said. “You want to see her getting naked, right? You want

to see her banging some guy.”

Courtney’s voice came from the en-suite, “Why do guys all like her? She’s so overrated.”

Harry replied to her, “She looks damn fine in movies.”

Courtney said, “She has big tits. That it?”

“It’s not just the big tits,” Harry laughed. Then he said to me, referring to my wife, “She’s your favorite movie star, right?”

I nodded. Swallowed.

Harry said, “When I see Scarlett Johansson on screen banging some dude, I don’t think about how embarrassing it is she’s with some other guy and not me. She’s a movie star. I enjoy how damn hot she is.”

I nodded again, said quietly, “It’s something like that.”

Oh, it was a hell of a lot more complicated than that. And with Courtney being wicked with some other guy, I had a very real need to claim her back afterward—that feeling did not apply to a movie star, Scarlett Johansson or otherwise. But if the explanation worked for Harry, I was happy enough.

And now Courtney sauntered out of the bathroom wearing black bra and panties, black thigh-high stockings, garter belt. Damn.

“You still wish Scarlett Johansson was here?” she said cheekily as she paused, standing there between the two of us men.

“Uh-uh,” Harry said diplomatically, whether it was the truth or not.

“No way,” I said, and I was telling God’s own truth. She looked stunning. I could smell a strong waft of that exotic perfume of hers, the one she’d started wearing only recently, which still leant me the notion of adultery.

Courtney turned and perched beside Harry on the edge of the bed. “Good, because I don’t have to be here, you know,” she teased. “I could go right back out there to some nightclub if I wanted to and find some other guy to give me a bed.”

Harry looked at her calmly and laughed. Said, “And risk losing all of this for someone who might have a tiny dick?”

“Okay, that would be the risk,” Courtney was laughing now. Pulling up her legs to sit there cross-legged. Brushing her hair out of her pretty face. Looking so damn good with him.

“And you’ve been telling me for a while how hot it would be for hubby to be here for once,” he said. I felt my hardness throb. Not just for the full confirmation of what was about to happen, but the fact that I was part of the experience for Courtney—she wanted me there to watch. She was such a tease, not telling me what was going on.

“Okay, you got me,” she giggled. “You can fantasize about Scarlett Johansson if you have to.”

She smirked at me, and then leaned in to kiss Harry right there in front of me. God, they had chemistry. If you’d asked me beforehand, I’d have told you I wanted my wife to have chemistry with her lover. But this was intimidating. These guys had history. They were so tender together, so affectionate.

“This okay, honey?” Courtney said breathily as she pulled herself back from it for a moment. God she looked sexy—flushed from the excitement, pupils dilated, chest heaving already.

“Uh-huh,” I said, a frog firmly in my throat.

“You know you can stop us any time you need...”

She was kidding, knowing how turned on I was, knowing how I reacted when I saw them doing this through her phone. But it was something different in the flesh. And the kissing... somehow it was worse than fucking. The affection was more apparent... the raw attraction between them.

Yet as is the way with this peculiar affliction of mine, the sense of risk only made things more intense. The feeling that Courtney was enjoying this only made it that much more powerful to watch.

They closed their eyes as they kissed. Hands traveled slowly and gently to tilt chins and brush through hair, to cradle jaws and caress necks.

My body pulsed with lust and jealousy, my stomach swam with nausea and fear, my erection raged at how beautiful they were together.

Oh, it took an age, and then this other man’s hands were trailing slowly down over my sweet wife’s chest, between her black lace-clad breasts and over her pale stomach, dwelling only briefly on the garter belt that seemed almost like some kind of binding, preventing her escape.

I watched them kiss and his hand skirt around her hip, and over her thigh, before lodging between her legs.

“Oh God...” she sighed as he touched her there. Glancing over at me to check I was still on board. I was. And I knew exactly how wet she was as his fingers sank beneath her panties. It drove me wild.

My Courtney moved her hand back, placing it on the mattress by her hip, out of the way so that I could watch Harry’s fingers stroking her sex as they continued to gently kiss.

She was smiling ear-to-ear as they explored each other’s lips right there in front of me. Giggling from time to time, mid-kiss. All these little touches that didn’t seem part of my bedroom experience with her, the

little details that had been ironed out of our marital sex over the years for the benefit of efficiency and on account of our familiarity. It was, after all, a date rather than a marital liaison. It struck me that she would have missed out on these little touches if we'd stayed purely monogamous the rest of our lives.

I liked that she worked on stripping him out of his clothes, teasing him and his hardness along the way. That he couldn't stop running his hands through her long, silky dark hair. That he took off her panties and breathed her scent like an addict. That they played with each other and laughed with each other and smiled at each other.

Whether or not they were deliberately playing up their foreplay because this was the first time I was physically there watching, it was no matter. It was inspiring. Made me want to up my own game the next time Courtney did me the honor of taking me to her bed.

When she was down to nothing but her stockings, and he was wearing only boxers, I watched him sink down onto the floor in front of her, parting her legs, dropping down to cover her sex with his mouth.

"Oh honey... it feels so good..." she sighed, and I was just dumbstruck.

With envy seeping from my every pore I saw him sucking on her pussy, nibbling gently on her labia, making her squirm under him. I could smell her responding to him now, and it made me shiver, my blood warmed by adrenaline.

It struck me that he wasn't just doing it to show off, to impress me or even Courtney. He wasn't even doing it merely for her pleasure or his own. He was experiencing her one last time—taking his time, never rushing—because after this he would be in the desert and there would be no one for him.

Then my wife was taking him into her mouth, Harry lying on the bed and Courtney kneeling on the floor in front of me.

"I'm gonna miss this..." she said.

Harry actually laughed. "You'll be too busy to miss anything," he said.

I could almost touch her ankles. She went at him from an angle so that I might see, but even now she was laughing and giggling, teasing him and playing with him as she licked his shaft, as she pumped his full length, as she took his balls into her mouth, as she stroked his large manhood all over her soft face.

Enjoying the sheer naughtiness of all this, her contact with another cock right in front of her dear husband.

After that, Courtney stood and turned to me, and I thought perhaps she was about to ask me to leave. As I sat there in the armchair, she loomed over me, her pale skin slightly glistening from perspiration, her face pink from the exertion of sucking another man's big prick. Her make-up was slightly running, but it was a sexy look on Courtney—or at least, for a husband who shared.

"You really do enjoy this, then?" she asked me, as though she needed to know by now.

"Uh-huh."

She leaned over my lap, ducked down to kiss me. I craned forward in the chair to reach her mouth, tasting the salt on her skin, and the strange essence of another man lingering on her lips. I didn't flinch. Feeling some need to prove my passion to her, I kissed her forcefully, showing her how much I loved her, how much I appreciated her.

She closed her eyes, enjoying our kiss. I kept my eyes open and saw Harry lining up behind her. I felt the jarring of her body against me as he entered her.

She moaned in my mouth as we kissed, every time he thrust into her. I held her pretty face in my hands, stroked her clammy, dampening hair as I kissed her, and as another man fucked her from behind. I tasted him on her lips—such a bizarre thing, but it only thrilled me more.

Her hands dipped down to press against the hardness in my pants—before unfastening my belt, unzipping my fly.

"Show me," she said.

It felt very, very strange whipping it out in front of another man—a naked man. But since he was standing there fucking my wife, the strangeness was soon diluted by the strangeness of this whole affair.

She gazed down on it, somehow impressed despite everything. Her hands shifted from my thighs, where they had been propping her up as Harry pounded her from behind, to my shaft. As she held on tight, it wasn't so much that she was actively pumping me, more that she was holding my prick for dear life.

To be honest, even with what I'd seen before, it was a little shocking just how hard he fucked her. Every impact drove the air from her chest, made her whole body shudder, even shook a few beads of sweat from her. But the way she was moaning, begging for more... it was irresistible.

And there was her wedding ring, sparkling as another man fucked her from behind.

But then she was being pulled back, Harry lying on the bed, Courtney moving to straddle him, facing my way. I leaned forward for a better look, and felt a little light-headed as I saw that thing—another man’s cock—squeezing into the familiar sight of my wife’s pussy time and time again, glistening with her juices.

“Oh fuck... Oh God... oh Jesus...” she moaned, and leaned forward as she straddled him, seeking me out. I had to stand to kiss her, and now I caught sight of Harry’s face. He didn’t seem concerned. That was perhaps surprising to me.

“Oh God... his cock is amazing...” she whispered to me, continuing to gyrate her hips over him.

She held onto my shoulders and as he made her come, the sheer bliss on her face, the way her body shook and trembled from the force of it, the power of the forbidden pleasures of another man’s cock driving deep into her—it was the hottest thing I’d ever seen.

“God, I love it when you watch,” she said, pulling herself off him, as though my presence there had given her the orgasm rather than his almighty weapon.

I sat back down in the chair, feeling almost as though it wasn’t my right to intervene here, it was their date: Harry was fucking her, not me.

She turned around, but lifted one foot over my legs and stood over me, facing Harry. I couldn’t see her face—was she teasing him? Taunting him because my hard cock was only inches away from her pussy now?

He stood, again seeming more curious about me being there than threatened or put off. Courtney shifted back a little, up my body, her stockings grazing against my sides as she moved, her delicate behind poised over my face so that I could smell the strong scent of sex from her.

She pushed out her butt, ducking down as Harry held his own shaft for her to take with her hands and her mouth. I was shocked and thrilled as she lowered her sex to my face, her pale flesh framed by black garters, stocking tops, her garter belt.

I lapped at her, tasting the salty, tangy flavor of their sex—her arousal and perhaps his trace evidence, as my wife now worked him back to hardness with her mouth. It felt so wrong, so forbidden, so taboo, to enjoy her like this, her puffy, reddened sex fresh from a fucking. I held apart her creamy buttocks and sucked on her pussy, loving every strange moment.

When he was hard again, she eased forward and Harry was back on the bed where she could straddle him and take his erection back inside

her. I watched again, mesmerized, as she reached behind herself to slip him in, and their juices coated his shaft.

“Here,” she said, breathless, patting the mattress next to her. I was unsure, but willing. I lay down there beside her lover and she turned to take my hardness in her mouth. Two cocks at once. Her wedding ring prominent as she pumped mine, as she sucked on mine.

And she didn’t look like this was the first time she’d ever done this. I wished I’d known her in college. Maybe back then I wouldn’t have meant anything to her, though. Or I might have been a fly-by-night lover instead of a long-term sharing keeper.

After a while, Harry pulled back, possibly needing a breather, though he didn’t get much of one since Courtney simply turned to him and took hold of his cock in her hands, stretching her lips around his girth.

He glanced at me, and there was some kind of signal in his eyes. Your turn, he was saying silently. He looked far from certain about it. He didn’t actively want me to fuck her just then, but he was curious about how it would feel.

I picked myself up off the bed and stepped around behind her as she went to town on his cock, kneeling on the edge of the mattress. Harry wasn’t looking at me, but I got the feeling he was monitoring the situation from the corner of his eye.

Taking things slowly in case he changed his mind, I stroked the head of my hard cock over the soft flesh of her pleasingly round behind, gradually getting closer and closer to her hot pussy.

Holding onto her garter belt, I rubbed my tip between her buttocks, slowly up and down, feeling the heat, the slippery oil over her pussy. He was holding her head as she bobbed up and down on him, controlling her rhythm. I finally eased my way inside her pussy, and heard her low moan muffled by his manhood.

I found my heart rate picking up even further as I slid inside her—she was so wet, so slippery. More so than usual, even the moments when she was particularly turned on. Had he come inside her? God. He’d planted his seed deep inside her.

Oh, she was on birth control. But the realization ignited the biological imperative in my male genome, injecting adrenaline into my bloodstream, making me want her more than ever.

I felt my cock swell further inside her, if that was possible, and the adrenaline pushed me to thrust hard into her, grabbing her hips with firm hands.

“Oh God... honey... Jesus... that’s so good...” she moaned as my cuckolded body strove to reclaim her, to redress any suspicion that she wasn’t mine, that I wasn’t leader of this little pack.

Jesus it felt so good. Her pussy squelching as I piled into her, because it was filled with another man’s come.

I glanced up to catch Harry watching me, watching us. He noticed me catch him, and his eyes darted away. Oh, so hot. I leaned forward to hold Courtney’s hair, keep it out of her face as she sank down on this other man’s cock. And after a while, I was gently pushing and pulling her head, moving her, controlling her movement on his manhood while fucking her adulterous pussy from behind.

I would never have ever predicted such a thing would happen. Me, involved in a threesome. I’m guessing Harry wouldn’t have predicted sharing a woman, either. Not in a million years. But it was fine. The two of us guys moved around each other, gave way to each other, took turns with her, never interfering but always fair with the beautiful woman between us, and as the night wore on we leisurely enjoyed ourselves with her, and she enjoyed herself with us. And if one or other of us came, things might slow a little, but generally kept on going until we were all back up to speed again.

I don’t even know how late it was that we ended up collapsing together on the bed, sweaty, fulfilled, exhausted.

I woke up, eventually, in the late morning to find my wife facing me, but spooned up against Harry, who was in the middle of fucking her right there next to me on the bed.

She smiled and kissed me quietly, her hands wandering down to find my hard cock—checking for my response, though, rather than wanting to pleasure me just then. I feigned sleep, letting him just do as he wanted with her. There was a tangible sense in the air that his time was running out, that he would have to leave very soon. There was an airplane waiting for him to carry him across the ocean.

I could simply bide my time and enjoy that strange frisson, that unlikely buzz that came with my beloved, exquisite wife making love to another man before my very eyes.

I’d get to take her for myself again soon enough. And I had a lifetime of this to look forward to.

Afterword by Max Sebastian

In writing fiction, an author usually takes some kind of balance between planning out the entire project in immense detail and writing page by page with absolutely no idea what will happen next in the story.

The exact balance an author takes is up to them, of course, and it can take time for an author to figure out what suits them best. Plan out a story in a lot of detail, and you can devise some very clever twists and turns, and indulge in some highly sophisticated structure and form. But you might feel robbed of the joy of not knowing what happens next in the story. Write a story page by page with no real plan to follow, and you might find more excitement in finding out what happens next, but your story could easily spiral out of control, your plot winding up in a dead end or some kind of tangle that doesn't make any sense.

I've always wavered a little between too much planning, or too little planning, in my stories. But in the first time I've really written a full book with another author, collaborating with Kenny Wright seemed to bring the best of both worlds. Both of us had a general idea what was going to happen in the story, but when it came to the writing, chapter by chapter we had no idea what the other was going to produce next, or which direction would be taken.

This made it extra absorbing for me—while I had the confidence that the story wasn't going to unravel as we went along, there was still that thrill of discovery as each chapter came together.

And for me, the fact that my writing partner in *Out of His League* was Kenny Wright was just tremendous, because there was a real guarantee he'd come back to me with a new chapter full of gripping suspense, sparkling characters and wonderful writing.

More than anyone else, I'd give Kenny credit for getting me into this sub-genre in the first place. In particular his short stories *Leap* and *Rediscovering Danielle*, followed by his novel *Just Watch Me*, revealed to me a new kind of suspense that I'd not seen before in erotic fiction, inspiring me no end.

I was lucky to connect with Kenny himself after I published *Anarchy of the Heart* a few years back, and since then have benefited tremendously as we bounced ideas off each other, shared views on

developing stories and figured out what worked, and what didn't in this sub-genre.

To collaborate with such a master of the genre on a joint project like this has, therefore, been a particular honor, as well as a real pleasure. All being well, it should lead to more collaboration between us later in the year.

As well as paying tribute to Kenny, I'd just like to add a little note of thanks to our esteemed beta readers Anjali, Dan, Ian, John, Nick and Robert. Their eagle eyes proved invaluable in presenting this story in the best possible light.

And as ever, thanks to you the reader for your support in picking up this particular story, I hope you enjoyed it.

Max Sebastian

London, January 13, 2017

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About the Authors

Max Sebastian is a thirty-something writer, author and occasional journalist who lives in London with his wife and two children. He has been writing erotica for more than 15 years, starting out at the website Literotica.com before joining the indie publishing revolution in late 2011.

You can find Max online at MaxSebastian.net, on Twitter [@MaxSebastian](https://twitter.com/MaxSebastian), on Facebook at facebook.com/writermx, and on GoodReads at goodreads.com/maxsebastian. And, you're always very welcome to contact Max by emailing Max@MaxSebastian.net.

Kenny Wright strives to write romantic erotica, filled with realistic characters who challenge and reaffirm their loving relationships. His themes usually gravitate towards husbands watching as their wives get naughty, and if you believe in the spectrum of “hotwife” and “cuckold” stories, he tends to write on the “hotwife” end of it.

Check out his blog at kennywriter.com. You can also follow him on Twitter at [@kennywriter](https://twitter.com/kennywriter).

Also by Max Sebastian
Available via MaxSebastian.net

Novels

Anarchy of the Heart
Submitting to Her
Madeleine Wakes
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Madeleine Strays
What's Mine is Yours
What's Yours is Mine
A Killer of a One Night Stand
She's a Star
The Game
Heidi, Corrupted
His Week With My Wife

Novellas

My Wife, The Seductress
A Calculated Affair
Her Dirty Little Secret

Short Stories

Wives with Benefits: Volume One
Wives with Benefits: Volume Two

Also by Max Sebastian:

His Week With My Wife

Because cheating doesn't have to end a relationship...

When Tyler discovers that his wife has been sleeping with other men while away on business attending conferences, it has the strangest effect of strengthening his desire for her.

Emily is forced to come clean and admit her infidelity to her husband after one of her new lovers — believing her to be single — invites himself to stay with her for a week, and to turn him down would likely mean she'd have to quit her job.

But to her surprise, Tyler not only allows her to continue seeing other men while away from home, he also says she can entertain her lover at home for the week he's in town — so long as she's happy to be shared.

Web: <http://maxsebastian.net/his-week-with-my-wife/>

Also by Kenny Wright
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Novels

Just Watch Me
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The Girlfriend Experience
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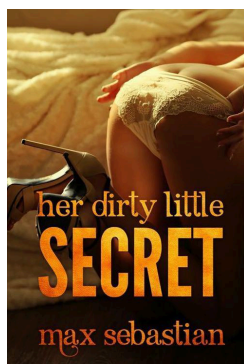
Ethan and Nicole met, dated, got married, a job took Ethan away, and they separated. And that's how it would have ended had circumstances not brought Ethan home a year later.

When he sees his wife again after so long, he realizes just how much he lost. When they fall into a physical, friends-with-benefits arrangement, he realizes that he wants more. And when he begins to suspect that he's not the only man in her life anymore, his reaction shocks him.

As Ethan and Nicole rediscover themselves and the new people that they have become, they must decide whether to rekindle what they once had, or let each other go at last.

Web: <http://www.kennywriter.com/books/separated-with-benefits/>

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